# THE BRAZILIAN EDGE

*What You Bring to Canada, and How to Use It*



RON TAYLOR

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# The Brazilian Edge

*52 Lessons on What You Bring to Canada, and How to Use It*

A self-analysis course in English for Brazilian professionals in Canada, and the teachers who work with them

RON TAYLOR

**The Brazilian Edge**
52 Lessons on What You Bring to Canada, and How to Use It

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**Not legal or immigration advice.** This book is for education and self-reflection. Immigration, work-permit, licensing and trade-certification rules change and vary by province and territory. Before making decisions, check current official sources, and consider speaking with a licensed immigration consultant, a lawyer or the relevant regulator.

**About the stories.** The lesson stories in this book are fictional composites based on patterns the author has observed in teaching. They do not describe any real person. Names, ages, cities and details are invented.

**About the research.** Statistics are taken from the Canadian government sources listed in Appendix E, as published at the time of writing. They describe immigrants in general, not Brazilians specifically, unless the text says otherwise.

Cover design: the stars of the Brazilian flag, and 52 points travelling north.

# A Note to the Reader

This book grew out of something I have watched happen in my lessons many times.

My Brazilian students arrive in Canada with remarkable track records. Most are between thirty and fifty-five. Most are married. Many hold two degrees, and many come from corporate environments that were demanding and competitive in a healthy way. They keep studying long after most people stop. Often one partner studies while the other works, to strengthen the family's immigration plan. They are hungry, and they are humble: some take cleaning or kitchen jobs to learn the language and pay the bills.

And yet, after some months in Canada, many of them forget how much they bring to the table. Impostor syndrome creeps in. Some begin to take their own track record for granted, as if anyone could have done what they did. In my experience, this quiet loss of self-knowledge is one of the main things that slows their English and their progress here. That is why, as a teacher, I have learned to watch the mindset as carefully as the grammar.

This book is my answer. It is built as 52 short lessons, one for each week of a year, and it asks four questions:

1. **What is your biggest challenge, really?**
2. **What have you learned about yourself?**
3. **Why have you been successful?**
4. **Which of your traits will help you master English, and succeed in Canada?**

## Who this book is for

It is written for Brazilian professionals who have immigrated to Canada, or are planning to, and for the teachers, tutors and coaches who work with them. Many of the ideas will also be useful to newcomers from other countries.

The Brazilian immigrants described here reflect a particular group I have taught: adults with university education, corporate experience and a strong desire to keep learning. They are not every Brazilian immigrant, and no nationality guarantees any particular trait. The aim is not to claim that Brazilians are better than Canadians or other newcomers. It is to help each reader recognize, and use, the assets they personally possess.

## What this book is not

It is not a promise that hard work always wins, that Canadian employers always recognize talent, or that confidence can replace English proficiency. Credential rules, financial pressure, discrimination and luck can all influence outcomes. It is not legal or immigration advice: rules change, and you should always check current official sources before making decisions.

## About the stories

The lesson stories in this book are fictional composites, based on patterns I have seen many times. They do not describe any one real student, and names, cities and details have been changed or invented. The statistics come from Canadian government sources listed in Appendix E. They describe immigrants in general, not Brazilians specifically, unless the text says otherwise.

## How to use this book

Each lesson follows the same pattern:

- **The idea:** a short explanation of one topic.
- **From my lessons:** a composite story that shows the idea in real life.
- **Look in the mirror:** questions for self-analysis, with space to write.
- **Say it in English:** useful phrases and a model answer, often for a job interview.
- **Em português:** a Brazilian expression with its natural English equivalent, and sometimes a *falso amigo*, a false friend to watch out for.
- **Teacher's note:** guidance for teachers, which students may also find useful.
- **Key points:** a short summary.

You can read one lesson a week, or work through the book more quickly with a teacher or study group. Write your answers in English whenever you can. By the end, you will have a complete self-analysis, a set of stories you can tell in English and a plan for the year ahead.

Use the questions honestly. Do not invent strengths to feel better. Find evidence. Name the gaps you need to close. Then make a plan.

You are not starting from zero.

*Ron Taylor*

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## Why give more than your 100%?

“Maybe because delivering 100% hasn’t been enough so many times.” *— Sergio*

PART I

# The Profile: Who Arrives

> *Know what you bring before you decide what you lack.*

# 1. You Are Not Starting From Zero

> *Being new to a country is not the same as being new to life.*

Picture a Brazilian professional arriving in Canada in their late thirties or early forties. They have two degrees, fifteen years of work experience, a spouse, children and a long history of meeting demanding expectations. They planned the move for years. They handled the paperwork, organized the finances, said goodbye to the people they love and started again in a language that is not their own.

Then ordinary life starts testing them. A conversation at work moves too quickly. A joke passes by before they understand it. A manager asks a question, and the answer forms in Portuguese before it can be built in English. A qualification does not translate neatly into the local job market. An interview ends without a clear explanation.

The person who once felt capable now feels slow, awkward or invisible. And slowly, without noticing, they begin to measure their whole self by the one part of themselves that is struggling most.

That is the first mistake this book challenges.

## What "starting from zero" really means

Many of my students use the same phrase in their first weeks in Canada: *"I am starting from zero."* I understand why. Their job title is gone. Their professional network is far away. Their English, which worked well enough in Brazil, suddenly feels small.

But "zero" is not accurate, and accuracy matters. You may be new to Canada. You may be a beginner in some parts of English. You may need to learn new workplace expectations, obtain local credentials or rebuild a professional network. None of that means you are new to life. You have a history, and that history contains information about what you know, how you learn, what you value and how you respond to difficulty.

A more accurate way of looking at it is this: *"I am investing in my success."* You are not starting over. You are investing everything you have experienced into your Canadian Dream.

## Capability and visibility

It helps to separate two questions that immigration tends to blur together:

1. **Capability:** *What can I actually do?*
2. **Visibility:** *What can other people see, understand and trust about what I can do?*

In Brazil, the two questions usually had the same answer. Your work was visible because people had watched you do it. Your university was one they recognized. Your references were people they could call. Over the years, your reputation did some of the explaining for you.

In Canada, the questions separate. Your capability arrived with you on the plane. Your visibility did not. A hiring manager in Vancouver may never have heard of your university, may not know what your former job title means and has no shared colleague who can vouch for you. None of that changes what you can do. All of it changes what you must explain.

This distinction runs through the whole book. When something is not working, ask: *Is this a capability problem or a visibility problem?* If it is capability, you need to learn something: a regulation, a software, a

professional standard, a level of English. If it is visibility, you need to show something: evidence, a clear story, a local reference.

## The evidence

This is not just encouragement; national data supports it. Statistics Canada analyzed survey data from September 2024 and September 2025 and found that **32.6%** of recent immigrants aged 25 to 54 with postsecondary education considered themselves overqualified for their jobs, compared with **19.1%** of Canadian-born workers with similar education. These figures describe recent immigrants in general, not Brazilians specifically, and they are based on people's own assessments. [1]

What the numbers tell you is simple: an entry-level job in Canada is not a reliable measurement of your real ability. Many capable people are working below their level while they adapt. You may be one of them. The job you have today describes your situation, not your potential.

> **From my lessons: the first lesson**
>
> *This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*
>
> In our first lesson, Fernanda introduced herself like this: "I'm Fernanda. I'm from Curitiba. I don't work. My English is very bad."
>
> Every part of the introduction was a subtraction. So I asked her to try again, with one rule: she could only say things that were true *and* that she had done.
>
> It took her a few minutes. The second version was: "I'm Fernanda. I'm from Curitiba. I was a human resources manager for nine years. I have a degree in psychology and an MBA. I moved to Canada with my

> husband and two children last year, and now I'm improving my English so I can work in HR here."
>
> Her English was exactly the same in both versions. The person in the second introduction was someone you would want to meet.

## Three principles

This book follows three principles. You will meet them again and again.

1. **Know yourself.** Understand your story, your values, your strengths, your limits and your ambitions.
2. **Recognize your edge.** Identify the education, experience, habits and perspectives you bring to Canadian life.
3. **Learn to express it.** Develop the English, cultural knowledge and relationships that help other people recognize what you can do.

The Brazilian Edge is not a claim that every Brazilian has the same advantages, or that Brazilians are better than anyone else. It is an invitation to investigate the advantages *you* bring and to take responsibility for developing them.

## Before you begin

The Note to the Reader explains how each lesson works. One request before you start: do not skip the **Look in the mirror** questions. They are the most important part of the book. Write your answers in full sentences, in English if you can. Keep them. You will use them later, in interviews, in conversations and in the moments when you forget what you bring.

## Look in the mirror

1. How have you described yourself since arriving in Canada? Write down the exact words.
2. Which of those words are subtractions ("I don't...", "I can't...", "I'm not...")?
3. Rewrite your introduction using only things that are true and that you have done.
4. What is one capability you have that is currently invisible to the people around you?
5. What would make it visible?

## Say it in English

**Introducing yourself as a whole person, not a subtraction**

- *"I'm a [profession] with [number] years of experience in..."*
- *"Before moving to Canada, I worked as..."*
- *"I moved here with my family in [year], and right now I'm..."*
- *"I'm currently improving my English so that I can..."*

- *"My background is in..., and I'm interested in..."*
- Instead of *"I don't work"* → *"I'm between roles while I settle in."*
- Instead of *"My English is very bad"* → *"My English is improving. Please let me know if I need to explain something again."*

**Model answer.** *"So, tell me a little about yourself."*

> *"Sure. I'm from Curitiba, in the south of Brazil. I worked in human resources for nine years, mostly in recruitment and training. I moved to Canada with my husband and our two children last year. Right now I'm focusing on my English and learning how HR works here, because I'd like to continue in the same field."*

**Em português.** *Começar do zero* (literally, "to start from zero"). In English: *to start from scratch*. In this book, the message is the opposite: you are *not* starting from scratch.

**Teacher's note**

Collect your students' first introductions in writing. Many will be lists of what they lack. Return to them in Lesson 9 and again at the end of the course. Seeing the change on paper is one of the most motivating things an adult learner can experience.

**Key points**

- You are not starting from zero. You are starting from a different place, with everything you have learned.
- Capability and visibility are different problems, and they need different solutions.

- National data shows that many recent immigrants work below their qualifications. Your current job does not measure your potential.
- Know yourself, recognize your edge, learn to express it.

# 2. Two Degrees and Still Studying: The Lifelong Learner

> *The habit of learning is more valuable than anything you have already learned.*

When I ask my Brazilian students about their education, the answers are often impressive. A degree in engineering, then an MBA. A law degree and a specialization in tax. Accounting, then a postgraduate certificate in finance, then courses in data analysis "because the market was changing." Many of them did their second degree at night, after a full day of work, sometimes with small children at home.

And many of them are still studying. In Canada, they enroll in English courses, college programs, online certificates and professional preparation classes. When I ask why, the answer is usually some version of: *"I have always studied. It's what I do."*

That sentence describes one of the most important parts of your edge.

## What lifelong learning really is

Lifelong learning is not the same as collecting diplomas. A diploma is a result. Lifelong learning is a habit: the regular, deliberate act of putting yourself in the position of a beginner, again and again, because you know that standing still is a risk.

People who have this habit share some characteristics:

- **They are comfortable not knowing.** They have been beginners many times, and they know the feeling passes.

- **They know how to organize study.** They can plan a semester, prepare for an exam and fit learning around work and family.
- **They expect learning to take time.** They do not assume that a skill will arrive in a week.
- **They connect learning to purpose.** They studied because they wanted something: a promotion, a career change, a better life.

Employers value this habit, and they say so. In the World Economic Forum's *Future of Jobs Report 2025*, employers around the world listed **curiosity and lifelong learning** among the ten core skills they need in their workforce, and among the skills growing in importance toward 2030. [8] An article in *Harvard Business Review* made the same point more sharply, quoting the business strategist Arie de Geus: *"The ability to learn faster than your competitors may be the only sustainable competitive advantage."* [9] What is true for companies is true for people. In a country where you must learn a new language, a new job market and a new culture at once, your habit of learning is not a hobby. It is your competitive advantage.

Each of these characteristics will help you in Canada, especially with English. A person who has already learned difficult subjects as an adult knows something that many language learners do not: progress is slow, uneven and real.

## Why this matters for English

Many adult immigrants feel frustrated by their English because they compare it with their professional knowledge. "I can explain a balance sheet in Portuguese in two minutes," one student told me, "but in English I sound like a child."

But think about how you learned to explain a balance sheet. You did not learn it in a week. You learned the vocabulary, practised it, made mistakes in front of colleagues, received corrections and gradually became fluent in the

language of your profession. You have already done this once. English is the same process with a different set of words.

The habit that earned you two degrees is exactly the habit you need now: regular study, a clear goal, patience with the plateau and the discipline to continue when it is boring.

## A warning: learning as a hiding place

There is one risk with this strength, and I see it often. Some students keep studying because studying feels safe. A course has a schedule, a teacher and a certificate at the end. A job search, a networking conversation or a difficult phone call in English has none of those things.

So they take another course. And another. Each one is useful, but together they become a way of postponing the uncomfortable step: using what they already know in the real world.

Ask yourself honestly: *Is this course moving me toward my goal, or is it helping me avoid the next difficult step?* Lifelong learning is a strength when it serves a purpose. It becomes a trap when it replaces action.

> **From my lessons: the student with nine certificates**
>
> *This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*
>
> Paulo, 41, was a systems analyst from Campinas. In his first two years in Toronto, he completed nine online certificates: project management, two cloud platforms, data analysis, agile methods and several others. His notebook was full of excellent notes.
>
> When I asked how many job interviews he had attended, he said, "None yet. I want to be ready first."

We made a list of his certificates and his fifteen years of experience on one side of the page, and the requirements of three real job postings on the other. He already met most of the requirements for two of them. What he did not have was practice telling his story in English and a single conversation with someone who worked in his field in Canada.

He stopped enrolling in new courses for three months. Instead, he practised interview answers twice a week and contacted two former colleagues who had moved to Canada before him. His learning habit did not disappear. It simply changed direction, from collecting knowledge to using it.

## Look in the mirror

1. List every degree, diploma, certificate or significant course you have completed as an adult. Next to each one, write *why* you took it.
2. Which of them did you complete under difficult conditions (while working, parenting or studying in another language)?
3. What did you learn about *how you learn* during those years?
4. Which of your current courses or study plans is clearly connected to a goal in Canada?
5. Is there any study you are doing to avoid something more uncomfortable? Be honest.

## Say it in English

**Talking about your education and your learning habit**

- *"I have a degree in... and a postgraduate qualification in..."*
- *"I completed my MBA part time while working full time."*
- *"I've always invested in my own development."*
- *"Since arriving in Canada, I've completed... to update my knowledge of..."*
- *"I'm a quick learner. For example, when my company introduced..., I..."*
- *"I'm currently studying... because it's required for..."*

**Model answer.** *"Why should we hire someone without Canadian experience?"*

> *"That's a fair question. One thing I can offer is that I learn quickly and I've done it many times. I completed my MBA at night while working full time, and when my company changed its software, I was one of the people who trained the rest of the team. Since arriving in Canada, I've completed two certifications to update my knowledge. I expect to learn the Canadian side of this job the same way: quickly and systematically."*

**Em português.** *Aprender nunca é demais* (literally, "learning is never too much"). In English: *Every day is a school day*.

**Teacher's note**

Ask students about *how* they studied for their degrees, not only *what* they studied. Their answers reveal study strategies (spaced review, study groups, practice exams) that can be transferred directly to English. Help them see the connection explicitly; most will not see it on their own.

**Key points**

- Employers rank curiosity and lifelong learning among the core skills they need. Your learning habit is a competitive advantage.
- Lifelong learning is a habit, not a collection of diplomas, and it is one of the strongest parts of your edge.
- You have already learned a professional language once. English is the same process with different words.
- Learning is a strength when it serves a purpose and a trap when it replaces action.
- Ask of every course: is this moving me toward my goal, or helping me avoid the next step?

# 3. Shaped by Healthy Competition: What the Corporate World Taught You

> *You learned to perform under pressure long before you learned English.*

Many of my Brazilian students come from large, demanding organizations: multinational companies, banks, consulting firms, industrial groups, technology companies. They describe workplaces with clear targets, regular evaluations, ambitious colleagues and managers who expected results. "It was competitive," they say, "but in a good way. Everyone was trying to improve."

This experience shaped them more than they realize. Years in a competitive environment build specific habits, and those habits do not disappear at the airport.

## What healthy competition builds

Healthy competition is different from a toxic workplace. In a toxic workplace, people succeed by making others fail. In a healthy competitive environment, people succeed by becoming better, and the presence of strong colleagues pushes everyone to raise their level.

If you worked in that kind of environment, you probably developed some of these habits:

- **Accountability for results.** You were measured, and you learned to take responsibility for numbers, deadlines and outcomes.
- **Preparation.** You learned that the meeting goes better when you arrive with data, a plan and an answer to the obvious objection.

- **Resilience to feedback.** You received performance reviews, criticism and corrections, and you learned to use them rather than collapse under them.
- **Speed.** You learned to make decisions with incomplete information and to deliver on time.
- **Professional standards.** You know what good work looks like, and you notice when something is not good enough.

These habits are valuable in Canadian workplaces. Employers here also want people who prepare, take responsibility and keep improving. The habits translate even when the job title does not.

## When competition turns against you

The same competitive instinct that helped you in Brazil can hurt you in your first years in Canada, if you point it in the wrong direction.

In a new country, there will always be someone ahead of you: a colleague whose English is more fluent, a friend who found a professional job faster, a couple who arrived at the same time and already bought a house. If your competitive instinct turns every comparison into a verdict on your own worth, it will slowly destroy your confidence.

The problem is not competition. The problem is competing in the wrong race. Your colleague grew up watching American television. Your friend works in a field with a labour shortage. The other couple had savings you did not have. Their circumstances are not yours, and their speed is not a measurement of your ability.

## Point the instinct at yourself

The healthiest use of your competitive instinct in Canada is to compete with yourself. Not with your colleagues, and not with the person you were in Brazil, but with the person you were last month.

- Did you understand more of the meeting than you did a month ago?
- Did you speak first, at least once, this week?
- Is your interview answer clearer than the first version?
- Did you make a phone call you would have avoided before?

These are real victories, and a competitive person needs victories. Track them. Write them down. They are evidence that your effort is working, and they will keep your motivation alive during the long middle period of adaptation, when progress is real but slow.

> **From my lessons: the sales manager and the leaderboard**
>
> *This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*
>
> Letícia had been the top regional sales manager at a pharmaceutical company in São Paulo. Her team appeared at the top of a national ranking for three years in a row. In Calgary, in her first Canadian job, she quickly became quiet and discouraged in team meetings. "Everyone speaks better than me," she told me in our first lesson.
>
> I asked her how she had motivated her sales team in Brazil. Her face changed. "Weekly targets. Small goals. We celebrated every week, not only at the end of the year."
>
> So we built her a leaderboard with only one name on it: hers. Each week she set three small targets: one phone call in English, one new

expression used in conversation, one question asked in a team meeting. Each Friday she recorded the result.

Within six weeks, she was speaking twice as often in team meetings. She had not become fluent. She had simply pointed her competitive instinct back at the only competitor who mattered.

## Look in the mirror

1. Describe the most competitive environment you have worked in. What did it demand from you?
2. Which three habits did that environment build in you?
3. Who do you compare yourself with in Canada? Are their circumstances really the same as yours?
4. In what ways is your English better today than three months ago? Be specific.
5. What would a weekly "leaderboard" with only your own name on it measure?

## Say it in English

**Describing a competitive work background positively**

- *"I come from a results-driven environment."*
- *"We had clear targets, and I'm used to being measured on outcomes."*
- *"I'm comfortable with feedback; it's how I improve."*
- *"I like working with strong colleagues because they push me to raise my level."*
- *"I'm competitive, but mostly with myself."*
- *"I always prepare. I'd rather be over-prepared than surprised."*

**Model answer.** *"How do you handle pressure?"*

> *"I'm used to it. In my previous role, my team had monthly sales targets, and our results were shared nationally every week. What helped me was preparation: I broke big targets into weekly goals and reviewed progress every Friday. I still work that way. Even with my English, I set small weekly goals and check whether I've met them."*

**Em português.** *Vestir a camisa* (literally, "to wear the shirt"). In English: *to be fully committed to the company; to give it your all*.

**Teacher's note**

Watch for students who withdraw after comparing themselves with colleagues or other learners whose English seems stronger. Do not tell them to stop comparing; competitive people cannot simply switch the instinct off. Redirect it instead: help them define personal weekly measures and make progress visible. A redirected instinct is far more powerful than a suppressed one.

**Key points**

- A healthy competitive workplace built habits that transfer: accountability, preparation, resilience to feedback and professional standards.
- The same instinct becomes harmful when it turns every comparison into a verdict on your worth.
- Compete with last month's version of yourself, not with people whose circumstances are different.
- Make weekly progress visible. Competitive people need victories, so record them.

# 4. Married, With a Plan: Immigration as a Shared Project

> *Two people with one plan can carry more than two people with two plans.*

Most of the students who inspired this book did not immigrate alone. They came as couples, often with children, after months or years of planning together. They researched immigration programs at the kitchen table, studied for language tests in the evenings and made a decision that affected every person in the family.

This is an important part of the edge, and it is often overlooked. A married couple with a shared plan has resources that a single person does not: two incomes (eventually), two sets of skills, two networks, two people to share the work of a household, and someone to talk to at the end of a difficult day.

But those advantages are not automatic. A shared project only works if it is *actually* shared.

## The strengths of a couple

When a couple immigrates together, they bring several kinds of strength:

- **Complementary skills.** One partner may be stronger in English, the other in finances. One may be better with paperwork, the other with people. Together, they cover more ground.
- **Flexibility.** One partner can work while the other studies, or one can take a temporary job while the other searches for a professional role.
- **Emotional support.** Immigration is lonely. Having a partner who understands exactly what you are going through is a powerful protection.

- **Shared motivation.** When one partner is discouraged, the other can remember why you came.

Many couples I have taught were already experienced at teamwork before they arrived. They had managed careers, children, finances and extended families together. Immigration is a bigger project, but it uses the same skills.

## The risks of a couple

Immigration also puts pressure on relationships in ways people do not expect.

The partner whose English is stronger may become responsible for every phone call, every appointment and every form. The partner who works long hours in a temporary job may feel that their sacrifice is invisible. The partner who is studying may feel guilty for not earning money. Both may be exhausted, and each may privately feel that they are carrying more than the other.

These feelings are normal. They become dangerous only when they are not discussed. Silence turns tiredness into resentment.

## Treat it like a project, because it is one

My corporate students already know how to manage a project. They know that a project needs a goal, roles, a timeline, regular meetings and honest reviews. Immigration is the biggest project most families will ever run, and it deserves the same discipline.

Some practical habits that work:

1. **A shared goal, written down.** Not "a better life," but specific outcomes: a professional job in your field within two years, permanent residence, a home, a certain level of English.
2. **Clear roles, reviewed regularly.** Who is studying now? Who is earning? Who handles which tasks at home? When will the roles change?

3. **A weekly planning conversation.** Fifteen or twenty minutes, at the same time each week, to review money, deadlines, children, English practice and one career step for each partner.
4. **Recognition.** Say out loud what the other person did this week. It costs nothing and prevents a great deal of quiet resentment.

**From my lessons: the Sunday meeting**

*This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*

Carla and André arrived in Ottawa with two children, aged six and nine. André found a job in a restaurant kitchen within a month. Carla, whose English was stronger, began a college program. Six months later, they started lessons with me together, and both arrived tired and tense. André felt that nobody noticed his long shifts. Carla felt guilty for studying while he worked.

I asked them how they had made decisions in Brazil. Carla laughed. "We had a spreadsheet for everything."

So they built one for Canada. Every Sunday evening, after the children were asleep, they spent twenty minutes reviewing the week: money, school deadlines, André's English practice, one step for Carla's future job search. Then each of them said one thing they had noticed the other person do.

"It felt strange at first," André said later. "Like a meeting at work. But it was the first time in months that I felt we were on the same team again."

## Look in the mirror

(If you immigrated alone, answer these questions about the people who support you, in Canada or in Brazil.)

1. What strengths does each of you bring to your immigration project?
2. Write your shared goal for the next two years in specific terms.
3. Who is currently carrying which responsibilities? Is that division still fair and realistic?
4. When did you last talk openly about how each of you is feeling?
5. What did your partner do this week that deserves to be recognized?

## Say it in English

**Talking about your family and your plan**

- *"My wife and I moved here together in [year]."*
- *"We decided that one of us would study first while the other worked."*
- *"It's been a team effort."*
- *"My husband is working in... at the moment while I complete..."*

- *"We planned the move for about two years before we came."*
- *"Our goal is to..., and we're taking it one step at a time."*

**Model answer.** *A colleague asks: "What brought you to Canada?"*

> *"My husband and I wanted more stability and better opportunities for our kids. We planned it for about two years: we studied English, saved money and researched different cities. Right now I'm finishing a college program, and he's working while we settle in. It's been hard work, but we're doing it together."*

**Em português.** *Um bom começo é meio caminho andado* (literally, "a good start is half the road walked"). In English: *Well begun is half done*.

**Teacher's note**

When a student seems tired or distracted in a lesson, the cause is often outside the lesson. You are not a family counsellor, and you should not act like one. But you can make room for the language of shared planning and recognition in your lessons. Role-plays about dividing responsibilities or thanking a partner are useful English, and sometimes they start a conversation that a couple needed to have.

**Key points**

- A couple with a shared plan has real advantages: complementary skills, flexibility, support and shared motivation.
- Immigration also puts pressure on relationships, especially when sacrifices feel invisible.
- Treat your immigration as a project: a written goal, clear roles, a weekly review and regular recognition.

- Silence turns tiredness into resentment. Talking turns it back into teamwork.

# 5. One Studies, One Works: The Couple Strategy

> *A good strategy is not about working harder. It is about deciding who does what, and when.*

There is a pattern I have seen many times among my Brazilian students. A couple arrives in Canada. One partner enrolls in a college or university program. The other takes a job, often far below their professional level, to pay the bills. They live carefully, sleep less than they would like and wait for the program to end.

Many of them do this for a specific reason: to strengthen their path to permanent residence. Others do it because a Canadian credential or Canadian work experience will open doors that a Brazilian qualification alone will not. Either way, it is a strategy, and a demanding one.

## Why couples choose this strategy

Canada's immigration system can reward a spouse's education, language results and Canadian experience, and a credential completed in Canada can count too. But the details (which programs qualify, how much they are worth, and whether the working partner is allowed to work while the other studies) change often, sometimes from one year to the next. That is why this book deliberately does not give immigration rules. **Before you build a plan around them, check the current rules on the official Immigration, Refugees and Citizenship Canada website, and consider speaking with a licensed immigration consultant or lawyer.** [6] This book is not immigration advice.

Immigration rules are only one reason. A Canadian credential can also give you local vocabulary, references, an alumni network and an internship. Canadian work experience, even in a different field, gives you local references and daily English practice. A well-chosen program and a well-chosen job can each do several jobs at once.

## What the strategy demands

The "one studies, one works" strategy is powerful, but it has costs that are easy to underestimate:

- **Money.** The family depends on one income, often a low one, and sometimes on tuition fees as well. In most Canadian cities, one entry-level wage is not enough to support a family, so most couples who choose this strategy also rely on savings they brought from Brazil. Work out the real monthly budget, including rent, before you arrive, and decide how many months your savings must cover.
- **Time.** The working partner often has long or irregular shifts. The studying partner has classes, assignments and exams. Time together disappears.
- **Identity.** The working partner may be doing a job that has nothing to do with their profession. The studying partner may feel like a student again at forty.
- **Imbalance.** One partner's career is moving forward. The other's is paused, and that can feel unfair even when it was agreed.

These costs do not mean the strategy is wrong. They mean it needs to be managed, like any important project.

## Make the strategy explicit

The couples who manage this well usually do three things.

**They agree on the reason.** Not just "it will help," but exactly how: points, a credential, a licence, references, a specific job. When the reason is clear, the sacrifice has meaning.

**They agree on the timeline.** Eighteen months, two years, three years. An end date makes a hard period bearable. Without one, it can feel permanent.

**They agree on what happens next.** When the program ends, does the working partner get their turn to study or search for a professional job? A strategy that only ever advances one partner will eventually create resentment.

**From my lessons: the turn**

*This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*

Rodrigo and Tatiana were both engineers in Brazil. In Edmonton, Tatiana enrolled in a two-year college program in engineering technology while Rodrigo, who had his own work permit, worked in a warehouse, then as a delivery driver. The plan was sensible. But by the second year, Rodrigo had stopped talking about engineering altogether. "Maybe that part of my life is finished," he told me.

In one of our lessons, we used the couple's situation for a writing task: describe your family's plan for the next two years. Rodrigo wrote about Tatiana's graduation, the job she hoped to find and the apartment they wanted. He did not mention himself once.

Tatiana read it that evening. At our next lesson, they came with a new plan: when she finished, he would start preparing for his own credential assessment, and she would take on more of the household work. "We forgot," she said, "that this was supposed to be both of our plans."

## Look in the mirror

1. If you and your partner divided roles (study and work, or something else), what was the exact reason?
2. Is there an agreed end date for the current arrangement? Write it down.
3. What happens next for each of you when that date arrives?
4. What is the strategy costing each of you? Have you said this to each other?
5. Have you checked the current official rules for the immigration or credential benefits you are counting on?

## Say it in English

**Explaining a career pause or a temporary role**

- *"We made a strategic decision as a family."*
- *"My wife is completing a program at [college], so I'm working in... for now."*
- *"It's a temporary arrangement while we..."*

- *"Once she finishes, I plan to..."*
- *"This job gives me Canadian experience and daily English practice."*
- *"It's not my field, but it's part of a longer plan."*

**Model answer.** *An interviewer asks: "Why have you been working as a delivery driver for two years?"*

> *"It was a family decision. My wife and I are both engineers, and we decided that she would complete a Canadian program first while I supported us financially. Now she's working in her field, and it's my turn. I've kept my technical knowledge up to date with online courses, and I'm ready to return to engineering."*

**Em português.** *A união faz a força* (literally, "union makes strength"). In English: *United we stand*.

**Teacher's note**

The working partner in a "one studies, one works" family is often the student who needs the most encouragement and gets the least. Their English practice happens at work, in fragments, while they are tired. Ask about their professional background regularly, so that it stays alive in your lessons even while it is paused at work.

**Key points**

- "One studies, one works" is a real strategy, often chosen to strengthen an immigration application or open professional doors.
- Official points rules exist but change, so always check the current Immigration, Refugees and Citizenship Canada (IRCC) criteria and get qualified advice.

- The strategy costs money, time, identity and balance. Manage those costs openly.
- Agree on the reason, the end date and what happens next for *both* partners.

# 6. Hungry: Ambition Without Apology

> *Ambition is not arrogance. It is a decision to want something and to work for it.*

When I describe my Brazilian students to colleagues, one word comes up again and again: *hungry*. Not hungry for food, but hungry to improve, to build something and to prove that leaving everything behind was worth it.

You can see it in small things. They arrive early. They ask for extra homework. They ask about the difference between two expressions that most learners would never notice. They want to know not only the correct answer but the reason.

I want to be careful here. Hunger is not a Brazilian trait. People from every country can be ambitious, and many Canadians work extremely hard. What I am describing is what I have observed in the particular group of adults I teach: people who gave up stable careers to start again and who carry a strong determination to make the decision worthwhile.

## Where the hunger comes from

For many of my students, hunger comes from a combination of things:

- **The size of the sacrifice.** They left careers, families, homes and a language they mastered. When you have given up that much, you want the result to be worth it.
- **A competitive background.** As we saw in Lesson 3, many of them come from environments where improvement was expected.

- **Responsibility for others.** Children, partners and sometimes parents in Brazil depend on their success.
- **Memory of instability.** Many grew up during periods of economic uncertainty and learned early that security is something you build, not something you are given.

Brazilians have a word for this quality: *garra*. Literally it means *claw*, but in daily use it means grit, fight and the determination to keep going when things are hard. When a Brazilian says someone *tem garra*, it is high praise. No single English word captures it fully; *grit* and *drive* come closest.

Whatever its source, this hunger is a powerful engine. It makes you study when you are tired, apply when you are discouraged and try again after a failed interview.

## Why some people hide their ambition

In Canada, some newcomers start to hide their ambition. They notice that Canadian workplace culture can be modest in style. People often understate their achievements, use soft language and avoid sounding as though they are pushing too hard. Newcomers sometimes conclude that ambition itself is unwelcome.

That is a misunderstanding. Canadian employers value ambition, initiative and a desire to grow. What varies is the *style* in which ambition is expressed. Saying "I want to become a manager within two years, and I'm working on these skills to get there" is usually received very well. Saying "I am better than the other candidates" usually is not.

The goal is not to hide your hunger. It is to express it in a way that your audience hears as energy and commitment rather than pressure.

## When hunger becomes harmful

Hunger has a shadow side. It can turn into impatience with yourself, with your progress and with a system that moves slower than you would like. It can lead you to accept every extra shift, every course and every volunteer opportunity until there is no time left to rest. And it can make every setback feel like a catastrophe, because the stakes feel so high.

Healthy hunger has a direction and a limit. It is aimed at specific goals, and it leaves room for sleep, family and recovery. We will return to this in Lesson 24 and Lesson 51, because a strategy that depends on permanent exhaustion is not a strong strategy.

**From my lessons: the hand that went up first**

*This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*

Thiago, 36, had been a marketing coordinator in Recife. He was living in Vancouver, and in our lessons he started answering before I had finished every question. He wanted to answer, then wanted to know why his answer was not perfect, then wanted three more examples. In team meetings at his part-time job he did the same, and some colleagues found him exhausting. He found himself exhausting too.

At the end of one lesson, he said, “In Brazil, people liked that I was intense. Here I feel like I’m too much.”

We talked about style rather than substance. His ambition was an asset; the way he expressed it in group settings sometimes left no space for others. We practised phrases that kept his energy but invited others in: “I have an idea, but I’d like to hear what others think first.” “Can I add one thing?”

A few months later, he told me that his supervisor at his part-time job had described him in a review as “highly motivated and a great team player.” “Same person,” he said. “Better packaging.”

## Look in the mirror

1. What are you hungry for in Canada? Write three specific things.
2. Where does your hunger come from? What or who is driving you?
3. Have you started hiding your ambition since arriving? In what situations?
4. Is your hunger pointed at specific goals, or is it spread across everything?
5. What limit do you need to protect, such as sleep, family time or health, so that your hunger stays sustainable?

## Say it in English

**Expressing ambition in a way Canadians hear as positive**

- *"I'm very motivated to grow in this field."*
- *"My goal is to..., and I'm working on... to get there."*
- *"I'm someone who likes to take initiative."*
- *"I'd welcome the chance to take on more responsibility."*
- *"I have an idea, but I'd like to hear other opinions first."*
- *"I'm ambitious, but I also believe in doing things step by step."*

**Model answer.** *"Where do you see yourself in five years?"*

> *"I'd like to be leading a small marketing team. I did that in Brazil, and I enjoyed developing people. I know I need to learn how the Canadian market works first, so in the next year or two my focus is on learning, delivering good results and building relationships. After that, I'd like to take on more responsibility."*

**Em português.** *Correr atrás* (literally, "to run after"). In English: *to go after it; to hustle*.

**Teacher's note**

Highly motivated adults often over-participate and then feel embarrassed when they sense it. Do not discourage the energy. Give it a structure: role-play meetings in which the student takes a defined role (leader, timekeeper, summarizer), and teach the language of turn-taking explicitly. The student keeps the drive and gains a skill they will need in Canadian meetings.

**Key points**

- Hunger, meaning the drive to improve and to make the sacrifice worthwhile, is a powerful part of your edge.
- It is not a national trait; it is a pattern built by circumstances, sacrifice and background.
- Canadian employers value ambition. Adapt the *style* of expression, not the ambition itself.
- Healthy hunger has a direction and a limit.

# 7. Humble Enough to Start Again

> *It takes a certain kind of strength to become a beginner on purpose.*

A manager takes a job in a restaurant kitchen. An accountant cleans offices at night. A lawyer works in a warehouse. A university professor delivers packages. I have met all of these people among my students, and I have learned to recognize something in them that is easy to miss: genuine humility combined with a very clear sense of purpose.

They are not taking these jobs because they believe that is all they can do. They are taking them because the jobs serve a purpose right now: paying the bills, practising English every day, learning how Canadian workplaces operate, getting a local reference. They are willing to start at the bottom because they understand that the bottom is not where they will stay.

That willingness is part of the edge.

## What humility is, and what it is not

Humility is often misunderstood. It is not thinking less of yourself. It is not pretending your experience does not exist. And it is certainly not accepting anything that happens to you.

Humility is the ability to see your situation accurately and act on it without letting pride get in the way. A humble person can say: *"In this new context, I don't yet know how things work. I'm willing to learn, even if it means doing work I haven't done in years."*

This takes strength. Many people with impressive careers cannot do it. They wait months or years for a job "at their level," running out of money and

confidence while they wait. Others refuse to take a course because it feels like going backward. The humble person moves.

## What humility gives you

When you are willing to start again, you gain things that a proud person misses:

- **Income and stability** while you build your longer-term plan.
- **Daily English practice** in a real environment, with real accents and real speed.
- **Canadian references,** which many employers value highly.
- **Cultural knowledge** about how Canadian workplaces communicate, schedule, give feedback and solve problems.
- **Resilience,** because you prove to yourself that you can adapt to almost anything.

Statistics Canada's research shows that, among recent working-age immigrants who had difficulties finding work, 42.2% named not having enough Canadian job experience or references as a main difficulty. [2] A humble first job can help address exactly that.

## Humility must not become a permanent identity

But there is a danger. Humility can slowly turn into resignation. The temporary job becomes the permanent job. The professional identity fades. A year becomes three years, and one day you realize you have stopped believing you could do anything else.

The difference between strategic humility and resignation is simple: **purpose and a review date.** Strategic humility knows why it is doing this job and when it will check whether the job is still serving that purpose. Resignation has stopped asking.

We will return to this in Lesson 8 and in Lesson 49, "The Bridge Job With a Purpose." For now, remember this sentence, which I give to many of my students:

> *"This is what I am doing now. It is not the only thing I can do."*

**From my lessons: the director in the kitchen**

*This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*

Marcelo, 49, had been a director at a logistics company in Porto Alegre. In Halifax, he worked as a prep cook in a busy restaurant. In our lessons, he was cheerful and hard-working, and he never complained. One day I asked him what the job had taught him.

He thought for a long time. "Speed," he said. "The kitchen talks fast, with slang, with jokes. In three months, my listening improved more than in two years of classes in Brazil. And I learned how a Canadian manager gives feedback, very polite, very indirect. I didn't understand at first that 'maybe try it this way' meant 'do it this way.'"

Then he added, "But I put a date in my phone. One year. On that date, I ask myself if the kitchen is still teaching me something." We will see what he decided when that date arrived in Lesson 49.

## Look in the mirror

1. What have you been willing to do in Canada that you would not have done in Brazil?
2. What has that experience given you (income, English, references, cultural knowledge)?

3. Is there anything you have refused to do because of pride? Was that decision helpful or harmful?
4. If you are in a temporary job now, what is its purpose? When will you review it?
5. Complete the sentence: "This is what I am doing now. It is not the only thing I can do. I can also..."

## Say it in English

**Talking about a humble job with dignity**

- *"I'm currently working in..., which has been great for my English."*
- *"It's not my field, but I've learned a lot about Canadian workplaces."*
- *"I took this role to gain Canadian experience while I..."*
- *"It's taught me to work fast and communicate clearly under pressure."*
- *"I see it as a stepping stone."*
- *"I'm proud of the work I do, and I'm also working toward..."*

**Model answer.** *"I see you're working in a restaurant kitchen. How does that relate to this logistics role?"*

> *"More than you might think. A busy kitchen is a logistics operation: timing, inventory, coordination and clear communication under pressure. I took the job to improve my English and learn how Canadian teams work, and it did both. Before moving to Canada, I spent twelve years in logistics, including six as a director, so this role is a return to my field with some very practical Canadian experience."*

**Em português.** *Arregaçar as mangas* (literally, "to roll up the sleeves"). In English: *to roll up your sleeves*. Here the expression is the same in both languages.

**Teacher's note**

Students in "survival jobs" sometimes avoid mentioning them because they feel ashamed. Make the job a resource in your lessons: ask what expressions they hear at work, what misunderstandings they have had, what their manager says. This turns the job into a source of language and pride, and it shows them that the experience has value they can talk about.

**Key points**

- Humility is seeing your situation accurately and acting on it without pride getting in the way.
- A humble first job can bring income, daily English, Canadian references and cultural knowledge.
- Lack of Canadian experience or references is the most common difficulty reported by recent immigrants looking for a first job.

- Strategic humility has a purpose and a review date. Without them, it can turn into resignation.

# 8. The Cleaning Job Is Not the Story

> *Your current job is a chapter. Do not let it become the title.*

In Lesson 7 we looked at humility, the willingness to start again. This lesson is about what happens next, in your own mind, when you have been doing that humble job for a while.

Something subtle happens to many of my students. In the first months, they describe the cleaning job, the kitchen job or the warehouse job as *temporary*. They talk about their real profession constantly. But slowly the language changes. "I was an engineer" becomes "I used to be an engineer." Then the engineer disappears from the conversation altogether. When someone asks what they do, they simply say, "I clean offices."

The job has not changed. The story has.

## How a job becomes an identity

There are several reasons why this happens.

**Repetition.** You spend forty hours a week doing one thing. You spend almost no hours doing the thing you used to do. Over time, the brain updates its picture of who you are based on what you actually do every day.

**How others see you.** Your co-workers, your manager and your customers know only the current version of you. Nobody at work has seen you lead a meeting or design a system. Their image of you slowly becomes your image of yourself.

**Fatigue.** Physical work, long shifts and night hours leave little energy for anything else. The professional self needs maintenance (reading, practising,

talking to people in your field), and when you are tired, maintenance is the first thing to go.

**Protection from disappointment.** Sometimes people stop talking about their profession because it hurts. If you stop hoping, you cannot be disappointed. This is understandable, and it is also how many talented people get stuck.

## Two stories at the same time

The answer is not to feel ashamed of the job. Honest work deserves respect, and many of the people I admire most among my students are doing physically demanding jobs with great dignity.

The answer is to hold two stories at the same time:

1. **The current story:** *I work as a cleaner. I am reliable, I work hard, and this job pays our bills and gives me English practice.*
2. **The professional story:** *I am a civil engineer with twelve years of experience in infrastructure projects. I am working toward recognition of my credentials in Canada.*

Both stories are true. The danger is when the first one replaces the second.

## How to keep your professional story alive

Some practical habits help:

- **Keep using the vocabulary.** Read one article a week in English about your field. Watch a conference talk. Keep the technical language alive in your head.
- **Keep one professional connection active.** One conversation a month with someone in your field, in Canada or in Brazil.

- **Introduce yourself with both stories.** "I'm an engineer; right now I'm working in cleaning while my credentials are assessed."
- **Keep a small project going.** A certificate, a volunteer role, a portfolio, anything that keeps your professional self in action, even for two hours a week.

**From my lessons: "I clean offices"**

*This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*

Luciana was living in Winnipeg and had been in Canada for two years when she started lessons with me. In our first lesson, we practised small talk, and I played someone she had just met. I asked, "What do you do?" She answered, "I clean offices." Then she looked down.

When the role-play ended, I asked her what she had done in Brazil. She had been a civil engineer for twelve years and had worked on bridge projects. She had not mentioned it to anyone in Canada for over a year.

"It feels like another person," she said.

We practised one sentence until it felt natural: "I'm a civil engineer. At the moment I'm working in cleaning while I prepare for my credential assessment." The first time she said it, her voice shook. By the fifth time, she was smiling.

A week later she told me that a woman at her church had asked what she did. Luciana used the sentence. The woman's brother worked for the city's engineering department, and he agreed to meet her for coffee. It was not a job. It was the first professional conversation she had had in Canada, and it happened because she told the whole story.

## Look in the mirror

1. When someone asks "What do you do?", what do you usually answer?
2. Has your answer changed since you arrived in Canada? How?
3. What is your professional story, in two sentences?
4. What is one habit you could start this month to keep your professional self alive?
5. Who is one person, in Canada or Brazil, you could talk to about your field this month?

## Say it in English

**Telling both stories at the same time**

- *"I'm a... by profession. At the moment, I'm working in... while I..."*
- *"Back home I worked as... for [number] years."*
- *"I'm in a transition period right now."*
- *"I'm working toward getting my credentials recognized here."*
- *"It's a temporary job, but I'm learning a lot."*

- *"In my field, I specialized in..."*

**Model answer.** *Small talk at a community event: "So, what do you do?"*

> *"I'm a civil engineer, actually. I worked on bridge and road projects in Brazil for about twelve years. Right now I'm working in cleaning while I go through the credential assessment process here. It's been a big change, but I'm getting closer. What about you?"*

**Em português.** *Trabalho honesto não envergonha ninguém* (literally, "honest work shames nobody"). In English: *There's no shame in honest work*.

**Teacher's note**

Notice when students describe themselves only by their current job, and gently ask about their profession. Practise the "two stories" introduction as a regular warm-up. Many students need permission to mention their past; once they hear themselves say it aloud in English, they often begin to use it outside your lessons.

**Key points**

- Over time, a temporary job can quietly replace your professional identity.
- Repetition, how others see you, fatigue and fear of disappointment all contribute.
- Hold two stories at once: the current one and the professional one. Both are true.

- Keep your professional self alive with small, regular habits, and tell the whole story when people ask.

# 9. Your Inventory: Everything You Carried Across

> *Before you decide what you lack, count what you have.*

We end Part I with a practical exercise. In the first eight lessons, we looked at the profile of the students who inspired this book: their education, their competitive professional background, their partnerships, their hunger and their humility. Now it is your turn to make a careful list of what *you* brought to Canada.

Most people never do this. They know exactly what they are missing: Canadian experience, fluent English, local contacts, recognized credentials. Ask them what they have, and they struggle to answer. This lesson fixes that imbalance.

## Formal and informal assets

Your assets fall into two groups.

**Formal assets** are written down, and someone else can verify them: degrees, diplomas, licences, certificates, documented achievements, language test scores.

**Informal assets** are less visible but just as real: staying calm when a project goes wrong, learning a new system quickly, noticing a risk before others do, helping a team work through disagreement, keeping your commitments.

Both count. But they become visible in different ways.

| Asset | How to make it visible |
|---|---|
| Degree or diploma | Credential evaluation; a clear English name for the program |
| Professional licence | Check with the provincial regulator early |
| Certificate | Name the issuing body; check for Canadian equivalents |
| Documented results | Numbers you can support: budgets, volumes, timelines |
| Calm under pressure | A specific story about a crisis and what you did |
| Learning quickly | An example of something you mastered, and how long it took |
| Building trust | A situation where you connected people who disagreed |
| Reliability | A record of commitments kept, and a reference who can confirm it |

Informal assets are the ones newcomers forget, because they feel too ordinary to mention. But employers hire for them every day. The question is never whether you have the quality; it is whether you can show it.

## The three-column inventory

Take a page and draw three columns:

1. **What I know:** knowledge and skills.
2. **What I have done:** specific examples that prove you have used them.
3. **What I need to learn here:** where this could be useful in Canada, and what adaptation is required.

The middle column is the most important. It turns a claim into evidence. "I am good at finance" is a claim. "I closed the books for a company of 400 people every month for six years and reduced the closing time from nine days to five" is evidence. Look for three things: **scale** (how big), **duration** (how long) and **result** (what changed).

The third column keeps you honest. Some things will transfer directly. Others will need a local credential, new software, a different regulation or a different

communication style. Writing this down is not admitting weakness; it is building a plan.

**Worked example: one row of a three-column inventory**

| What I know | What I have done | What I need to learn here |
|---|---|---|
| Financial reporting and month-end closing | Closed the books for a 400-employee company every month for six years; reduced closing time from 9 days to 5 | Canadian accounting standards; local payroll rules; the CPA Canada route for internationally trained accountants |

Notice that the middle column never says "I am excellent." It gives scale (400 employees), duration (six years) and a result (9 days to 5). The facts do the work.

## Put a number on it

If you remember only one thing from this lesson, remember this: **wherever you can, quantify.**

Numbers do two jobs. In an interview, they turn a claim into impact. A Canadian interviewer may never have heard of your company, your city or the Brazilian system you worked in, but everyone understands *a team of twelve*, *forty percent faster* or *three hundred clients*. Numbers travel across borders better than adjectives do.

The second job is less obvious and just as important: numbers show *you* the impact you have had. Many of my students have never counted. When they finally do (how many people they trained, how much money passed through their hands, how many hours their process saved) they are often surprised. A job that felt ordinary from the inside turns out to have touched hundreds of people or millions of reais. That is not exaggeration. It is the first accurate measurement they have ever taken of their own work.

### Seven kinds of numbers

Almost every achievement can be measured in at least one of these ways:

| Kind of number | Questions to ask yourself |
|---|---|
| **People** | How many people did I lead, train, serve or affect? |
| **Money** | What budget did I manage? How much did I save, earn or protect? |
| **Time** | How much time did I save? How fast did I deliver? For how many years? |
| **Volume** | How many projects, files, clients, transactions or units? |
| **Change** | What was the number before, and what was it after? |
| **Frequency** | How often: every day, every week, every month-end? |
| **Rank or scale** | Out of how many? The largest, the first, the top five? |

### When you do not have the exact figure

You will not remember every number, and that is fine. Estimate honestly:

- **Reconstruct it.** About forty invoices a day, five days a week, for six years is roughly sixty thousand invoices.
- **Use honest approximations:** *about*, *roughly*, *more than*, *nearly*.
- **Be ready to explain** how you arrived at the number if someone asks.
- **Never invent.** A modest, true number is far stronger than an impressive one you cannot defend.

If a figure is confidential, use a percentage or a range instead: *"a budget in the millions"*, *"a 15% reduction in costs"*.

### Translate the number for a Canadian listener

A Canadian interviewer will not know what *R$ 2 milhões* means for a company in Recife. Convert money into Canadian dollars at the current rate and round it, or describe the scale in relative terms: *"the second-largest budget in the division"*. And remember that English uses a decimal *point* and a

thousands *comma*, the opposite of Portuguese: R$ 1.500,50 is written *1,500.50* in English.

### The "so what?" test

A number on its own is not yet impact. After every number, ask: *so what?* What did it mean for the company, the client or the team?

*"I reduced closing time from nine days to five."* So what? *"So managers received the monthly results a week earlier and could correct problems before the next month began."* Now the listener understands why the number matters.

**From my lessons: the analyst who wrote "none"**

*This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*

Mariana worked for fifteen years as a financial analyst in São Paulo. Eight months after arriving in Calgary, she applied online for a bookkeeping assistant position. When the form asked for "relevant Canadian experience," she typed *none*, and then deleted her Brazilian roles from the "additional experience" box as well. "They felt like something from another life," she said.

In our lesson, her first attempt at the inventory was short. Column one: *Excel, finance, Portuguese.* Column two: empty. "I have done nothing here yet," she explained.

I changed the instruction: column two is not about Canada. It is about everything you have done, anywhere. Slowly, the page filled. *Built an 18-month forecast used by three departments. Reduced reporting errors by introducing a checking routine. Trained four new analysts. Presented results to clients in Spanish.* The third column became specific too: *learn*

*Canadian tax terms; ask a local accountant which software is common; check how CPA Canada evaluates foreign experience.*

Nothing about her English changed that week. What changed was her own account of what she brought. She stopped writing *none*.

## Look in the mirror

1. Complete a three-column inventory with at least five rows. Take your time; do it over several days if you need to.
2. For each row, check the middle column: does it include scale, duration or a result? Add at least one number to every row.
3. Which informal assets did you nearly forget to include?
4. Which items in the third column are the most urgent to learn?
5. Look back at the introduction you wrote in Lesson 1. What would you add now?

## Say it in English

**Turning your inventory into conversation**

- *"In my previous role, I was responsible for..."*
- *"One result I'm proud of is..."*
- *"I have [number] years of experience in..., mainly in..."*
- *"I led a team of [number] and managed a budget of about [amount]."*
- *"We reduced [something] from [before] to [after], which meant that..."*
- *"The context was different in Brazil, but the core skill is the same."*
- *"I'm currently learning how this works in Canada, specifically..."*
- *"I don't have Canadian experience in this yet, but I've done something very similar."*

**Model answer.** *"Do you have any Canadian experience?"*

> *"Not yet in this exact role. But I worked for fifteen years as a financial analyst in Brazil, where I built an 18-month forecast that three departments relied on. The accounting standards are different here, and I'm studying the Canadian rules now. The core work, which is analyzing numbers, catching errors early and explaining results clearly, is the same, and that's what I'd bring to this team."*

Notice the shape: an honest *not yet*, specific evidence, what you are learning, and a link to their needs. No apology, no exaggeration.

**Em português.** *Fazer um balanço* (literally, "to draw up a balance sheet"). In English: *to take stock*.

**Teacher's note**

Do the inventory together during the lesson, not as homework. Students working alone tend to leave the middle column empty or fill it with adjectives. Ask "How many? How long? What changed?" for every row. That is exactly the questioning they will face in interviews, and exactly the English they need to practise.

**Key points**

- Most newcomers can list what they lack but not what they have. Fix that imbalance.
- Formal assets can be verified; informal assets need stories to become visible.
- Strong evidence has scale, duration and a result.
- Wherever you can, quantify: people, money, time, volume, change, frequency or rank. Then ask "so what?"
- The third column, what you need to learn here, is a plan, not a weakness.

PART II

# Why You Have Succeeded

> *Before you can use your success, you have to understand it.*

# 10. Why Have You Been Successful? The Question Nobody Asks

> *If you do not understand why you succeeded, you cannot do it again on purpose.*

People ask newcomers many questions. Where are you from? Why did you come? Do you have Canadian experience? How is your English? Almost nobody asks the question that matters most: *Why have you been successful?*

And yet most of my students *have* been successful. They built careers, earned degrees, raised families, managed money through difficult economic periods and organized an international move. Those are not small achievements. Something made them possible.

Part II of this book is about finding that something. Because if you can name the reasons for your past success, you can use them deliberately in your new life. If you cannot, you are relying on luck to repeat it.

## Results versus reasons

Most people can describe their *results* easily: "I was promoted to manager." "I finished my MBA." "I doubled the sales in my region." What they struggle to describe are the *reasons*: the habits, choices and qualities that produced those results.

There are a few reasons for this. Success often feels natural from the inside, so the habits behind it become invisible. Some people believe that talking about the reasons for their success is arrogant. And many people simply attribute success to luck or circumstances: "I had a good boss." "The market was growing." "I was in the right place."

Luck and circumstances matter; nobody succeeds alone. But they are rarely the whole story. Two people with the same good boss do not always get the same result. Something about *you* made a difference.

## Three questions to find the reasons

When students struggle with this, I give them three questions to ask about any achievement:

1. **What did I do that others in the same situation did not do?** This reveals your distinctive behaviours.
2. **What did I keep doing when it became difficult?** This reveals your persistence and discipline.
3. **What would have happened if I had not been there?** This reveals your real contribution.

Answer these three questions about three different achievements, and patterns begin to appear. Perhaps you always prepared more than others. Perhaps you were the person who built relationships across departments. Perhaps you stayed calm when others panicked. These patterns are your success factors. They are portable. They came with you to Canada.

## Why this matters now

In Canada, you will need to answer some version of this question many times, in interviews, networking conversations and performance reviews. "What are your strengths?" "Tell me about a time you succeeded." "What would your previous manager say about you?"

But the deeper reason is personal. When English is hard and the job search is slow, you need to remember that you are a person who has succeeded before, and that you know *how*. That knowledge is one of the strongest protections against the impostor feelings we will explore in Part IV.

**From my lessons: "I was lucky"**

*This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*

Gustavo, 39, had risen from analyst to finance manager at a large retailer in Brasília in eight years. When I asked him why, he shrugged. "I was lucky. I had a good director who liked me."

I asked the three questions. *What did you do that others did not?* He thought. "I always sent my reports a day early, and I added a page explaining what the numbers meant. The others just sent numbers." *What did you keep doing when it was difficult?* "During the crisis in 2015, I kept meeting every store manager personally. Many people stopped travelling." *What would have happened without you?* "Honestly? The cost-reduction plan would have been late."

His director liked him for reasons. Gustavo had simply never named them. By the end of the lesson, he had three: *anticipation, translating numbers into meaning, and showing up in person during difficult periods.* He wrote them on a card and kept it in his wallet.

## Look in the mirror

1. List three achievements you are proud of, from work, study or family life.
2. For each one, answer: What did I do that others did not? What did I keep doing when it was difficult? What would have happened without me?
3. What patterns do you see across the three achievements?

4. Write your three most important success factors in one sentence each.
5. Which of these factors are you using in Canada right now? Which have you stopped using?

## Say it in English

**Explaining why you succeeded, without bragging and without luck**

- *"I think the main reason it worked was..."*
- *"What made the difference was that I..."*
- *"I was fortunate to have a good team, and my part was..."*
- *"One thing I always did was..."*
- *"My manager used to say that I was the person who..."*
- Instead of *"I was lucky"* → *"I had good support, and I also worked hard to..."*

**Model answer.** *"What would your previous manager say are your strengths?"*

> *"I think she would say I anticipate problems. I usually sent my reports a day early, with a short explanation of what the numbers meant for the business, so she could prepare for her meetings. And during difficult periods, I made a point of visiting the stores in person rather than relying on emails. That's how I like to work: early, clear and close to the people involved."*

**Em português.** *Sorte é quando a preparação encontra a oportunidade*. In English: *Luck is what happens when preparation meets opportunity*. A saying often quoted in Brazil, and often attributed to the Roman philosopher Seneca.

**Teacher's note**

When students attribute success to luck or other people, do not contradict them; ask the three questions. Adults rarely believe compliments about themselves, but they do believe their own answers. The language of cause and effect (*because, so, as a result, which meant that*) is also excellent grammar practice.

**Key points**

- Most people can describe their results but not the reasons behind them.
- Luck and support matter, but they are rarely the whole story.
- Ask three questions: What did I do that others did not? What did I keep doing? What would have happened without me?
- Your success factors are portable. Name them, and you can use them deliberately in Canada.

# 11. Discipline: The Habit Behind the Results

> *Motivation starts things. Discipline finishes them.*

Ask my students how they finished a second degree while working full time, and very few of them say "motivation." They say things like: "I studied every night from nine to eleven." "I used my lunch break." "I woke up at five on Saturdays." What they are describing is not a feeling. It is discipline: the ability to do what needs to be done, regularly, whether or not you feel like it.

Discipline is one of the quietest parts of the edge. It does not look impressive. Nobody applauds you for studying on a Tuesday night. But over months and years, it produces results that talent alone rarely does.

## What discipline really looks like

Discipline is often imagined as a heroic effort: long hours, strong willpower, no breaks. In practice, the most disciplined people I know rely much less on willpower and much more on structure. They:

- **Decide in advance.** They do not ask themselves every evening whether they will study. The decision was made once, and the schedule carries it.
- **Make it small enough to repeat.** Thirty minutes every day is more disciplined than five hours once a month.
- **Attach new habits to existing ones.** "After I drop the children at school, I listen to an English podcast in the car."
- **Track it.** A simple calendar with a mark for each day completed.
- **Forgive a missed day without abandoning the habit.** One missed day is a pause; two in a row is a warning; quitting is a decision.

If you completed a demanding degree, held a responsible job or raised children while studying, you already know most of this. You may simply not have thought of it as a skill. It is one.

## Discipline in a new country

Immigration tests discipline in new ways. In Brazil, your routines were established: your commute, your gym, your study time, your family's schedule. In Canada, everything is new at once. The structure that supported your discipline has disappeared, and you have to rebuild it.

Many of my students tell me, "I used to be so organized. Now I feel chaotic." That is not a loss of discipline. It is a loss of structure. The habit is still in you; it needs a new framework.

The solution is to rebuild the structure deliberately, starting small:

1. **Choose one fixed daily anchor.** One activity at the same time every day, for example 20 minutes of English after dinner.
2. **Protect it for 30 days** before adding anything else.
3. **Add a second anchor** only when the first one is automatic.

Do not try to rebuild your entire life's routine in the first month. That is how people burn out and conclude that they have "lost" their discipline.

> **From my lessons: the five o'clock alarm**
>
> *This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*
>
> Patrícia, 45, had completed a law degree and a master's in tax law while working at a firm in Rio de Janeiro. Her method in Brazil had been simple: she studied from five to seven every morning before her children woke up.

In Toronto, she was working irregular shifts at a pharmacy, and her English was not improving as fast as she wanted. “I have no discipline here,” she told me. “I’m not the same person.”

I asked her about the five o’clock alarm. She laughed: “That was another life.” But she agreed to try a smaller version: 25 minutes of English, at the same time, on the four mornings when she did not have an early shift. She kept a paper calendar on the fridge and drew a mark for every session.

After six weeks, she had 22 marks. Her listening test score had improved, but she was more excited about something else. “I’m the same person,” she said. “I just needed the alarm back.”

## Look in the mirror

1. Describe a period in your life when you were very disciplined. What did your routine look like?
2. What structure supported that discipline (time, place, people, habits)?
3. Which parts of that structure did you lose when you moved to Canada?
4. What is one small daily anchor you could start this week?
5. How will you track it?

## Say it in English

**Talking about discipline and routines**

- *"I'm a very organized person."*
- *"I like to plan my week in advance."*
- *"I set aside time every day for..."*
- *"I completed my degree while working full time, so I'm used to managing my time."*
- *"I've built a routine that works for me."*
- *"I'm consistent. I'd rather do a little every day than a lot once in a while."*

**Model answer.** *"How do you manage your time when you have many priorities?"*

> *"I plan my week every Sunday and decide in advance what's most important. When I did my master's degree while working full time, I studied from five to seven every morning, before my children woke up. That routine taught me that small, consistent blocks of time are more effective than trying to do everything at once. I still work that way."*

**Em português.** *Deus ajuda quem cedo madruga* (literally, "God helps those who get up early"). In English: *The early bird catches the worm*.

**Teacher's note**

When a student says "I have no discipline," ask how they achieved their degrees. Then ask what has changed in their routine. Usually the answer is structure, not character. Helping a student design one small daily anchor for English practice often does more for their progress than any single lesson.

**Key points**

- Discipline relies more on structure than on willpower.
- If you have completed demanding studies or work, you already have the habit. It is a real skill.
- Immigration removes the structure that supported your discipline; it does not remove the discipline.
- Rebuild slowly: one daily anchor, protected for 30 days, then the next.

# 12. Learning How to Learn

> *The most transferable skill you own is the ability to become good at something new.*

In Lesson 2 we looked at lifelong learning as a habit. This lesson goes one step deeper. It is not only *that* you have learned many things as an adult. It is *how* you learned them. The methods you used to pass difficult exams, master new software or understand a new industry are tools. They came with you to Canada, and they can be pointed at English and at your new career.

## You have a learning method, even if you have never named it

Every successful adult learner has a method, although most have never written it down. When I ask my students how they prepared for difficult exams in Brazil, the answers are revealing:

- "I made summaries of every chapter and reviewed them the night before."
- "I studied in a group. We explained the material to each other."
- "I did old exams again and again until I understood the patterns."
- "I recorded myself reading my notes and listened in the car."
- "I studied a little every day. I could never study for ten hours at once."

Each of these is a real learning strategy, supported by research on how people learn: summarizing, teaching others, practice testing, repetition and spaced practice. My students discovered them through experience. And almost all of them can be applied directly to English.

## From exam strategy to language strategy

Here is how some common study methods translate into English practice:

| How you studied before | How to apply it to English |
|---|---|
| Summarizing chapters | Write a three-sentence summary of a podcast or article you heard |
| Studying in a group | Find a conversation partner and explain your professional field to each other |
| Doing old exams | Practise with real interview questions, real forms, real workplace emails |
| Recording yourself | Record your answers, listen, correct, record again |
| A little every day | 20 minutes daily instead of two hours on Sunday |

The point is not that one method is best. The point is that *you already know what works for you*. Many adult immigrants abandon their own successful methods when they start learning English, because English feels different from "real" study. It is not. It is a skill, and you have built difficult skills before.

## Learning in a new environment

Learning how to learn also applies outside your English lessons. In Canada, you will need to learn how your industry works here, how hiring works, how a new workplace communicates and how systems like banking, health care and schools operate.

The same approach works: identify what you need to know, find a reliable source, practise, get feedback and correct. A student who once learned a complex tax system in Brazil can learn the Canadian one. A student who learned a new enterprise software at work can learn the one a Canadian employer uses. The content changes; the method does not.

**From my lessons: the old exams**

*This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*

Rafael, 37, had passed one of Brazil's most competitive public service exams. His method had been simple and relentless: he collected every old exam he could find and practised them under timed conditions until the patterns became obvious.

In Canada, he was frustrated with job interviews. "I never know what they will ask," he said.

I asked him how he had prepared for the public service exam. As he explained, I could see him realize the connection himself. Job interviews in Canada also have patterns. That week, he collected forty common interview questions, wrote answers to each, practised them aloud with a timer and asked for feedback. He organized them by type: questions about strengths, conflict, failure, teamwork, motivation.

"It's the same thing," he said. "It's just an exam in English."

## Look in the mirror

1. Think of the most difficult thing you have ever learned as an adult. How did you learn it, step by step?
2. Which study methods worked best for you in the past?
3. Which of those methods are you using for English right now? Which have you abandoned?
4. Choose one method from your past and design a way to apply it to English this week.

5. What is one Canadian system (in your field or your daily life) that you need to learn, and how will you learn it?

## Say it in English

**Describing how you learn**

- *"I learn best by..."*
- *"When I need to learn something new, I usually start by..."*
- *"I like to practise with real examples."*
- *"I'm a hands-on learner."*
- *"I learned [software/system] in about [time] by..."*
- *"I ask a lot of questions at the beginning, so I can work independently later."*

**Model answer.** *"How quickly can you learn our systems?"*

> *"I'm confident I can learn them quickly. When my previous company introduced a new ERP system, I learned it in about three weeks by practising with real transactions every day and keeping a list of*

> *questions for the trainer. I ask a lot of questions at the beginning so that I can work independently as soon as possible."*

**Em português.** *A prática leva à perfeição* (literally, "practice leads to perfection"). In English: *Practice makes perfect*.

**Falso amigo:** *college* ≠ *colégio*. In Canada, a *college* is a post-secondary institution. A *colégio* is a school, often private, for primary or secondary students; in Canada, say *school* or *high school*.

**Teacher's note**

Ask students to describe how they prepared for their most difficult exam. Then help them map that method onto English practice. Adults are far more committed to a strategy they recognize as their own than to one a teacher prescribes, and many already use methods that research supports.

**Key points**

- You already have a learning method, even if you have never named it.
- Methods that worked for exams (summaries, group study, practice tests, recording, daily repetition) work for English too.
- Many adult immigrants abandon their own successful methods because English feels different. It is not.
- The same method applies to learning Canadian systems and your industry here.

# 13. Resilience You Have Already Proven

> *You do not need to become resilient. You need to remember that you already are.*

"Resilience" has become a popular word. It appears in job postings, self-help books and motivational speeches. But for most of my students, resilience is not a theory. It is their biography.

Many of them grew up during periods of high inflation and economic uncertainty in Brazil. Some lost jobs during recessions and found new ones. Some built careers while supporting parents or siblings. Some lived through company closures, restructurings and mergers. All of them made one of the hardest decisions an adult can make: to leave everything familiar and start again in another country.

These experiences are evidence. You do not need to *hope* that you can handle difficulty. You already have proof.

## What resilience actually is

Resilience is not the absence of difficulty, or the absence of pain. Resilient people feel fear, frustration and sadness like everyone else. What distinguishes them is what happens next. They:

- **Accept the situation as it is,** without pretending it is better or worse.
- **Find the next possible action,** even a small one.
- **Ask for help** when they need it.
- **Learn from the experience** and adjust.
- **Keep a sense of meaning,** a reason why the effort is worth it.

Notice that none of these require you to feel strong. Resilience is mostly a series of actions, not a feeling.

## The danger of forgetting

The strange thing about resilience is that people often forget their own. When you are in the middle of a new difficulty, past difficulties seem smaller, as if they had been easy. "That was different," people say. "I was younger." "I had my family nearby." "I spoke the language."

Some of that is true; circumstances change. But the core abilities you used then are still yours: staying calm, finding options, asking for help, persisting. The tools are the same, even if the situation is new.

One useful exercise is to write a short "resilience history": three difficult periods in your life, what you did, and what happened in the end. Read it when Canada feels impossible. It is not a motivational poster. It is your own evidence.

> **From my lessons: the list in the notebook**
>
> *This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*
>
> Simone, 42, had been in Canada for fourteen months when she had what she called "the worst week." Her application for a coordinator role was rejected after the final interview, her son was struggling at school, and her car broke down in January in Saskatoon.
>
> In our next lesson, she said quietly, "I don't think I can do this."
>
> I asked her to write about another difficult period, any time in her life. She wrote about 2015, when the company she had worked at for ten years closed in Belo Horizonte and she was unemployed for seven months with a newborn baby. She described how she had called every

contact she had, taken freelance work, studied for a certification and eventually been hired by a competitor, at a higher level.

When she finished, she read it twice. “I forgot that I did this,” she said. “I really forgot.”

She kept the page in the front of her notebook. Several months later, she told me she had read it “maybe twenty times.” She did get a coordinator role, eventually, after two more interviews.

## Look in the mirror

1. Describe three difficult periods in your life: what happened, what you did and how it ended. (If three feels like too much, start with one.)
2. What actions helped you most during those periods?
3. Who helped you, and how did you ask for that help?
4. What is the most difficult part of your life in Canada right now?
5. Which of the actions from your resilience history could you apply to that difficulty this week?

## Say it in English

**Answering behavioural questions about setbacks**

- *"It was a very difficult period, both professionally and personally."*
- *"The first thing I did was..."*
- *"I realized that I needed to..."*
- *"I reached out to..."*
- *"In the end, ..."*
- *"What I learned from that experience is..."*

**Model answer.** *"Tell me about a time you faced a major setback."*

> *"In 2015, the company I'd worked at for ten years closed, and I was unemployed for seven months, with a newborn baby at home. The first thing I did was contact everyone in my professional network. I took freelance projects to keep earning, and I used the extra time to complete a certification. In the end, I was hired by a competitor at a higher level. What I learned is that, in a difficult situation, the most important thing is to keep taking small actions every day."*

**Em português.** *Brasileiro não desiste nunca* (literally, "Brazilians never give up"). In English: *Never give up*. A popular saying in Brazil. Remember that resilience is a set of actions, not a nationality.

**Teacher's note**

Behavioural interview questions ("Tell me about a time when...") are an ideal vehicle for this lesson. Students practise the past tenses and sequencing language while retelling their own resilience. If a student

shares something painful, acknowledge it briefly and respectfully, and keep the focus on what they did, not on the pain itself.

**Key points**

- For many immigrants, resilience is not a theory; it is their biography.
- Resilience is a series of actions (accept, act, ask, learn, find meaning), not a feeling.
- People often forget their own resilience when facing a new difficulty.
- Write a resilience history and read it when Canada feels impossible.

# 14. Responsibility: Carrying Other People

> *The people who depend on you are part of the reason you succeed.*

Most of my students do not only carry their own lives. They carry other people. A spouse who gave up a career to move. Children who need stability in a new school. Elderly parents in Brazil who still need financial help or emotional support. Sometimes siblings, nephews and godchildren too.

This responsibility is heavy. It is also one of the deepest sources of their strength.

## What responsibility builds

People who have carried responsibility for others tend to develop specific qualities:

- **Reliability.** When others depend on you, you learn to keep commitments.
- **Long-term thinking.** You plan beyond next week because other people's futures are involved.
- **Calm decision-making.** You learn that panic does not help the people you are responsible for.
- **Prioritization.** You learn quickly what matters and what can wait.
- **Motivation that does not depend on mood.** You keep going on bad days because someone is counting on you.

Employers value these qualities highly, especially in roles involving management, client relationships or trust. A person who has managed a

household, a career and the needs of an extended family has been practising leadership for years, often without calling it that.

## Responsibility at work

Many of my students also carried significant responsibility in their jobs: teams, budgets, clients, compliance, safety. They were the person others called when something went wrong.

In Canada, they may be in a role with very little responsibility for a while. This can be a relief, but it can also be disorienting. People who are used to carrying weight sometimes feel lost without it. They may start to believe that they are no longer "the kind of person" who is trusted with important things.

That belief is wrong. Your capacity for responsibility has not disappeared; it is simply not being used at work right now. Look for places where you can use it: volunteering, community organizations, leading a study group, supporting newer immigrants, taking on extra responsibility in your current job when it is offered.

## The weight can become too heavy

There is also a warning here. Responsibility for others can become so heavy that you stop taking care of yourself. You work extra shifts to send money home. You give up your own study time to help your children with homework. You never rest, because someone always needs something.

Carrying others is admirable. But a person who collapses cannot carry anyone. Taking care of your own health, sleep and development is not selfish. It is part of being responsible, because it allows you to keep carrying the people you love.

> **From my lessons: the money transfer**

*This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*

Leonardo, 47, worked full time in a factory in Kitchener and had English lessons with me two evenings a week. Every month, he sent money to his mother in Fortaleza, who had health problems. He also helped his two teenage children adjust to school and supported his wife, who was retraining as a nurse.

In our lessons, Leonardo was often tired, and his homework was frequently incomplete. One evening he apologized, explaining his situation.

I did not need him to apologize. Instead, I asked him to describe his week in English, everything he managed. As he listed it, we both went quiet. He was coordinating finances in two countries, supporting three people's education and working full time, in a second language.

"In an interview," I said, "what kind of person would you say this describes?"

He thought. "Someone who manages many priorities," he said slowly. "Someone reliable."

Then we discussed one change he could make: a shorter, realistic homework goal that fit his actual week, so that he could succeed at it rather than fail at a bigger one. He met that goal in seven of the next eight weeks, and for the first time since arriving, he stopped apologizing at the start of our lessons.

## Look in the mirror

1. Who depends on you, in Canada or in Brazil? List them.

2. What qualities has carrying that responsibility built in you?
3. What responsibilities did you carry at work before moving?
4. Where could you use your capacity for responsibility in Canada right now (work, volunteering, community)?
5. What are you neglecting in your own life because of the weight you carry? What is one small change that would help?

## Say it in English

**Talking about responsibility and reliability**

- *"I'm used to having people depend on me."*
- *"In my previous role, I was responsible for a team of..."*
- *"I managed a budget of..."*
- *"I'm someone people can count on."*
- *"I'm good at juggling multiple priorities."*
- *"I'm comfortable making decisions that affect other people."*

**Model answer.** *"Tell me about a time when you had a lot of responsibility."*

> *"In my last job in Brazil, I supervised a team of twelve people in a factory, and I was responsible for safety on the night shift. If something went wrong, I was the person who had to make the decision. I learned to stay calm, communicate clearly and follow procedures carefully. I think that experience is why people tend to trust me with important tasks."*

**Em português.** *Segurar as pontas* (literally, "to hold the ends"). In English: *to hold the fort; to keep things together*.

**Teacher's note**

Students carrying heavy family responsibilities often fall behind on homework and feel ashamed. Adjust expectations to their real lives and help them set smaller, achievable goals. A student who succeeds at a small goal every week will progress further than one who repeatedly fails at a large one.

**Key points**

- Many immigrants carry responsibility for spouses, children and family in two countries.
- That responsibility builds reliability, long-term thinking, calm decisions and strong motivation.
- Your capacity for responsibility has not disappeared; find places to use it in Canada.
- Taking care of yourself is part of being responsible for others.

# 15. Working Well Under Pressure

> *You have been trained for this moment, even if the moment is in English.*

Many of my students describe their former workplaces with the same words: *fast, demanding, intense*. Monthly targets. Quarterly closings. Audits. Product launches. Crises that arrived on Friday afternoon and had to be solved by Monday morning. They learned to work under pressure because there was no other option.

In Canada, they sometimes discover that this experience is more valuable than they thought, and more transferable. Pressure is universal. Every workplace has deadlines, difficult clients and unexpected problems. A person who has learned to function well under pressure brings a quality that employers notice quickly.

## What working under pressure really means

Working well under pressure is not about being fearless or never feeling stressed. It is a set of skills:

- **Prioritizing quickly:** deciding what must be done first and what can wait.
- **Breaking big problems into small steps** so they become manageable.
- **Communicating clearly** when there is no time for misunderstanding.
- **Staying calm enough to think,** even when you feel anxious.
- **Recovering afterward,** so that pressure does not accumulate into exhaustion.

If you have managed a difficult deadline, a crisis or a demanding client, you have used these skills. The question is whether you recognize them.

## Pressure in a second language

Here is something interesting I have noticed in my lessons. Many students who are excellent under professional pressure become very anxious under *language* pressure: a phone call, a fast meeting, a question they do not fully understand.

This makes sense. Language pressure is new. In your professional life, you had years to develop strategies for pressure. In English, you are still building them.

But many of the same strategies work. When a crisis arrived at work, you probably did not panic and act randomly. You paused, clarified the problem, decided on the first step and communicated. The same sequence works in English:

1. **Pause.** Take a breath. It is acceptable to say, *"Let me think about that for a moment."*
2. **Clarify.** *"Just to make sure I understand, are you asking about...?"*
3. **Choose the first step.** Answer the most important part first.
4. **Communicate simply.** Short sentences are stronger under pressure than long, complex ones.

You already know how to handle pressure. You are learning to do it in a new language.

> **From my lessons: the conference call**
>
> *This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*

Daniela, 40, had been a supply chain manager in Manaus, responsible for keeping production lines running during supply disruptions. She was famous at her old company for staying calm during crises.

In her new job in Vancouver, as an operations assistant, she froze during her first conference call. A supplier spoke quickly, her manager asked her a question, and she could not find any words at all. "I felt like a child," she told me. "In Brazil, I was the calm one."

We role-played calls in our lessons, using the same steps she had used in supply crises: pause, clarify, answer the most important part first, keep it short. She wrote the clarifying phrases on a card and kept it next to her computer.

Two weeks later, she reported back. On a call with a supplier, she had said, "Sorry, just to make sure I understand, you're saying the delivery will be three days late?" The supplier confirmed. She then said, "Okay. Let me check with my manager and I'll call you back within the hour." "It was a very simple sentence," she said, "but it was the old me."

## Look in the mirror

1. Describe the most high-pressure situation you handled at work. What did you do, step by step?
2. Which of those steps could you use when you feel pressure in English?
3. In which English situations do you feel the most pressure right now?
4. Write three phrases you could use to give yourself time or clarify under pressure.

5. What helps you recover after a stressful day? Are you doing it?

## Say it in English

**Buying time and staying clear under pressure**

- *"Let me think about that for a moment."*
- *"Just to make sure I understand, are you asking...?"*
- *"Could you repeat the last part, please?"*
- *"The most important thing right now is..."*
- *"Let me check and get back to you by [time]."*
- *"I'll send you a quick summary by email to confirm."*

**Model answer.** *"How do you handle stress and tight deadlines?"*

> *"I'm used to it. In my previous role, I managed the supply chain for a production plant, and supply disruptions happened often. My approach is always the same: first I clarify the problem, then I decide on the most important action, and I communicate clearly with everyone involved. I've found that staying calm and organized helps the whole team stay focused."*

**Em português.** *Manter a cabeça fria* (literally, "to keep the head cold"). In English: *to keep a cool head*.

**Teacher's note**

Explicitly teach "buying time" phrases and clarification questions early. Students who are calm under professional pressure often panic under language pressure because they lack these tools. Practising them in realistic role-plays (phone calls, fast meetings, unexpected questions) reduces anxiety more effectively than any reassurance.

**Key points**

- Working under pressure is a set of skills: prioritizing, breaking problems down, communicating clearly, staying calm and recovering.
- Many professionals who handle work pressure well still feel overwhelmed by language pressure.
- The same sequence works in English: pause, clarify, choose the first step, communicate simply.
- Learn a few phrases that give you time. They are among the most useful English you will ever learn.

# 16. Relationships: The Brazilian Talent for Connection

> *In a new country, the people you know become the roads you travel.*

Every nationality has its generalizations, and most of them should be treated carefully. But there is one observation I have made so often, across so many students, that I am comfortable sharing it as a pattern: many of my Brazilian students are remarkably good at building relationships.

They remember names. They ask about your family. They remember your birthday. In a new job or a college program, they create a WhatsApp group in the first week and keep it alive for years. They notice when a colleague is missing and send a message. Within a month, they know the receptionist, the security guard and half the neighbours in their building.

Not every Brazilian is like this, of course, and many people from other cultures are wonderful at connection too. But if this description sounds like you, you should know that you are carrying one of the most valuable assets for life in Canada.

## Why relationships matter so much here

In Canada, as in most countries, a large share of jobs are filled through people who know people: referrals, recommendations, a manager who remembers a good conversation. A newcomer's professional network is usually very small at the beginning. That is one of the main reasons the first Canadian job is hard to find.

Relationships also matter for daily life. Neighbours tell you which school is good. A colleague explains how the unwritten rules of the office work. A

friend from church or the soccer club tells you about an opening at their company. A study partner corrects your English without making you feel embarrassed.

The person who builds relationships naturally has a quiet advantage in all of this.

## Where the talent can get stuck

There are two common places where this strength gets stuck.

**The first is the language.** In Portuguese, my students are warm, funny and quick. In English, many become quiet and formal. They feel that their personality "does not come through," so they avoid social conversations, the very conversations where relationships begin. A student once told me, "In English, I am a boring person." She was not boring. She simply had not yet learned the small phrases that carry warmth in English.

**The second is the comfort of the community.** Brazilian communities in Canadian cities are generous and supportive, and they are an enormous help in the first months. But it is easy to build your entire social life inside them. Then your English stays where it is, and your network stays inside one community. The goal is not to leave your community. It is to add new circles to it.

## Connection is a skill you can transfer

The good news is that connection does not depend mainly on vocabulary. It depends on attention: remembering details, showing interest, following up, being generous. These behaviours work in any language. A short, sincere question in simple English ("How was your weekend? Did your daughter enjoy the trip?") builds more connection than a perfect sentence with no warmth.

Canadian workplace culture is often described as friendly but somewhat reserved. People may be polite and pleasant without inviting you into their personal lives quickly. Your warmth can be a real asset here, as long as you read the room, move at the other person's pace and respect privacy. Lesson 48 returns to this in more detail.

**From my lessons: the coffee list**

*This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*

Felipe, 38, had been a key account manager for a beverage company in Recife. His clients loved him. In Calgary, working in a warehouse while he improved his English, he barely spoke to anyone outside the Brazilian group at lunch.

"In Portuguese I'm the guy everybody calls," he said. "In English I disappear."

We made a small plan. Each week he would have one ten-minute conversation in English with someone outside his community: a co-worker, a neighbour, another parent at his children's school. We practised the opening questions and the follow-up phrases. He kept a simple list on his phone: name, one detail they had mentioned, and a reminder to ask about it next time.

Three months later, the list had twenty-two names. One of them was a shift supervisor who mentioned that the company's sales team needed someone with account experience. "It's the same thing I did in Recife," Felipe said. "I just needed to do it slowly, in English."

## Look in the mirror

1. How do people in your life describe you in relationships? Write three words they would use.
2. How did relationships help your career in Brazil? Give one specific example.
3. Does your personality "come through" in English? What changes?
4. How many people outside your own community do you speak with regularly in English?
5. Who is one person you could have a short conversation with this week?

## Say it in English

**Starting and keeping conversations**

- *"How was your weekend?"*
- *"Did you do anything fun?"*
- *"Last time you mentioned... How did it go?"*
- *"How long have you been working here?"*

- *"What do you enjoy most about your job?"*
- *"It was really nice talking to you. Let's grab a coffee sometime."*

**Model answer.** *"How do you build relationships with clients or colleagues?"*

> *"I think it starts with paying attention. I try to remember what people tell me, their priorities, their concerns, even small personal details, and I follow up. In my previous role, I managed accounts with some of our largest clients, and most of the growth came from trust that we built over time. I'm the kind of person who keeps in touch."*

**Em português.** *Puxar conversa* (literally, "to pull conversation"). In English: *to strike up a conversation*.

**Teacher's note**

Teach small talk explicitly. Many advanced students know complex grammar but have never been taught the short, informal phrases that carry warmth in English. Students who say they feel "boring" or "like a different person" in English usually need social language, not more vocabulary. Encourage them to set a weekly goal for conversations outside their own community.

**Key points**

- Many of my Brazilian students are naturally strong at building relationships. In Canada, this is a major asset.
- Networks matter for finding work and for daily life, and newcomers' networks start small.

- The talent gets stuck when English feels “cold” and when social life stays inside one community.
- Connection depends on attention more than vocabulary. Simple, sincere English is enough.

# 17. Adaptability: You Have Changed Before

> *The person who moved to Canada had already reinvented themselves several times.*

When people describe immigration, they often speak as if it were the first great change of a person's life. For most of my students, it is not. It is simply the largest in a long series.

Look at the typical path. A student moves from a small city to a capital to study. Changes jobs three or four times. Changes industries once. Learns new technologies every few years. Survives a merger and a new boss with a completely different style. Becomes a parent. Goes back to school in their thirties. Each of these changes required learning new rules, new people and new ways of working.

That is adaptability. You have practised it for years.

## What adaptability is made of

Adaptability is not the same as having no preferences or accepting everything. Adaptable people have strong values and clear goals. What they are flexible about is the *method*. They:

- **Notice quickly that the rules have changed** instead of insisting on the old ones.
- **Observe before judging.** They watch how things are done before deciding whether it is right or wrong.
- **Experiment.** They try a new approach, see what happens and adjust.

- **Tolerate discomfort** for a period, knowing that the unfamiliar becomes familiar.
- **Keep what works.** They do not throw away their old strengths; they apply them in a new way.

## Adapting to Canada

In Canada, almost everything requires some adaptation: the weather, the food, the schools, the health system, the way people disagree in meetings, how direct you can be with a manager, how long people stay at work, how often they say "sorry."

Some of these differences are small. Others touch your identity. Many of my students are surprised, for example, by how indirect Canadian feedback can sound, or by how much is written down rather than discussed. Others notice that Canadians separate work and personal life more strictly than they were used to.

You do not have to like every difference. You do have to understand it. Adaptability means learning the new context well enough to work effectively inside it, while keeping the values that make you who you are. Lesson 47 explores this balance in more detail.

## Adaptability and English

English requires adaptation too, and not only in grammar. Spoken English in Canada has its own rhythms, idioms, accents and levels of politeness. The English you learned from textbooks or international business may not match what you hear in a Tim Hortons line or a team meeting.

The adaptable learner treats this as data, not as failure. "I didn't understand that expression. What does it mean? When do people use it?" That attitude, curious rather than defensive, is one of the fastest ways to improve.

**From my lessons: the third reinvention**

*This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*

Cláudia, 46, felt that Canada had made her rigid. "Everything here is different and I keep fighting it," she told me in one of our lessons. "I think I'm too old to change."

I asked her to draw a simple timeline of her career. She had started as a journalist in Curitiba, moved into corporate communications when newspapers began cutting staff, then taught herself digital marketing when her company moved its budget online. Each change had felt frightening at the time. Each one had worked.

She looked at the timeline for a long moment. "This is my third reinvention," she said. "I'd forgotten the first two."

From then on, when something in Canada frustrated her, she asked a different question: not "Why is it like this?" but "How does this work, and how can I use it?" Within a year she was working in content marketing for a Toronto non-profit, with skills from all three of her careers.

## Look in the mirror

1. Draw a timeline of the major changes in your life and career. How many reinventions can you count?
2. Which change was the most difficult? How did you adapt?
3. What differences in Canada have been the hardest for you to accept?
4. Which of those differences could you study and understand better, even if you do not like them?

5. What is one strength from your old life that you could apply in a new way here?

## Say it in English

**Talking about change and flexibility**

- *"I've adapted to a lot of changes in my career."*
- *"I'm comfortable with change."*
- *"When I joined a new team, the first thing I did was..."*
- *"I try to understand how things work before I suggest changes."*
- *"It took me some time to get used to..., but now..."*
- *"I'm open to new ways of doing things."*

**Model answer.** *"Tell me about a time you had to adapt to a major change."*

> *"I've reinvented myself a few times. I started as a journalist, moved into corporate communications when the newspaper industry changed, and later taught myself digital marketing when my company shifted its budget online. Moving to Canada is the biggest change so far, but*

> *the approach is the same: I observe, I learn how things work here, and I find ways to use the skills I already have."*

**Em português.** *Dançar conforme a música* (literally, "to dance according to the music"). In English: *to go with the flow*.

**Teacher's note**

Students who feel "too old to change" respond well to the career-timeline exercise. It replaces a vague fear with concrete evidence. In your lessons, encourage curiosity about Canadian expressions and customs rather than comparison ("in Brazil we..."). Comparison is natural, but curiosity is what accelerates learning.

**Key points**

- Immigration is usually not your first great change; it is the largest in a long series.
- Adaptable people keep their values and goals, and stay flexible about methods.
- You do not have to like every difference in Canada, but you do need to understand it.
- Treat unfamiliar English as data, not as failure.

# 18. Your Success Formula, in One Paragraph

> *When you can explain your success, you can repeat it.*

In the last seven lessons, we have looked at the reasons behind your results: discipline, learning methods, resilience, responsibility, performance under pressure, relationships and adaptability. Now it is time to bring them together.

This lesson asks you to write one paragraph. It is the most important paragraph in Part II, and possibly one of the most useful things you will write in Canada. It answers the question we began with in Lesson 10: *Why have you been successful?*

## Why one paragraph

A long list of strengths is easy to forget and hard to use. A single paragraph forces you to choose. It makes you decide which three or four qualities explain most of your success, and how they work together.

Once you have it, you can use it in many places:

- As the foundation of your answer to "Tell me about yourself."
- In cover letters and your LinkedIn summary.
- As a reminder on difficult days, when impostor syndrome tells you that your success was luck.
- As a guide for your English study: the traits that made you successful are the traits that will make you fluent.

## How to build it

Use this simple structure:

1. **Your track record in one sentence.** What have you achieved? Be specific: degrees, roles, results.
2. **Your three or four key traits.** Choose from the lessons in Part II, or add your own.
3. **One short example for the strongest trait,** with a number if possible. Evidence makes the paragraph believable; a number makes it memorable.
4. **How these traits are working for you in Canada now.** This connects the past to the present.

Keep it between 80 and 120 words. Write it first in Portuguese if you wish, to find the ideas, then write it in English. Do not translate word for word. Write the English version in short, clear sentences.

> **Worked example: Mariana's success formula**
>
> *Mariana is the fictional composite we met in Lesson 9.*
>
> **First draft (too general):**
>
> "I am a hard-working person. I have a lot of experience and I am responsible and organized. I like to learn new things and I work well in teams. I think I can be successful in Canada."
>
> **Final version:**
>
> "For fifteen years, I worked as a financial analyst in São Paulo, where I built an 18-month forecast used by three departments and trained four new analysts. I've been successful mainly because of three things: discipline, a structured way of learning and attention to detail. When I noticed errors in our monthly reports, I introduced a checking routine that reduced them by about 70%. In Canada, I use the same habits: I

practise English every day on my commute, I prepare for interviews the way I prepared for exams, and I'm learning Canadian tax terms and accounting software one module at a time."

The first draft could describe almost anyone. The final version could only describe Mariana. That is the goal.

## Common mistakes

- **Being too modest.** "I was lucky" and "I just worked hard" are not explanations. Name the *how*.
- **Listing everything.** Ten strengths are less convincing than three with evidence.
- **No numbers.** "I trained new analysts" is good; "I trained four new analysts" is better. Quantify wherever you honestly can.
- **Staying in the past.** Always end with how the traits are working for you now.
- **Writing complex English.** Short, clear sentences sound more confident.

**From my lessons: reading it aloud**

*This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*

Gustavo, the finance manager we met in Lesson 10, resisted this exercise. "It feels like bragging," he said.

He wrote a first draft anyway. It was full of words like *maybe* and *I think* and *a little*. We removed them one at a time, and each time he read the paragraph aloud to me. By the fourth reading, his voice had changed. He was not louder, but he was steadier.

I told him, “Now I would hire you.” Gustavo laughed, but he copied the paragraph onto an index card and kept it in his wallet. It joined the card with his three reasons. He told me later that he read both in the car before every interview.

## Look in the mirror

1. Write your track record in one sentence.
2. Which three or four traits explain most of your success?
3. Choose your strongest trait and write one short example that proves it.
4. How are these traits helping you in Canada right now?
5. Combine your answers into one paragraph of 80 to 120 words. Then read it aloud three times.

## Say it in English

**Phrases for explaining your success**

- *"I've been successful mainly because of..."*
- *"The main reason for my results is..."*
- *"What has made the biggest difference in my career is..."*
- *"For example, when..."*
- *"I bring the same approach to..."*
- *"In Canada, I'm applying the same habits by..."*

**Model answer.** *"What would you say is the key to your success?"*

> *"I'd say it's a combination of discipline and a structured way of learning. I completed my MBA while working full time by studying every morning before work, and I still work that way. When I need to master something new, I break it into small modules and practise with real examples. That's exactly how I'm approaching English and Canadian accounting now."*

**Em português.** *Em time que está ganhando não se mexe* (literally, "you don't change a winning team"). In English: *If it ain't broke, don't fix it*. Your success formula is the winning team. Keep using it.

**Teacher's note**

This paragraph is an excellent writing assignment and an even better speaking one. Have students revise it over two or three lessons, removing hedging words and adding evidence. Then ask them to deliver it from memory. Watch for changes in posture and voice as they repeat

it; those changes are often the first visible sign that the student is beginning to believe their own story.

**Key points**

- Bring your success factors together into one paragraph of 80 to 120 words.
- Structure: track record, three or four traits, one example, how the traits are working now.
- Specific beats general. The paragraph should describe only you.
- Use it for interviews, cover letters, LinkedIn and difficult days.

PART III

# Your Biggest Challenges

> *Name the obstacle precisely, and it becomes a project.*

# 19. What Is Your Biggest Challenge, Really?

> *A vague problem feels enormous. A precise one feels like work.*

Ask a newcomer, "What is your biggest challenge?" and the first answer is almost always the same: *"English."* The second most common answer is *"Finding a job in my field."*

Both answers are true. Both are also too large to act on. "English" is not one challenge; it is dozens. "Finding a job" includes credentials, networks, interviews, résumés, confidence and timing. When a challenge is that big, it becomes a cloud of worry instead of a plan.

Part III of this book is about making your challenges precise. Not smaller, because some of them are genuinely hard, but precise enough that you can see where to push.

## The challenge behind the challenge

When I work with a student who says "English is my biggest challenge," I ask a series of follow-up questions:

- *In which situations* does English feel hardest? Meetings, phone calls, small talk, writing, interviews?
- *What exactly happens* in those moments? You do not understand? You understand but cannot answer quickly? You answer, but feel your answer sounds simple?
- *What does it cost you?* A missed opportunity? Embarrassment? Avoiding certain people or situations?
- *When was the last time* it happened? Describe the moment.

By the end, "English" has usually become something much more specific: *"I understand meetings, but I can't interrupt politely, so I never give my opinion."* Or: *"I panic on the phone because I can't see the person's face."* Or: *"I write well, but I avoid speaking because my accent embarrasses me."*

Each of these is a real challenge with a real solution. "English" is not.

## Three kinds of challenge

It helps to sort your challenges into three kinds:

| Kind | Example | What helps |
|---|---|---|
| **Skill** | Understanding fast speech | Practice, method, time |
| **System** | Credential recognition | Information, process, patience |
| **Mindset** | "I'm not good enough here" | Evidence, reflection, support |

Many challenges are a mix. Fear of phone calls, for example, is partly a listening skill and partly a mindset. But sorting them helps you choose the right response. You cannot fix a system problem with more confidence, and you cannot fix a mindset problem with more grammar exercises.

## The challenge you do not say aloud

There is often a deeper challenge underneath the ones people name first. It may be the fear that the move was a mistake. The worry that you are letting your family down. The feeling that you have become less important. These are harder to say, especially to a teacher.

You do not need to share them with anyone. But it is useful to name them for yourself, because unspoken challenges have a way of shaping decisions quietly. A student who is secretly afraid the move was a mistake may avoid applying for good jobs, because rejection would confirm the fear.

**From my lessons: “English” becomes three things**

*This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*

Carlos, 44, an IT project manager from Porto Alegre, wrote “English” as his biggest challenge in our first lesson. When I asked him to describe the last time English had been a problem, he told me about a team meeting at his new job in Ottawa.

“Everyone was talking. I had a good idea about the timeline. By the time I had the sentence ready in my head, they were on the next topic.”

We broke it down. His listening was good. His vocabulary was more than enough. The real challenges were three: speed of response, knowing how to enter a conversation and the habit of building complete sentences in his head before speaking.

“That’s not ‘English,’” he said. “That’s three things I can practise.”

## Look in the mirror

1. Write your biggest challenge in one or two words, as you would normally say it.
2. Now describe the last time it happened: where, with whom, what exactly went wrong?
3. Rewrite the challenge as one precise sentence.
4. Is it mainly a skill, system or mindset challenge, or a mix?
5. Is there a deeper challenge you have not said aloud? Write it here, for yourself only.

## Say it in English

**Describing a challenge precisely and professionally**

- *"The area I'm working on most right now is..."*
- *"Specifically, I find it difficult to..."*
- *"It happens mostly when..."*
- *"I've noticed that..."*
- *"To improve, I'm..."*
- *"I've already seen some progress in..."*

**Model answer.** *"What is your biggest weakness?"*

> *"I'd say it's speaking up quickly in fast-paced meetings in English. My understanding is strong, but sometimes the conversation moves on before I've finished preparing what I want to say. To improve, I've started preparing two or three key points before each meeting and practising short phrases to join the discussion. I've already noticed that I contribute much more often."*

**Em português.** *Dar nome aos bois* (literally, "to give names to the oxen"). In English: *to call a spade a spade*.

**Teacher's note**

When a student names "English" as their biggest challenge, do not accept it as the final answer. Ask about the last specific situation, and keep asking until the challenge becomes precise. You will often find that the student's real need is different from what the course was planning to teach, and adjusting to it accelerates progress dramatically.

**Key points**

- "English" and "finding a job" are too large to act on. Make your challenges precise.
- Ask: in which situations, what exactly happens, what does it cost, when did it last happen?
- Sort challenges into skill, system and mindset. Each needs a different response.
- Name the deeper, unspoken challenge for yourself; it quietly shapes your decisions.

# 20. When Your English Hides Your Intelligence

> *Your vocabulary is smaller in English. Your mind is not.*

This is one of the most painful experiences my students describe, and one of the most common. In Portuguese, they are articulate, precise and persuasive. They can explain a complex idea, tell a funny story, negotiate a difficult agreement. In English, they hear themselves speaking like someone much simpler than they are.

"I sound like a child." "People think I don't understand." "In meetings, they explain things to me very slowly." "I feel stupid."

None of these students are stupid. Their English is hiding their intelligence. That is a very different thing.

## Why it happens

When you speak a language you are still learning, your brain is doing two jobs at once: thinking about *what* to say and working hard on *how* to say it. Grammar, vocabulary, pronunciation and listening all take mental effort. Less of your attention is left for nuance, humour and complexity.

The result is predictable. You choose simpler ideas because they are easier to express. You avoid jokes. You agree instead of disagreeing, because disagreement needs careful language. You stay quiet in fast conversations. To other people, it can look as if you have less to say. To you, it can start to feel as if you *are* less.

## Why it matters

Language skills do affect professional outcomes. A Statistics Canada study of economic immigrants admitted through Express Entry between 2015 and 2018 found that tested listening, speaking, reading and writing skills were each positively associated with earnings in their first years in Canada. [3] The study covers that specific group, not every newcomer, but its message is clear: language is part of how professional knowledge turns into professional results.

That is a reason to practise seriously. It is not a reason to judge your intelligence by your English. Those are two separate things, and confusing them is one of the fastest routes to impostor syndrome.

## Canada will not teach you English by itself

Many of my students arrived believing that living in Canada would improve their English automatically. They imagined speaking English all day: at work, in shops, with neighbours. For some, that happened. For many, it did not.

How much English you speak in Canada depends largely on your job. An office role may give you meetings, emails and small talk every day. A night shift in a warehouse, a delivery route or a kitchen where many colleagues speak Portuguese or Spanish may give you very little. Some of my students spoke less English in their first year in Canada than they did in their English classes in Brazil.

That is why the English you bring matters so much. If you are still in Brazil, learn as much as you can before you leave, while you still have a professional income, a stable routine and family nearby to help. Every level you reach before you arrive is a level you will not have to reach later, while you are tired, working long hours and adjusting to a new country.

## How to let your intelligence show

You cannot become fluent overnight. But you can reduce the gap between what you think and what you can express:

- **Prepare your expertise in English first.** Learn to explain your professional field, your best projects and your opinions in English *before* you need them. Expertise is the area where your intelligence most needs to show, and it is also the most predictable vocabulary.
- **Use structure.** "There are two reasons. First... Second..." A clear structure makes simple sentences sound intelligent.
- **Say the complex idea simply.** "I don't think that will work, because the costs are too high in the first year" is simple English and sophisticated thinking.
- **Name what you are doing.** "My English is still developing, so let me explain this step by step." This signals that the limit is language, not understanding.
- **Write when it matters.** Follow a meeting with a short email that contains your full idea. Many newcomers write far better than they speak at first.

> **From my lessons: the slow explanation**
>
> *This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*
>
> Juliana, 41, had been a hospital pharmacist in Belo Horizonte, responsible for medication safety protocols. In Canada, while preparing for her licensing exams, she worked as a pharmacy assistant. One day a pharmacist explained a basic drug interaction to her, very slowly, as if she had never heard of it.

"I knew more about that interaction than he did," she told me. "But I couldn't say it fast enough."

We worked on a short explanation of her old role and three of the safety protocols she had designed, in clear, structured English. She practised it until she could deliver it calmly. A few weeks later, the opportunity came naturally: the same pharmacist asked about her background. She told him.

"He looked at me differently after that," she said. "Not because my English was perfect. Because finally he could see what I knew."

## Look in the mirror

1. In which situations do you feel your English hides your intelligence?
2. What do you do in those moments (stay quiet, simplify, agree, avoid)?
3. What are three things you know deeply in your professional field?
4. Can you explain each of them in clear English in under one minute? Which one needs work?
5. How have you been judging yourself because of your English? What would be a fairer judgment?

## Say it in English

**Showing your thinking clearly**

- *"There are two main reasons. First... Second..."*
- *"In my experience, the key issue is..."*
- *"Let me explain this step by step."*
- *"I'd see it a little differently. My concern is..."*
- *"In my previous role, I was responsible for exactly this kind of problem."*
- *"I'll send a short email with the details after the meeting."*

**Model answer.** *"Can you tell me about your background?"*

> *"Sure. I was a hospital pharmacist for twelve years in Brazil, and I was responsible for medication safety. I designed three protocols to reduce dispensing errors, including a double-check system for high-risk drugs. I'm now preparing for my licensing exams here, so this role is a great way to learn how Canadian pharmacies work in practice."*

**Em português.** *Me deu um branco* (literally, "it gave me a blank"). In English: *My mind went blank*.

**Falso amigo:** *actually* ≠ *atualmente*. *Actually* means *na verdade*. For *atualmente*, say *currently* or *at the moment*.

**Teacher's note**

Professionals with limited English are often treated, and begin to treat themselves, as less capable than they are. Prioritize “expertise English”: a student’s ability to explain their own field, projects and opinions clearly. It is predictable vocabulary, highly motivating to learn and the quickest way to let the person’s real intelligence show.

**Key points**

- Speaking a new language uses so much mental effort that it can hide your intelligence.
- Language affects professional outcomes, so practise seriously, but do not judge your mind by your English.
- Prepare your expertise in English first; use structure; say complex ideas simply.
- Name the limit as language, not understanding, and follow up in writing when it matters.
- Living in Canada does not guarantee English practice; that depends on your job. Learn as much as you can before you arrive.

# 21. Speed: The Conversation That Moves Too Fast

> *You do not need to be fast. You need to be in the conversation.*

When students describe what is hardest about English in Canada, one word appears again and again: *speed*. People speak quickly. They interrupt each other. They use expressions you have never studied. By the time you understand the question, someone else has answered it. By the time you have prepared your sentence, the topic has changed.

Speed is one of the most frustrating challenges because it makes you feel slower than you are. In Brazil, you may have been the person who responded first. Here, you may be the last.

## Two kinds of speed

There are two separate speed problems, and they need different solutions.

**Listening speed** is about understanding fast, natural speech: reduced forms ("gonna," "whaddya think"), linked words, accents, background noise and unfamiliar idioms.

**Response speed** is about producing an answer quickly enough to take part. This is usually the bigger problem for advanced learners. Many of my students understand nearly everything but still cannot join the conversation in time.

## Improving listening speed

Listening speed improves with exposure to *real* speech, not textbook recordings. Useful habits include:

- Listening to podcasts and videos made for native speakers, in your professional field, at normal speed.
- Using short clips: listen, write down what you hear, check the transcript, listen again.
- Paying attention to *chunks* (groups of words that are always said together) rather than individual words.
- Listening to a variety of accents. Canada is a multicultural country, and your colleagues will not all sound the same.

## Improving response speed

Response speed improves when you stop trying to build perfect sentences in your head. Here are the techniques that work best with my students:

1. **Start with a ready-made opener.** Phrases like *"That's a good point," "I agree, and..."* or *"Can I add something?"* give you a second or two to think while you are already speaking.
2. **Say the main idea first.** Put your conclusion at the start: *"I think we should wait. The reason is..."* If you are interrupted, the important part has already been said.
3. **Accept short answers.** Three short sentences said now are worth more than one perfect sentence said too late.
4. **Prepare before meetings.** Know the agenda, prepare two or three points and the phrases to introduce them.
5. **Signal that you want to speak.** A small gesture, leaning forward or a simple *"Sorry, just quickly..."* can open the door.

## A word about pauses

In some Canadian conversations, especially group discussions, there are very few pauses. People take turns quickly and may even overlap. This can feel rude to someone who is waiting politely for silence. It usually is not rude; it is simply a different rhythm. If you wait for a perfect pause, it may never come. Learning to enter the conversation politely but decisively is part of the skill.

**From my lessons: the main idea first**

*This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*

Carlos, the project manager from Lesson 19, decided to work on response speed. His habit was to build a complete, careful sentence in his head, with an introduction, the context and finally his opinion. By the time he reached the opinion, the meeting had moved on.

We changed the order. For two weeks, in every discussion in our lessons, he had to start with his conclusion in fewer than ten words, then explain. At first his answers felt abrupt to him. To me, they sounded confident.

At his next team meeting, when the timeline came up, he said, "I think we need two more weeks. The testing phase is too short." The project lead turned to him and said, "Tell me more." "It was the first time," Carlos told me, "that they waited for me."

## Look in the mirror

1. Is your main difficulty listening speed, response speed or both?
2. In which situations does speed affect you most?

3. What do you usually do when the conversation moves too fast?
4. Which two ready-made openers will you practise this week?
5. Before your next meeting or lesson, what two points could you prepare?

## Say it in English

**Joining a fast conversation**

- *"Sorry, can I just add something?"*
- *"Just quickly, on that point..."*
- *"I agree, and I'd add that..."*
- *"Going back to what you said about..."*
- *"Sorry, I missed the last part. Could you say it again?"*
- *"Before we move on, I have one quick comment."*

**Model answer.** *"How do you contribute in team meetings?"*

> *"I like to prepare beforehand. I read the agenda and note the two or three points where I can add the most value. During the meeting, I try to be concise: I say my main idea first and then give the reasons. I've*

> *found that short, clear contributions are usually the most useful for the team."*

**Em português.** *Pegar o bonde andando* (literally, "to catch the tram while it is moving"). In English: *to come in halfway through*. That is exactly how a fast meeting can feel at first.

**Teacher's note**

Separate listening speed from response speed when diagnosing a student. Many advanced learners need far more work on response speed: practise "main idea first" answers under gentle time pressure, and teach turn-taking phrases explicitly. Fast-paced discussions, where the student must interrupt politely to get a turn, are excellent preparation for real meetings.

**Key points**

- Speed has two parts: listening speed and response speed. Diagnose which one you need.
- Listening improves with real speech, short clips, chunks and varied accents.
- Response speed improves with openers, main idea first, short answers and preparation.
- Do not wait for the perfect pause. Learn to enter the conversation politely but decisively.

# 22. Credentials That Do Not Travel

> *Your degree did not lose its value at the border. It lost its recognition, and recognition can be earned.*

For many of my students, this is the challenge that hurts the most. They spent years earning degrees, licences and professional titles. They passed difficult exams. They built a reputation. Then they arrived in Canada and discovered that some of these credentials are not automatically recognized.

An engineer cannot call herself an engineer. A lawyer cannot practise law. A nurse, a doctor, a teacher or an accountant may need assessments, exams, additional courses or supervised experience before working in the same profession again.

This can feel like an erasure. It is important to understand exactly what it is, and what it is not.

## Recognition is not the same as value

Your education and experience are real. The knowledge in your head did not disappear when you crossed the border. What changed is that a Canadian employer or regulator may not yet be able to *verify* and *compare* what you know.

That is a system challenge, not a judgment of your worth. Keeping this distinction clear protects your confidence while you work through the process.

## Regulated and non-regulated occupations

The first step is to find out whether your occupation is **regulated** in the province or territory where you plan to work.

- In **regulated occupations** (for example many health professions, engineering, law, teaching and some trades), a regulatory body decides what credentials, exams, training and licences are required. The rules vary by profession and by province. [4]
- In the **skilled trades**, provinces and territories certify tradespeople, and many trades share a national standard called the Red Seal (see below).
- In **non-regulated occupations** (many roles in business, marketing, IT, administration and finance, for example), there is no licence requirement, and employers decide for themselves how to assess your education and experience.

Many newcomers lose months because they assume their profession is closed, or because they rely on advice from friends instead of the official process. Check early, with the official regulator.

## Skilled trades and the Red Seal

If your experience is in a skilled trade (electrician, welder, plumber, carpenter, heavy-duty mechanic, cook and many others), the system works differently, and often more clearly. Trades are certified by each province and territory, and in some provinces certain trades are *compulsory*: you cannot legally work in them without a certificate.

Many trades also have a national standard, the **Red Seal**. Tradespeople who pass the Red Seal exam receive a Red Seal endorsement on their provincial or territorial certificate, which is widely recognized by employers and makes it easier to work in other parts of Canada. In most provinces, experienced workers trained outside Canada can apply to have their hours and experience assessed and, if they qualify, challenge the certification exam without

repeating a full apprenticeship. The process, fees and required documents vary by province, so contact the apprenticeship authority where you live. [7]

This matters for more readers than you might think. Some of my students arrive with a trade. Others, after honest analysis, choose one as a *new direction*: a Brazilian engineer who becomes a certified electrician, or a manager who retrains as an industrial mechanic. A Red Seal trade can offer good pay, strong demand and a clear path, and your professional experience in planning, safety and leadership still counts.

## The barriers are real

The process is not easy, and it is fair to acknowledge that. Statistics Canada reported that among working-age immigrants who had applied to practise a regulated occupation using foreign credentials, 42.7% had received full recognition by the third quarter of 2024, and 34.0% had received partial recognition and needed additional courses or training. [2] These figures cover immigrants in general, not Brazilians specifically, but they show that recognition is often a process with several stages, not a single decision.

## Options, not one path

When credentials do not travel immediately, you usually have more options than it first appears:

- **Full recognition:** complete the regulator's process, even if it takes time.
- **Adjacent roles:** work in a related position that uses your knowledge while you complete the process (a foreign-trained engineer as a technologist, a lawyer in compliance or paralegal work, a physician in research or health administration).
- **Credential assessment for employers:** in non-regulated fields, an educational credential assessment can help employers understand your degree.

- **Strategic retraining:** a short Canadian program that adds local knowledge to your existing expertise.
- **A new direction:** sometimes, after honest analysis, a different career makes more sense, and your previous experience still gives you an advantage in it.

Each option has costs in time, money and energy. The right choice depends on your finances, your family and your goals. What matters is making the choice deliberately, with accurate information.

**From my lessons: the engineer who checked**

*This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*

Renata, 39, a civil engineer from Campinas with fourteen years of experience, had concluded within her first month in Canada that she would "never be an engineer again." A friend had told her the process took ten years.

I asked whether she had read the regulator's website herself. She had not. That week she did, and she found that the process in her province was long but clear: an academic assessment, an exam on professional practice and ethics, and documented work experience, some of which could come from Brazil.

It was not quick. It was not ten years either. While she worked through it, she took a job as a construction project coordinator, which counted as relevant experience and kept her in her industry. "My friend's story was true for my friend," she said. "It wasn't my story."

## Look in the mirror

1. List your degrees, licences and professional titles.
2. Is your occupation regulated in your province? Have you checked the official regulator yourself?
3. What do you believe about your credentials in Canada? Where did that belief come from?
4. Which options (full recognition, adjacent role, assessment, retraining, new direction) are realistic for you?
5. What is one piece of accurate information you need to find this week?

## Say it in English

**Explaining your credentials and process**

- *"I'm a licensed [profession] in Brazil, and I'm currently going through the licensing process here."*
- *"I've completed my credential assessment, and my degree was assessed as equivalent to..."*

- *"I'm working toward my [licence/designation], and I expect to complete it by..."*
- *"In the meantime, I'm looking for a role where I can use my experience in..."*
- *"I'm a certified [trade] in Brazil, and I'm preparing to challenge the Red Seal exam."*
- *"I have fourteen years of experience in..."*

**Model answer.** *"I see your degree is from Brazil. Are you licensed in Canada?"*

> *"Not yet. I'm a licensed civil engineer in Brazil with fourteen years of experience, and I'm currently going through the licensing process here. I've completed the academic assessment, and I'm preparing for the professional practice exam. In the meantime, I'm looking for a role in project coordination, where I can use my experience and continue building the experience the licensing process asks for."*

**Em português.** *Uma coisa de cada vez* (literally, "one thing at a time"). In English: *One step at a time*.

**Cuidado:** *I am graduated* ← *sou formado*. Say *I have a degree in engineering* or *I graduated in engineering*, not *I am graduated in engineering*.

**Teacher's note**

Students often absorb discouraging stories about credential recognition from their community. Encourage them to read the official regulator's requirements themselves, in English. It is excellent reading practice, and accurate information usually replaces vague fear with a concrete

process. Do not give licensing advice yourself; point students to the regulator.

**Key points**

- Your knowledge did not lose its value at the border; it lost automatic recognition.
- Find out whether your occupation is regulated, from the official regulator, early.
- The barriers are real, and recognition is often a process with several stages.
- You usually have options: full recognition, adjacent roles, assessment, retraining or a new direction. Choose deliberately.

# 23. The First Canadian Job

> *The first Canadian job is not the destination. It is the key that opens the next door.*

"Canadian experience." My students hear this phrase so often that it becomes a kind of bitter joke. *How can I get Canadian experience if nobody will give me a job without Canadian experience?*

The frustration is understandable, and it is backed by data. Statistics Canada found that among recent working-age immigrants who had difficulties finding work, 42.2% named a lack of Canadian job experience or references as a main difficulty. [2] That figure covers recent immigrants in general, not only Brazilians, but it matches what I hear from my students almost every week.

This lesson is about breaking that circle.

## What "Canadian experience" really means

When employers ask for Canadian experience, they are rarely asking whether you have worked inside Canada's borders. They are usually trying to reduce uncertainty. They want to know:

- Will this person understand how our workplace communicates?
- Can I check their work with someone I can call?
- Will they know local rules, tools and expectations?
- Will they fit into the team?

Once you see the question behind the question, you can answer it in other ways, even before you have a long Canadian work history.

## Ways to reduce the employer's uncertainty

- **References in Canada.** A supervisor from a bridge job, a volunteer coordinator or an instructor can speak about your reliability and communication. One good Canadian reference can make a large difference.
- **Volunteering in your field.** Even a few hours a week with a non-profit, using your professional skills, creates Canadian experience and a reference.
- **Short Canadian training.** A course or certificate shows that you know local standards, tools or terminology.
- **Translating your experience.** Describe your Brazilian roles using language Canadian employers recognize: results, scale, tools, team size. Explain the company if it is not well known in Canada.
- **Bridging programs and newcomer services.** Many communities offer employment programs for newcomers, mentoring and work placements. Eligibility depends on your status and location, so check the official Government of Canada eligibility rules and services directory. [5]

## The first job is a step

Many of my students accept a first job below their level. That is often a wise decision, as long as it has a purpose (Lesson 49 returns to this). The first Canadian job gives you references, local knowledge, workplace English and a professional network. It also gives you something less visible: proof to yourself that you can succeed here.

The mistake is to see the first job as a verdict on your value, or to stay in it so long that it becomes permanent without your deciding so. Treat it as a step, with a review date.

## "You are overqualified"

Many of my Brazilian students hear this sentence in interviews, often for roles one or two levels below the one they held in Brazil. On paper, the interviewer is right. A manager with fifteen years of experience is overqualified for a coordinator position.

But the paper does not show the whole picture. Without Canadian experience, local references and knowledge of Canadian standards, you are not yet fully qualified for the senior role either, at least in the employer's eyes. In some cases, the wiser strategy is to apply for a more junior position on purpose. It is easier to get, it gives you the Canadian experience that senior roles ask for, and a capable professional who proves themselves inside an organization can often move up faster than one who keeps applying from outside.

If you do apply below your level, answer the "overqualified" concern before the interviewer raises it. Explain why this role makes sense for you now, and show that you plan to stay, learn and grow.

> **From my lessons: the volunteer project**
>
> *This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*
>
> Eduardo, 36, had worked in human resources at a multinational in São Paulo for nine years. In Winnipeg, he had applied for more than a hundred HR positions without one interview. "When anyone answers at all, it's the same thing," he said. "Canadian experience."
>
> We looked at the question behind the question. Employers did not know whether he understood Canadian employment standards or how HR worked here. So he did two things. He took a short online course in Canadian employment law, and he volunteered six hours a week

helping a settlement organization organize its volunteer onboarding process.

Four months later, he had a Canadian reference who could describe his work in detail, a course on his résumé and a project he could talk about in interviews. His next application led to an interview, and the interviewer spent ten minutes asking about the volunteer project.

## Look in the mirror

1. How have you interpreted "Canadian experience" until now?
2. Which of the employer's uncertainties (communication, references, local knowledge, fit) could you reduce first?
3. Who could be your first Canadian reference? If no one yet, how could you create that relationship?
4. Is there a volunteer role or short course that would connect directly to your field?
5. If you already have a first job, what is its purpose, and when will you review it?

## Say it in English

**Bridging the "Canadian experience" gap**

- *"Although my experience is mostly in Brazil, it's directly relevant because..."*
- *"I worked for [company], which is one of the largest [industry] companies in Latin America."*
- *"Since arriving in Canada, I've been volunteering with..."*
- *"I recently completed a course on..., so I'm familiar with Canadian standards for..."*
- *"My supervisor at [organization] would be happy to provide a reference."*
- *"I know my background is more senior than this role. That's exactly why I want to start here: to learn how things are done in Canada and to prove myself."*

**Model answer.** *"I see you don't have much Canadian experience."*

> *"That's true. My professional experience is mainly from Brazil, where I worked in HR for nine years at a multinational with over two thousand employees. Since arriving, I've completed a course in Canadian employment standards, and I've been volunteering with a settlement organization, where I redesigned their onboarding process. My coordinator there can speak to my work. I'm confident I can apply the same skills here quickly."*

**Em português.** *Quem tem padrinho não morre pagão* (literally, "whoever has a godfather does not die unbaptized"). In English: *It's not what you know, it's who you know*. In Canada, the polite version of this is a good reference.

**Falso amigo:** *résumé* ≠ *resumo*. A *résumé* is your CV. A *resumo* is a *summary*.

**Teacher's note**

Help students rehearse a calm, confident answer to "You don't have Canadian experience." Many become defensive or apologetic. A strong answer acknowledges the fact, translates the foreign experience and offers Canadian evidence. Students who have prepared this answer often report that the question stops feeling like a rejection.

**Key points**

- Lack of Canadian experience is a common, real barrier, named by 42.2% of recent immigrants who had difficulties finding work.
- "Canadian experience" usually means the employer wants less uncertainty.
- Reduce it with references, volunteering, short training, clear translation of your experience and newcomer services.
- The first job is a step with a purpose, not a verdict on your value.

# 24. Fatigue: Working, Studying and Parenting at Once

> *Exhaustion is not a character flaw. It is a planning problem.*

There is a challenge my students rarely name in the first lesson, but it shows on their faces by week three: they are tired.

Look at a typical week. One partner works full time, sometimes in a physically demanding bridge job. The other studies at a college or university, often in English, sometimes at a graduate level. Both are parenting children who are adjusting to a new school and a new language. Both are managing the administration of a new life: banks, health cards, leases, immigration documents. Many are also supporting family in Brazil. And somewhere in that week, they are supposed to improve their English.

This is not a normal amount of work. It is two or three lives at once.

## Why hungry people burn out

In Lesson 6, I described the hunger that drives many of my students. It is one of their greatest strengths. But hungry, disciplined people are also the ones most likely to push past their limits, because they have always succeeded by working harder.

In Canada, that strategy has a ceiling. Extra hours are available, but energy is not unlimited. Tired people learn more slowly, remember less and speak with less confidence. A student who sleeps five hours a night will often make less progress in English than one who studies less but sleeps well.

## Signs to watch for

- Difficulty concentrating in lessons or at work.
- Forgetting words you knew well a month ago.
- Irritability with your partner or children.
- Feeling that English is getting *worse*, not better.
- Getting sick more often.
- Losing interest in things that used to give you energy.

These are not signs that you are weak. They are signals that the plan needs adjusting. If tiredness becomes persistent low mood, hopelessness or anxiety, speak to a doctor or a mental health professional. Newcomers often wait too long to ask for this kind of help.

## Managing energy, not just time

The answer is not to stop working hard. It is to manage energy as carefully as you manage time:

- **Protect sleep first.** It is the foundation of learning. Late-night study sessions often cost more than they give.
- **Use small pockets.** Ten minutes of listening on the bus is better than a two-hour session you are too tired to complete.
- **Combine goals.** Practise English while doing something you already do: podcasts while cooking, conversation while walking with a friend, reading your child's school notices aloud.
- **Plan as a couple.** Decide together who carries what this month, and review it. The couple strategy (Lesson 5) needs regular maintenance.
- **Schedule rest deliberately.** One evening a week with nothing planned is not laziness. It is maintenance.

- **Lower the bar temporarily.** During exam periods or busy seasons at work, reduce your English goal to a minimum, rather than dropping it entirely.

**From my lessons: the five-hour nights**

*This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*

Wagner, 43, worked days on a food-processing line in Guelph while his wife completed a master's degree. He had English lessons with me three evenings a week and studied after the children were asleep, often until one in the morning.

After two months, he told me he was getting worse. "I forget everything. Words I knew before, I can't find them."

We looked at his week together. He was sleeping about five hours a night. We changed one thing: no studying after eleven. Instead, he listened to a short English podcast during his commute and reviewed vocabulary for fifteen minutes during lunch.

His total study time went down slightly. Within a month, he said his memory had "come back." "In Brazil, I always solved problems with more hours," he said. "Here, I need to solve them with better hours."

## Look in the mirror

1. Describe your typical week: work, study, family, administration, support for others.
2. How many hours do you sleep on an average night?

3. Which signs of fatigue from this lesson do you recognize in yourself?
4. What is one change that would protect your energy this week?
5. If you live with a partner, when will you next review together who carries what?

## Say it in English

**Talking about workload and limits**

- *"I'm stretched quite thin at the moment."*
- *"I've got a lot on my plate right now."*
- *"I need to prioritize. What's most urgent?"*
- *"I'd like to do this properly, so could we move the deadline to...?"*
- *"I'm going to take the evening off and recharge."*
- *"I'm running on empty."*

**Model answer.** *"How do you manage a heavy workload?"*

> *"I prioritize carefully, and I've learned that managing energy is as important as managing time. When things get busy, I focus on the*

> *most important tasks first and communicate early if a deadline is at risk. Since moving to Canada, I've been balancing work, studies and family, so I've become very deliberate about planning my week."*

**Em português.** *Dar um passo maior que a perna* (literally, "to take a step bigger than your leg"). In English: *to bite off more than you can chew*.

**Teacher's note**

When a student's progress suddenly stalls or reverses, ask about sleep and workload before assuming a learning problem. Fatigue is one of the most common hidden causes of plateaus among working immigrant adults. Helping a student reduce their plan to something sustainable often restores progress faster than adding more practice.

**Key points**

- Many immigrant families are living two or three lives at once: work, study, parenting and administration.
- Hungry, disciplined people are the most likely to push past their limits.
- Tired brains learn more slowly. Protect sleep first.
- Manage energy: small pockets, combined goals, couple planning, scheduled rest and temporary lower goals.

# 25. Distance: Family, Friends and the People You Left

> *You can miss home deeply and still be in the right place.*

Every immigrant carries two maps: the map of the place where they live, and the map of the people they left behind. Parents getting older. Brothers and sisters celebrating birthdays without you. Friends who know you completely, now in a different time zone. A favourite café, a street, a beach, a way of laughing.

My students rarely bring this up at the beginning of a course. But it is always there, and it affects their energy, their concentration and sometimes their decisions.

## The weight of distance

Distance becomes heaviest at certain moments: when a parent is ill, when you miss a wedding or a funeral, during the holidays, in the long dark of the first winter. In these moments, many students question the whole decision. *What am I doing here? Was it worth it?*

These questions are normal. They do not mean that you made a mistake. They mean that you love people who are far away, and that what you gave up was real.

## Saudade

Portuguese has a word for this feeling, and English has no single word that matches it: *saudade*. It is the longing for someone or something you love that is absent, a sadness that also contains affection and memory. English speakers

sometimes say *I miss you* or *I'm homesick*, but neither carries the full weight of *saudade*. If you feel it, you are not failing to adapt. You are carrying love across a distance. When you explain it to Canadian friends, you may find that they understand the feeling even without the word.

## Guilt

For many of my students, distance also brings guilt. Guilt for not being there to help an ageing parent. Guilt for taking grandchildren away from grandparents. Guilt for "having it easier" than the people who stayed, even when life in Canada is not easy at all.

Guilt can be useful when it points to a specific action: calling more often, planning a visit, supporting a sibling who is doing the caring. It becomes harmful when it turns into a constant background feeling that steals your energy without changing anything. A useful question is: *Is there something concrete I can do about this, this month?* If yes, do it. If no, the guilt is not helping anyone.

## Staying connected without staying behind

Technology makes it possible to stay very close to home. You can call every day, follow every conversation in the family group and watch Brazilian television every night. This is a great comfort. It can also, without your noticing, keep half of your life in Brazil, and leave less of you available for building a life in Canada.

The goal is not to reduce your love for home. It is to find a balance: strong connection with the people who matter, and enough presence here to build new relationships, new routines and new English.

Some practical ideas:

- **Schedule your calls,** so that they are something to look forward to rather than a constant interruption.
- **Share your new life with your family.** Send photos, describe your progress. It helps them understand, and it helps you notice how much you have achieved.
- **Build a "local family."** Friends, neighbours and colleagues who can be with you on difficult days.
- **Keep the traditions that matter,** and invite new friends to share them.

**From my lessons: the Sunday call**

*This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*

Sônia, 50, had moved to Halifax with her husband and youngest son. Her mother, 82, lived in Salvador with Sônia's sister. Sônia called every day, often twice, and felt guilty whenever she did not.

In our lessons, she seemed distracted, often checking her phone. One day she told me that her sister had said, gently, "Mamãe is fine. You need to live there too."

Sônia and her sister made a new plan: a long video call every Sunday with the whole family, short messages during the week and a promise that the sister would call immediately if anything changed. Sônia also used part of her new free time to join a walking group in her neighbourhood.

"I thought calling less would mean loving less," she said. "It just means I can be in two places properly, instead of half in each."

## Look in the mirror

1. Who do you miss most? What do you miss about them?
2. When is distance hardest for you?
3. Do you carry guilt about being far away? Is there a specific action that guilt is pointing to?
4. How much of your daily time and attention is in Brazil, and how much is in Canada?
5. Who is part of your "local family," or who could become part of it?

## Say it in English

**Talking about home and family**

- *"Most of my family is still in Brazil."*
- *"I miss them a lot, especially during the holidays."*
- *"We video-call every weekend."*
- *"It's been an adjustment, but we're building a good life here."*
- *"I'm planning to visit next year."*

- *"I've made some great friends here, too."*

**Model answer.** *"Do you have family here in Canada?"*

> *"My husband and youngest son are here with me, and my mother and sister are in Salvador, in the Northeast of Brazil. I miss them, especially during the holidays, but we have a family video call every Sunday, and I'm planning to visit next summer. We've also met some wonderful people here, so it's starting to feel like home."*

**Em português.** *Longe dos olhos, perto do coração* (literally, "far from the eyes, close to the heart"). In English: *Absence makes the heart grow fonder*. An affectionate twist on the traditional proverb *longe dos olhos, longe do coração* (out of sight, out of mind).

**Teacher's note**

Homesickness and family worries often explain a sudden drop in a student's concentration. A brief, private, respectful question ("Is everything okay at home?") is usually appreciated. Conversations about family are also excellent practice in emotional vocabulary, which many advanced learners have never been taught.

**Key points**

- Distance is part of every immigrant story, and it is heaviest at particular moments.
- Questioning the decision in difficult moments is normal; it does not mean the decision was wrong.
- Guilt is useful only when it points to a specific action.

- Stay connected to home without leaving half your life there: schedule calls, share your progress and build a local family.

# 26. Turning a Challenge Into a Plan

> *Ambition becomes more effective when you can see the next step.*

In this part of the book, we have looked at the biggest challenges my students face: English that hides their intelligence, conversations that move too fast, credentials that do not travel, the first Canadian job, fatigue and distance. Each of these is real. None of them is solved by worry.

This lesson gives you a simple tool to turn any challenge into a plan. It is not complicated. Its value comes from using it consistently.

## Effort is not the same as strategy

A strong work ethic keeps you moving. It does not, by itself, tell you which direction to take. Many newcomers spend enormous energy applying for jobs, taking courses and practising English without checking whether those activities are moving them toward their goals.

The solution is not to plan every detail of the next five years. It is to build a system that tells you, regularly, what is working and what is not.

## The six-question map

For any challenge, answer these six questions:

1. **Destination.** What specific result are you working toward? (A role, a qualification, a level of English, a kind of life.)
2. **Current position.** What can you already do? What evidence supports that?
3. **Gap.** What, precisely, is preventing progress right now?

4. **Next action.** What is the smallest meaningful step you can take this week?
5. **Feedback.** Who or what will tell you whether that step is working?
6. **Review date.** When will you look at the results and adjust?

The last two questions are the ones most people skip. Without feedback and a review date, a plan becomes a wish.

**Worked example: Carlos's map**

*Carlos is the project manager we met in Lessons 19 and 21.*

| Question | Carlos's answer |
|---|---|
| Destination | Contribute confidently in English team meetings within three months |
| Current position | Understands nearly everything; strong technical vocabulary; contributes about once a month |
| Gap | Slow response; builds full sentences before speaking; does not know how to enter the conversation |
| Next action | Prepare two points before every meeting; use one opener and "main idea first" at least once per meeting |
| Feedback | Count contributions each week; ask his manager for one comment after a month |
| Review date | Last Friday of every month |

After one month, Carlos was contributing in most meetings. His manager's comment ("Your input on the testing schedule was really valuable") became one of the most motivating sentences of his first year in Canada.

## Small enough to start, specific enough to measure

Two common mistakes make plans fail.

The first is a **next action that is too big.** "Improve my English" is not an action. "Listen to one ten-minute podcast in my field every weekday and write three new expressions" is. If you cannot start the action this week, it is too big.

The second is a **destination that cannot be measured.** "Be more confident" is a feeling, not a result. "Speak at least once in every meeting" or "complete the licensing exam by June" can be measured. Confidence usually follows measurable progress.

## Review without judgment

When you reach your review date, look at the results like a professional reviewing a project, not like a judge sentencing a defendant. If the plan did not work, that is information. Change the action, the timing or the feedback, and try again. Lesson 30 looks more closely at separating facts from feelings in exactly these moments.

> **From my lessons: the map on the fridge**
>
> *This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*
>
> Renata, the engineer from Lesson 22, wrote a six-question map for her licensing process and taped it to the refrigerator. Her husband wrote his own map next to it, for his goal of moving from a warehouse job into logistics coordination.
>
> Every second Sunday, they reviewed both maps together over coffee. Some weeks the review took five minutes. Some weeks it led to difficult conversations about money and time. "It stopped us from arguing

about vague things," Renata said. "We argued about the map instead, and the map could be fixed."

## Look in the mirror

1. Choose the most important challenge from Part III for you right now.
2. Answer the six questions for that challenge.
3. Is your next action small enough to start this week? If not, make it smaller.
4. Is your destination measurable? If not, rewrite it.
5. Write your review date in your calendar now.

## Say it in English

**Talking about goals and plans**

- *"My goal is to... by..."*
- *"Right now, the main gap is..."*

- *"The next step is..."*
- *"I'm tracking my progress by..."*
- *"I review my plan every month and adjust it."*
- *"That approach didn't work, so I changed it to..."*

**Model answer.** *"Where do you see yourself in five years?"*

> *"My goal is to be working as a licensed civil engineer here, ideally leading infrastructure projects. Right now, I'm completing the licensing process, and I'm working as a project coordinator to build Canadian experience. I keep a simple plan with clear steps and review it every month, so I know I'm moving in the right direction."*

**Em português.** *Para quem não sabe aonde vai, qualquer caminho serve*. In English: *If you don't know where you're going, any road will take you there*.

**Falso amigo:** *eventually* ≠ *eventualmente*. *Eventually* means *no fim* or *mais cedo ou mais tarde*. For *eventualmente*, say *occasionally* or *possibly*.

**Teacher's note**

The six-question map works well as a monthly activity. Students write it in English, share it with you or a study partner and review it a month later. It is useful language practice (future forms, time expressions, cause and effect) and it gives the teacher a clear view of each student's goals and obstacles, which makes it easier to tailor the course.

**Key points**

- Effort keeps you moving; strategy tells you which direction to take.

- Use the six-question map: destination, current position, gap, next action, feedback, review date.
- Make the next action small enough to start this week and the destination measurable.
- Review results like a professional, not like a judge. A plan that did not work is information.

PART IV

# What You Have Learned About Yourself

> *Immigration is the most honest mirror you will ever look into.*

# 27. What Have You Learned About Yourself?

> *Immigration is the most honest mirror you will ever look into.*

At home, you are surrounded by things that tell you who you are: your job title, your family, your friends, your language, your neighbourhood, your reputation. You rarely have to ask the question, because the answer is all around you.

Immigration removes most of those signals at once. Suddenly nobody knows your history. Your title is gone, at least for now. You are speaking a language in which you cannot yet be fully yourself. In that empty space, you see things about yourself that were invisible before, some uncomfortable and some surprising.

This part of the book is about those discoveries.

## What the mirror shows

When I ask my students, after their first year in Canada, "What have you learned about yourself?", the answers fall into a few groups.

**Strengths they did not know they had.** "I'm braver than I thought." "I can live with much less than I imagined." "I'm good at starting over."

**Weaknesses that were hidden by structure.** "In Brazil, I needed my title to feel confident." "I didn't realize how much I depended on my family." "I'm more afraid of failure than I admitted."

**Values that became clearer.** "I realized what really matters to me is time with my children." "I discovered that I care more about meaningful work than status."

**Patterns in how they react to difficulty.** "When I'm stressed, I isolate myself." "I always try to solve everything alone." "I become very critical of myself."

Each kind of discovery is valuable. Strengths become resources. Hidden weaknesses become areas to work on. Clearer values help you make decisions. And once you know your patterns under stress, you can catch them early.

## Why self-knowledge accelerates English

This may seem like a long way from learning English. It is not.

In my experience, the students who progress fastest are not always the ones with the best grammar at the start. They are the ones who understand themselves well enough to know *why* they get stuck: the student who knows she stops speaking when she feels judged; the student who knows he avoids phone calls because he fears looking foolish; the student who knows she studies best early in the morning.

Self-knowledge lets you design your learning around who you really are, instead of fighting against yourself. That is why the teacher's job, and your own, includes watching the mindset as well as the language.

## The difference between reflection and rumination

There is a healthy and an unhealthy way to look in the mirror.

**Reflection** asks: *What happened? What did I learn? What will I do differently?* It moves toward action.

**Rumination** repeats: *Why am I like this? Why did I fail? What is wrong with me?* It goes in circles and leaves you feeling worse.

The lessons in this part are designed for reflection. If you notice yourself sliding into rumination, stop, and ask the reflection questions instead. If rumination becomes constant, talk to someone you trust or a professional.

**From my lessons: the list of surprises**

*This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*

Beatriz, 37, had been a marketing manager in São Paulo. A year after she arrived in Montreal, I asked her to write a list titled "Things I have learned about myself in Canada."

She wrote quickly, then stopped and laughed. Her list included: *I can fix a bicycle. I can handle minus thirty. I can make friends in a language that is not mine. I was more attached to my title than I wanted to admit. I am happier with less.*

"The last one surprised me most," she said. "In Brazil, I thought I needed everything I had. Here I discovered which things I actually needed."

She later used two items from the list in a job interview, when she was asked what the move had taught her.

## Look in the mirror

1. What strength have you discovered in yourself since moving to Canada?
2. What weakness was hidden by the structure of your old life?
3. What value has become clearer to you?

4. How do you typically react when things are difficult? What is your pattern?
5. Write a list titled "Things I have learned about myself in Canada." Aim for at least eight items.

## Say it in English

**Talking about personal growth**

- *"Moving to Canada has taught me that..."*
- *"I've discovered that I'm more... than I thought."*
- *"I've realized that what really matters to me is..."*
- *"I've learned to..."*
- *"One thing I'm working on is..."*
- *"Looking back, I can see that..."*

**Model answer.** *"What has the experience of immigrating taught you?"*

> *"It's taught me a lot about myself. I've discovered that I'm much more adaptable than I thought, and that I can build relationships in a language that isn't my first. I've also realized that I was quite attached*

> *to my job title in Brazil. Starting over has made me focus on the work itself, and I think that's made me a better professional."*

**Em português.** *Caiu a ficha* (literally, "the token dropped"). In English: *The penny dropped; it finally sank in*.

**Teacher's note**

Reflection activities are powerful but should stay focused on learning and action. If a student begins to ruminate or becomes distressed, gently redirect to the questions "What did you learn?" and "What will you do next?" Students who understand their own patterns, such as avoidance, perfectionism or isolation, can often be helped to design practice that works with those patterns rather than against them.

**Key points**

- Immigration removes the signals that tell you who you are, and shows you things that were invisible before.
- Discoveries include strengths, hidden weaknesses, clearer values and patterns under stress.
- Self-knowledge accelerates English, because you can design learning around who you really are.
- Reflect, do not ruminate: ask what you learned and what you will do differently.

# 28. Impostor Syndrome: How It Creeps In

> *Impostor syndrome rarely arrives on the first day. It arrives slowly, one small doubt at a time.*

When my students first arrive in Canada, most of them are confident. They have succeeded before, and they plan to succeed again. The hunger is strong. The plan is clear.

Then, gradually, something changes. It does not happen in one dramatic moment. It creeps in.

A few months of rejections. A meeting where nobody understood you. A comment about your accent. A job where nobody asks about your experience. Weeks of feeling slower than everyone else. Each moment is small. Together, they build a new and quiet belief: *Maybe I was never as good as I thought. Maybe my success in Brazil was luck. Maybe I don't belong here.*

That is impostor syndrome: the persistent feeling that you are less capable than others believe, or less capable than your record shows, and that sooner or later you will be "found out."

Brazilians have their own name for a version of this feeling. In the 1950s, the writer and journalist Nelson Rodrigues called it *complexo de vira-lata*, the *mongrel complex*: a habit of assuming that what comes from Brazil is second-rate and that the real standard is always somewhere else. Many of my students recognize it immediately. In a new country, the mongrel complex and impostor syndrome reinforce each other. *My degree is from Brazil, so it probably doesn't count. My experience was in Brazil, so it probably wasn't real experience.* Naming the pattern is the first step in refusing it.

## Why immigrants are especially vulnerable

Impostor syndrome affects many high-achieving people in every country. But immigration creates particularly good conditions for it:

- **Your evidence is far away.** Your colleagues, clients and achievements are in Brazil. Nobody here has seen them.
- **Language hides your competence.** As we saw in Lesson 20, people may underestimate you, and you may begin to agree with them.
- **You are working below your level.** It is easy to start seeing yourself as the role you are in now, rather than the professional you are.
- **Everything is new.** In a new system, everyone makes mistakes. But when you are new, each mistake feels like proof that you do not belong.
- **Comparison.** You compare yourself with Canadian-born colleagues who have advantages you do not, and with other immigrants who seem to be progressing faster.

## How to recognize it

Impostor syndrome often disguises itself as modesty or realism. Watch for thoughts like:

- *"I was lucky in Brazil."*
- *"Anyone could have done what I did."* (Lesson 29 looks closely at this one.)
- *"They only hired me because they needed someone quickly."*
- *"I shouldn't apply. I'm not qualified enough."*
- *"If I speak up, they'll see I don't really know."*

And watch for behaviours: not applying for jobs you could do, staying silent in meetings, over-preparing for simple tasks, refusing compliments, working much harder than necessary to "prove" yourself.

## The cost

Impostor syndrome is not only uncomfortable. It has practical consequences. People who feel like impostors apply for fewer jobs, negotiate less, speak less in meetings and take fewer risks. In English learning, it makes students avoid the very conversations they need. Over months, it can turn a temporary situation into a permanent one.

That is why it is worth naming and confronting directly.

> **From my lessons: the job she did not apply for**
>
> *This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*
>
> Vanessa, 44, had been a finance director for a regional bank in Recife. After two years in Ottawa, working as an accounts payable clerk, she showed me a job posting for a financial analyst. She met every requirement.
>
> "I'm not going to apply," she said. "I'm not at that level anymore."
>
> I asked her what had changed in her abilities in the last two years. She thought for a long time. "Nothing," she said finally. "I just stopped believing it."
>
> We went through the posting line by line, and for each requirement she wrote one example from her career. When she finished, the page was full. She applied that evening. She did not get that position, but she was invited to interview for another analyst role at the same organization two months later, and she got that one.

## Look in the mirror

1. Have you felt impostor syndrome since moving to Canada? When did you first notice it?
2. Which of the impostor thoughts in this lesson have you had?
3. Which behaviours (not applying, staying silent, over-preparing, refusing compliments) do you recognize?
4. What has impostor syndrome already cost you?
5. Has your ability actually changed, or only your belief about it?

## Say it in English

**Replacing impostor language with accurate language**

| Impostor language | Accurate language |
|---|---|
| "I was just lucky." | "I worked hard and made good decisions." |
| "I'm not really qualified." | "I meet the main requirements, and I can learn the rest." |
| "It was nothing special." | "I'm proud of what we achieved." |
| "I only helped a little." | "I was responsible for..." |

**Model answer.** *"Why do you think you're a good fit for this role?"*

> *"I meet all of the main requirements. I have fifteen years of experience in financial analysis and reporting, including eight years as a finance director, and in my current role I've learned Canadian accounts payable processes and our ERP system. I'm confident I can add value quickly, and I'm very motivated to grow with your team."*

**Em português.** *Complexo de vira-lata* (literally, "mongrel complex"). There is no exact English equivalent; the closest is *an inferiority complex*.

**Teacher's note**

Impostor syndrome is often visible in lessons before the student names it: refusing compliments, apologizing before speaking, or saying "my English is terrible" when it is not. Name it gently and normalize it: many successful professionals experience it. Then return the student to evidence. The more specific the evidence, the less power the feeling has.

**Key points**

- Impostor syndrome usually creeps in slowly, through many small experiences.
- Immigration creates ideal conditions: distant evidence, hidden competence, lower roles, constant newness and comparison.
- It disguises itself as modesty or realism. Watch both your thoughts and your behaviours.
- It has real costs: fewer applications, less speaking, fewer risks. Name it and return to evidence.

# 29. “Anyone Could Have Done It”

> *The most dangerous thing you can do with your track record is forget it.*

I hear the sentence from almost every student, usually in a quiet voice and often with a small shrug. A student describes something remarkable. She led a team through a company merger, finished a master’s degree while raising two children, or rebuilt a department after a failed project. Then she adds the line that erases it: *“But anyone could have done it.”*

It sounds like modesty, and partly it is. But in my experience it is something more dangerous. It is a habit of discounting your own track record, and in a new country, where nobody else knows your history, it can quietly take away the very evidence you need.

## Why capable people discount themselves

The strange thing is that the people most likely to say “anyone could have done it” are usually the ones who did the hardest things. There are a few reasons for this.

**First, you only see the work from the inside.** When you have done something many times, it feels ordinary. An experienced project manager no longer notices the hundred small decisions she makes in a single meeting. She remembers that it was tiring; she forgets that it was skilled. The skill has become invisible to its owner.

**Second, you compare yourself with the wrong people.** In a competitive corporate environment, you were surrounded by other strong performers. Next to them, your achievement looked normal. But “normal among high achievers” is not the same as normal.

**Third, the circumstances disappear from the memory.** You remember the result, not the conditions. You forget that you finished the degree while working full time, that the budget was cut halfway through the project, that you were the only person who stayed late to fix the error. Those conditions are what made the achievement difficult, and they are exactly what you leave out.

**Fourth, immigration changes the scale.** In Canada, everyday tasks suddenly require enormous effort: a phone call to the bank, a parent–teacher meeting, a job interview in a second language. When small things feel hard, your past achievements can start to feel unreal, as if they belonged to someone else.

## Why it matters more in Canada

In Brazil, your reputation could speak for you. Colleagues had seen your work. A manager could call a former boss. Your track record existed outside your own head.

In Canada, for a while, it exists *only* in your head and in the way you describe it. If you discount it, nobody else will correct you. An interviewer will not say, "Wait, that sounds impressive. Tell me more." They will simply take your word for it that it was nothing special.

This is why I tell my students that modesty and accuracy are not the same thing. Modesty is a social choice about how loudly you speak. Accuracy is about whether what you say is true. You can be modest in tone and still be accurate in content. What you cannot afford is to be *inaccurate*, to describe a difficult achievement as if it were easy.

> **From my lessons: the merger nobody mentioned**

*This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*

Ricardo was 44, an operations director from Belo Horizonte, now working the night shift in a warehouse in Mississauga while his wife completed a college program. In our first lessons, he was polite, prepared and quiet. When I asked about his career, he said, "I managed some logistics. Nothing special."

Weeks later, during a speaking exercise about difficult decisions, he mentioned, almost by accident, that his company had merged with a competitor. I asked what his role had been. He paused. He had combined two distribution networks, closed three warehouses, moved 140 people into new roles and kept deliveries running throughout. Customer complaints, he said, had actually gone down.

"Anyone in my position would have done the same," he added.

I asked him one question: "How many people in your company were given that job?" He laughed. "Only me."

We spent the next lesson turning that merger into a two-minute story in English. Ricardo's grammar did not change that week. What changed was his posture. He sat up when he told it. A month later, he used the story in an interview for a supervisor role, and the interviewer asked three follow-up questions about it. He did not get that particular job, but he left the room, he told me, "feeling like myself again."

## The difference between "anyone could" and "anyone did"

Here is a simple test I give my students. When you catch yourself saying "anyone could have done it," change one word and ask: **did anyone else actually do it?**

- Could anyone have finished that degree at night? Perhaps. Did your classmates who dropped out do it? No.
- Could anyone have managed the merger? Maybe. Were they asked to? No. You were.
- Could anyone have moved to another country at forty with two children? Many could. Most never do.

"Anyone could" is a guess about other people. "I did" is a fact about you. Build your story on facts.

## Count it

There is a second test, and it is often even more powerful: **count it.** When a student tells me that something was "nothing special," I ask four questions:

- How many people did it affect?
- How much money was involved?
- How long did it take, and how much time did it save?
- How many other people were given the chance to do it?

Something changes when the numbers appear. Ricardo's "some logistics" became *two distribution networks combined, three warehouses closed and 140 people moved into new roles, with deliveries running throughout*. It is very difficult to say "anyone could have done it" about a sentence like that, and that is exactly the point. Counting is not boasting. It is measuring. And until you measure your impact, you cannot see it clearly yourself.

## Look in the mirror

Take your time with these. Write your answers in full sentences, in English if you can.

1. What is one achievement you usually describe as "nothing special"? Describe it again, this time including the conditions: the time pressure, the resources you lacked, the responsibilities you carried.
2. Who else had the opportunity to do what you did? How many actually did it?
3. What would a former colleague or manager say about this achievement if someone called them today?
4. Which skill did this achievement require that you no longer notice because you use it so often?
5. Write one sentence about this achievement that is modest in tone but accurate in content.

## Say it in English

**Describing an achievement accurately, without bragging**

- *"One thing I'm proud of is..."*
- *"It was a challenging situation because..."*
- *"I was responsible for..., which involved..."*
- *"The result was..."* (Use a number if you can.)
- *"What I learned from that was..."*
- *"I wasn't working alone, but my part was..."*
- Instead of *"It was nothing special"* → *"It was a lot of work, and I'm glad it went well."*
- Instead of *"Anyone could have done it"* → *"It required careful planning, and I enjoyed the challenge."*

**Model answer.** *Interviewer: "Tell me about a big project you managed."*

> *"In my last company in Brazil, we merged with a competitor, and I was responsible for combining our two distribution networks. It was challenging because we had to close three warehouses and move about 140 people into new roles without stopping deliveries. I planned the changes in stages and met with each team leader every week. In the end, deliveries continued without interruption, and customer complaints actually went down. What I learned is that good communication matters as much as a good plan."*

Notice that the answer never says "I am an excellent manager." It lets the facts say it.

**Em português.** *Se subestimar* (literally, "to underestimate yourself"). In English: *to sell yourself short*.

**Teacher's note**

Listen for minimizing language: *just*, *only*, *nothing special*, *anyone could*. When you hear it, do not argue or offer praise. Ask a factual question instead: "How many people were there? How long did it take? Who else was asked to do it?" Facts restore the achievement more effectively than compliments, and the student practises exactly the English they will need in an interview.

**Key points**

- Count it: people, money, time and how many others had the chance. Numbers make your impact visible, first of all to you.
- Capable people often discount the hardest things they have done, because skill becomes invisible to its owner.
- In Canada, your track record exists only in the way you describe it, at least at first.
- Modesty is about tone; accuracy is about content. Be modest if you like, but always be accurate.
- Replace "anyone could have done it" with a fact: "I did it, under these conditions, with this result."

# 30. The Harsh Verdict: Separating Facts From Feelings

> *A rejection is a fact. "I am not good enough" is a verdict. Learn to tell them apart.*

Something happens. You do not get the job. A colleague looks confused when you speak. Your test score is lower than you expected. Within seconds, your mind delivers a verdict: *I'm not good enough. My English will never be good. I made a mistake coming here.*

The event takes a moment. The verdict can last for weeks.

Many high-achieving people are very hard on themselves. In their old lives, that harshness may even have helped: high standards pushed them to do better. But in a new country, where setbacks are frequent and normal, a harsh inner judge can become exhausting and destructive.

## Facts, interpretations and verdicts

It helps to separate three things:

- **The fact:** what actually happened, as a camera would record it.
- **The interpretation:** what you think it means.
- **The verdict:** the conclusion you draw about yourself.

For example:

| Fact | Interpretation | Verdict |
|---|---|---|
| I didn't get the job after the second interview. | They chose someone better. | I'm not good enough for jobs here. |

| Fact | Interpretation | Verdict |
|---|---|---|
| My manager asked me to repeat my point. | She didn't understand my accent. | My English is terrible. |
| My test score went down this month. | I'm getting worse. | I'll never be fluent. |

Notice how far the verdict travels from the fact. The fact is limited and specific. The verdict is total and permanent.

## Questioning the verdict

When you notice a harsh verdict, try these questions:

1. **What exactly happened?** Write only the fact.
2. **What other interpretations are possible?** Perhaps the other candidate had an internal referral. Perhaps the room was noisy. Perhaps the test was on a topic you have not studied.
3. **What evidence do I have against the verdict?** Other interviews that went well, conversations where you were understood, past progress.
4. **What would I say to a friend in this situation?** Most people are far kinder and more accurate with friends than with themselves.
5. **What is one useful action?** Ask for feedback. Practise the specific skill. Rest.

This is not about pretending everything is fine. Sometimes the fact *does* show something you need to work on. The point is to respond to the real fact, not to an exaggerated verdict.

## Feelings are real, but they are not evidence

Disappointment, embarrassment and frustration are real and natural. You do not need to suppress them. Feel them, and give them some time.

But a feeling is not evidence. Feeling like a failure does not make you one. Feeling that your English is terrible does not make it terrible. The professional habit of checking data before drawing conclusions, which many of my students used every day in their careers, is exactly the habit needed here.

**From my lessons: the three columns**

*This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*

Roberto, 48, had been an internal auditor at a mining company in Belo Horizonte. Living in Edmonton, he arrived at our lesson one evening looking defeated. He had received an email rejecting his application for an audit position after a final interview.

"I'm too old, my English is not good enough and I should accept that this career is finished," he said.

I drew three columns on our shared screen: *Fact, Interpretation, Verdict.* He was an auditor; he understood the exercise immediately. The fact was one email from one company. The interpretation was a guess. The verdict was a conclusion based on a single data point.

"If one of my junior auditors drew that conclusion from one sample," he said slowly, "I would send the report back."

The next day, he wrote to the hiring manager, thanked her and asked for feedback. She replied that the other candidate had specific experience with a software system the team used. Roberto found a short course in that system. The feedback said nothing about his age or his English.

## Look in the mirror

1. Think of a recent setback. Write the fact, your interpretation and your verdict.
2. What other interpretations are possible?
3. What evidence do you have against the verdict?
4. What would you say to a friend in the same situation?
5. What is one useful action you could take?

## Say it in English

**Responding professionally to setbacks**

- *"Thank you for letting me know. Would you be able to share any feedback?"*
- *"I'd appreciate any suggestions on how I could strengthen my application."*
- *"That didn't go the way I hoped, but I learned a lot."*
- *"Let me look at what actually happened."*
- *"One data point isn't a trend."*

- *"Next time, I'll..."*

**Model answer.** *"Tell me about a setback and what you learned from it."*

> *"After a final interview last year, I wasn't selected, so I asked the hiring manager for feedback. She told me the successful candidate had experience with a specific audit software package. I enrolled in a course the following week and completed the certification. I try to treat feedback as information, not as a judgment."*

**Em português.** *Tempestade em copo d'água* (literally, "a storm in a glass of water"). In English: *a tempest in a teapot; making a mountain out of a molehill*.

**Teacher's note**

Listen for verdict language in lessons: "I'm terrible at," "I'll never," "I always." Gently ask for the fact behind it. The fact/interpretation/verdict table works well as a short writing exercise and gives students practice with past tenses, modals of possibility ("It might have been...") and hedging, which are useful in professional English.

**Key points**

- Separate the fact, the interpretation and the verdict. The verdict usually travels far beyond the fact.
- Question harsh verdicts: other interpretations, counter-evidence, what you would tell a friend, one useful action.
- Feelings are real, but they are not evidence.

- Use the professional habit of checking data before drawing conclusions.

# 31. Pride and Humility Together

> *Humility without pride becomes self-erasure. Pride without humility stops you from learning.*

My students are humble. They take cleaning jobs, kitchen jobs and warehouse jobs. They study alongside people half their age. They accept correction. They start again. This humility, which we explored in Lesson 7, is one of their great strengths.

But I have also watched humility, over time, slide into something less healthy: a gradual erasure of pride in who they are and what they have done.

This lesson is about holding both at the same time.

## Two dangers

**Too little humility.** Some newcomers find it hard to accept a lower role or to learn from people with less experience. They compare everything with "how we did it in Brazil." They resist feedback. They may refuse jobs that could be useful steps. This kind of pride protects their identity in the short term, but it slows their progress.

**Too little pride.** More common among my students is the opposite. They accept the lower role so completely that they begin to believe it is who they are. They stop mentioning their background. They apologize constantly. They let others speak for them. This kind of humility looks admirable from the outside, but it slowly erodes their confidence and their future.

## What healthy pride looks like

Healthy pride is not arrogance. It is an accurate respect for what you have achieved and what you can do. It sounds like:

- *"I'm proud of my career in Brazil."*
- *"I know I'm good at this."*
- *"I'm learning, and I also have a lot to offer."*

It does not require you to tell everyone about your achievements. It requires *you* to remember them.

## What healthy humility looks like

Healthy humility is not self-erasure. It is openness to learning, respect for others' knowledge and the willingness to start where you need to start. It sounds like:

- *"I'm still learning how things work here."*
- *"Could you show me how you do it?"*
- *"Thank you, that's a helpful correction."*

## Holding both

The most effective newcomers I have taught hold both at the same time. They can wash dishes in the morning and think like a director in the afternoon. They can accept a correction from a 25-year-old supervisor and still know their own worth. They say, in effect: *"I'm new here, and I'm very capable."*

Both statements are true. Neither cancels the other.

> **From my lessons: the supervisor who was 24**

*This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*

Marcos, 51, had run his own construction company in Goiânia for twenty years. In Kelowna, he worked as a general labourer on a residential site. His supervisor was 24.

At first, Marcos found it very hard. "He tells me how to do things I was doing before he was born," he told me in a lesson, half joking.

Then, slowly, he noticed that the young supervisor knew things he did not: local building codes, the materials suppliers used here, how inspections worked. Marcos began asking questions. The supervisor, in turn, began asking Marcos for advice on scheduling and crew management.

After six months, Marcos was promoted to lead hand. "I learned the Canadian part from him," he told me. "He learned the experience part from me. Both of us were right to be proud, and both of us needed to listen."

## Look in the mirror

1. Which danger is closer to you right now: too little humility or too little pride?
2. What are you genuinely proud of in your life and career?
3. In what situations do you find it hard to accept learning from others?
4. In what situations do you hide or erase your background?

5. Complete this sentence in your own words: “I’m new here, and I’m...”

## Say it in English

**Balancing confidence and openness**

- *“I have a lot of experience in..., but I’m still learning how it works in Canada.”*
- *“In my previous company, we did it this way. How do you usually do it here?”*
- *“Thanks for the tip. That’s really useful.”*
- *“I’m proud of what I achieved in Brazil.”*
- *“I’d be happy to share what worked for us, if it’s helpful.”*

**Model answer.** *“How do you feel about working for a manager who is younger than you?”*

> *“It doesn’t bother me at all. I’ve been in the industry for a long time, but I’m new to how things work in Canada, so I have a lot to learn from my manager. At the same time, I think my experience can be*

> *useful to the team. In my current job, my supervisor is much younger than I am, and we've learned a lot from each other."*

**Em português.** *Nem tanto ao mar, nem tanto à terra* (literally, "neither so much to the sea, nor so much to the land"). In English: *Find the middle ground*.

**Teacher's note**

Watch for both extremes. Students with too little humility may resist correction or compare constantly with Brazil; students with too little pride may never mention their background or may apologize before every answer. The phrase "I'm new here, and I'm very capable" is a useful anchor for both groups.

**Key points**

- Humility is a strength, but it can slide into self-erasure.
- Too little humility slows learning; too little pride erodes confidence.
- Healthy pride is accurate respect for your achievements; healthy humility is openness to learning.
- Hold both: "I'm new here, and I'm very capable."

# 32. What You Will Not Sacrifice

> *Knowing your limits is not weakness. It is what keeps ambition human.*

Immigrants sacrifice a great deal. My students have given up careers, homes, salaries, social status, proximity to family and the comfort of their own language. Many accept these sacrifices willingly, as an investment in a better future.

But there is a question that is rarely asked, and it is one of the most important questions in this book: *What will you not sacrifice?*

## Why limits matter

Hungry, disciplined people are good at sacrifice. That is part of their success. But without clear limits, sacrifice can spread until it takes things that were never meant to be part of the deal: your health, your marriage, your children's childhood, your integrity, your sense of who you are.

These losses often happen gradually. A few extra shifts become a permanent second job. A temporary pause in exercise becomes two years without it. Missing one family dinner a week becomes missing most of them. Nobody decided to sacrifice these things. They simply were not protected.

## Naming your non-negotiables

A non-negotiable is something you have decided in advance that you will protect, even under pressure. It is useful to name them explicitly, and to discuss them with your partner if you have one.

Common non-negotiables among my students include:

- **Health:** a minimum amount of sleep, regular exercise, medical check-ups.
- **Marriage:** regular time together that is not about logistics.
- **Children:** being present for certain moments, such as dinner, bedtime or weekends.
- **Integrity:** never lying on a résumé, never taking shortcuts with immigration rules, never compromising your professional ethics.
- **Identity:** keeping your language, culture and traditions alive at home.
- **Faith or community:** time for the practices and groups that give life meaning.

Your list will be different. What matters is that it is *yours*, and that it is specific enough to guide decisions. "Family is important" is not a non-negotiable. "Sunday afternoon is family time, without phones" is.

## When limits are tested

Limits are easy to set on paper and harder to keep in real life. There will be moments when an extra shift pays well, or an exam requires everything, or a job opportunity requires a sacrifice you had decided not to make.

In those moments, it helps to ask:

1. Is this temporary, with a clear end date?
2. Have I discussed it with the people affected?
3. What will I do to protect the non-negotiable as soon as the period ends?

A temporary, agreed exception is different from a slow erosion. The first is a decision. The second is something that happens to you.

> **From my lessons: the Saturday rule**

*This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*

Cristina, 40, and her husband had moved to Toronto with two young daughters. He studied full time for an engineering master's degree; she worked as a dental assistant while preparing for her dentistry equivalency exams. Within a year, they realized they had not spent a single full day together as a family in months.

They made one rule: Saturdays until three o'clock belonged to the family. No studying, no shifts, no phones at the table. If an exception was necessary, they had to agree on it together, in advance.

"Some weeks it was very hard," Cristina told me. "But our daughters started calling it 'family Saturday.' I realized that in five years, they would not remember my exam scores. They would remember Saturdays."

## Look in the mirror

1. What have you already sacrificed for this move?
2. What have you lost without deciding to lose it?
3. Write three to five non-negotiables, specific enough to guide decisions.
4. Which one is most at risk right now?
5. If you have a partner, when will you discuss your non-negotiables together?

## Say it in English

**Setting boundaries politely**

- *"I'm not available on Saturday mornings, but I could do Sunday."*
- *"I'd love to help, but I can't take on extra shifts this month."*
- *"That's important to me, so I need to protect that time."*
- *"Let me check with my family and get back to you."*
- *"I'm committed to doing this properly, and I also need to keep a balance."*

**Model answer.** *"Are you able to work overtime when needed?"*

> *"Yes, I'm flexible when there's a deadline or an urgent need, and I'm happy to help the team. I also plan my time carefully so that I can be fully focused at work and still meet my family commitments. With some notice, I can usually adjust my schedule."*

**Em português.** *Quem tudo quer, tudo perde* (literally, "whoever wants everything loses everything"). In English: *Try to do everything and you'll do nothing well*.

**Teacher's note**

Students who are overextended often believe that setting limits is ungrateful or weak. Teaching polite boundary-setting language in English is practical and important; many newcomers say "yes" to everything simply because they do not know how to say "no" politely in their second language.

**Key points**

- Immigrants make many sacrifices; it is just as important to decide what you will not sacrifice.
- Without clear limits, sacrifice spreads to health, relationships, integrity and identity.
- Name specific non-negotiables and discuss them with the people affected.
- A temporary, agreed exception is a decision; slow erosion is something that happens to you.

# 33. The Version of You That Stayed in Brazil

> *Comparing yourself with the person you might have been is a race nobody can win.*

Many of my students carry a quiet companion: the version of themselves that never left.

That version is still in Brazil. They got the promotion. They live in the apartment they were planning to buy. They have dinner with their parents every Sunday. They speak with ease, laugh at every joke, never fill in a form in a language they half understand. When life in Canada is hard, this imaginary person seems to be doing very well.

This lesson is about that comparison, and how to handle it.

## Why the comparison happens

The comparison is natural. Any big decision creates an "alternative life" in our imagination. And because immigration is a decision with a long, difficult beginning, the alternative life tends to look especially attractive in the first years.

But there is a problem with the comparison: it is not fair.

The version of you in Brazil is imaginary. It has no bad days that you know about. It has no economic crises, no traffic, no security worries, no frustrations at work, none of the reasons you decided to leave. You are comparing your real life, with all its difficulties, against an edited one.

## What the comparison can tell you

The comparison is not useless, however. Sometimes the imaginary version of you contains real information. If you keep imagining Sunday dinners, perhaps you need more family connection in your life now. If you keep imagining the promotion, perhaps you need a clearer career plan here. If you keep imagining speaking with ease, perhaps you need more chances to speak Portuguese, or more patience with your English.

Ask: *What does that imaginary person have that I am missing? Is there a way to bring some of it into my life here?*

## Remembering why you came

It also helps to remember, specifically, why you left. Not the general reason ("a better future"), but the concrete one. Many of my students find it useful to write down their reasons in their first months, and to read them again when the comparison becomes strong:

- *"I wanted my children to grow up feeling safe."*
- *"I wanted to work in an international environment."*
- *"I was tired of my career depending on who I knew."*
- *"We wanted to build something new together."*

Those reasons are real. The imaginary version of you gave them up.

## Two lives, one person

Eventually, many immigrants make peace with both lives. They accept that they gave up some things to gain others. They stop comparing and start integrating: bringing the best of their Brazilian life into their Canadian one, and recognizing that they are not two people, but one person with a larger story.

**From my lessons: the LinkedIn update**

*This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*

Sérgio, 42, had been a product manager at a telecommunications company in São Paulo. One evening, he saw on LinkedIn that a former colleague, who had been his junior, had become a director.

He came to our lesson unusually quiet. "That could have been me," he said. "If I had stayed, I'd be a director now."

I asked him to write down why he had left. He wrote: *Two robberies in one year. A career that depended on politics. A wish to raise our son bilingual.* Below it, without being asked, he added what he missed: *My friends. Sunday lunch at my mother's. The sea.* Then I asked him to write what he had gained in Canada so far. *My son walks to school alone. I'm learning a new industry. I have a new perspective I would never have had.*

"I still think about the director job," he said. "But I wouldn't trade."

## Look in the mirror

1. Describe the version of you that stayed in Brazil. What does their life look like?
2. What does that imaginary person have that you miss?
3. Is there a way to bring some of that into your life in Canada?
4. Write down, specifically, why you left.

5. What have you gained in Canada that the imaginary version of you does not have?

## Say it in English

**Talking about decisions and alternatives**

- *"If I had stayed in Brazil, I would probably have..."*
- *"Sometimes I wonder what would have happened if..."*
- *"It was a difficult decision, but I don't regret it."*
- *"I gave up..., but I gained..."*
- *"Looking back, I'm glad we made the move."*

**Model answer.** *"Why did you decide to move to Canada?"*

> *"It was a family decision. We wanted our son to grow up in a safe environment and to be bilingual, and I wanted to work in a more international context. It meant giving up a good position in São Paulo, so it wasn't easy. But I've gained a new perspective and new skills, and I don't regret it."*

**Em português.** *A grama do vizinho é sempre mais verde* (literally, "the neighbour's grass is always greener"). In English: *The grass is always greener on the other side*.

**Falso amigo:** *pretend* ≠ *pretender*. *Pretend* means *fingir*. For *pretender*, say *intend to* or *plan to*: *I intend to work in finance*.

**Teacher's note**

This lesson is excellent practice for the third conditional ("If I had stayed, I would have…") and mixed conditionals, which advanced students often find difficult. Use the grammar practice as a natural way into the reflection, and keep the focus on what the student has gained as well as what they gave up.

**Key points**

- Many immigrants compare themselves with an imaginary version who stayed in Brazil.
- The comparison is unfair: you are comparing a real life with an edited one.
- The imaginary version can still show you what you are missing; bring some of it into your life here.
- Write down specifically why you came, and read it when the comparison is strong.

# 34. Identity Bigger Than a Job Title

> *You were never just your title. Canada simply gives you the chance to discover it.*

In Brazil, as in many countries, the first question at a party is often some version of *"What do you do?"* For years, my students had a clear and impressive answer: *I'm a lawyer. I'm a finance manager. I'm an engineer. I'm a director.*

In Canada, the same question can be painful. *"I work in a warehouse." "I'm a cleaner." "I'm a student."* The answer is true, but it does not feel like the truth. It feels like a reduction.

This lesson is about building an identity that does not depend entirely on your current job title.

## When the title was the identity

For many professionals, especially those who built their careers in competitive corporate environments, the job title gradually becomes the centre of identity. It explains who they are to others and to themselves. It brings respect, structure and a sense of worth.

When the title disappears, even temporarily, the loss can be surprisingly deep. Some of my students describe it as a kind of grief. "I don't know who I am without my job," one told me.

This is not vanity. It is a natural result of years of investment. But it is also a vulnerability, and immigration exposes it.

## What identity is really made of

Your identity is much larger than your title. It includes:

- **Your skills and knowledge:** what you can do, wherever you are.
- **Your values:** what you care about and how you treat people.
- **Your relationships:** the roles you play as a partner, parent, child, friend and colleague.
- **Your history:** what you have lived through and achieved.
- **Your character:** traits such as discipline, generosity, humour, courage.
- **Your culture:** language, traditions, ways of seeing the world.
- **Your direction:** where you are going, not only where you are.

Your title was one way of expressing some of these things. It was never all of them.

## A better answer to "What do you do?"

You do not have to answer "What do you do?" only with your current job. You can answer with your direction and your background:

- *"My background is in civil engineering. I was a licensed engineer in Brazil for fifteen years, working in infrastructure, and right now I'm going through the licensing process here."*
- *"I'm in finance. I'm working in accounts payable while I complete my Canadian designation."*
- *"I'm a marketing professional. I'm currently working in retail while I build my network here."*

These answers are honest. They also tell the full story, instead of a fragment of it.

**From my lessons: "a Brazilian-trained lawyer"**

*This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*

Aline, 38, had been a corporate lawyer in Rio de Janeiro. In Vancouver, she worked part time in a clothing store while she studied for the exams required to practise law in Canada. At social events, when people asked what she did, she said, "I work in a store," and then fell silent.

In our lessons, we practised a different answer. She wrote it, revised it and said it aloud until it felt natural: "I'm a Brazilian-trained lawyer. I practised corporate law in Brazil for ten years, and I'm now completing the requirements to practise in Canada. In the meantime, I'm working in retail, which is teaching me a lot about customer service."

The next time someone asked, she used it. The conversation lasted twenty minutes. The person turned out to work in compliance at a bank and offered to introduce her to a colleague.

## Look in the mirror

1. How did you answer "What do you do?" in Brazil? How do you answer it now?
2. How much of your identity was built around your job title?
3. Using the list in this lesson, describe yourself without mentioning any job title.
4. Write a new answer to "What do you do?" that includes your background and your direction.
5. Practise it aloud until it feels natural.

## Say it in English

**Introducing yourself with your full story**

- *"My background is in [field]. I worked in... in Brazil for [number] years."*
- *"I'm a Brazilian-trained [profession]."* (In Canada, titles such as *engineer*, *lawyer* or *nurse* are legally protected until you are licensed here.)
- *"Right now, I'm..., while I..."*
- *"My background is in..."*
- *"I'm currently in transition, moving from... to..."*
- *"I'm working toward..."*

**Model answer.** *"So, what do you do?"*

> *"I'm a Brazilian-trained corporate lawyer. I practised in Rio de Janeiro for ten years, and now I'm completing the requirements to practise here in British Columbia. In the meantime, I'm working in retail, which is actually great for my English and my customer service skills. What about you?"*

**Em português.** *O hábito não faz o monge* (literally, "the habit does not make the monk"). In English: *Clothes don't make the man; don't judge a book by its cover*. Your job title is the habit. You are the monk.

**Cuidado:** *I have 40 years* ← *tenho 40 anos*. In English, age uses *be*: *I'm 40*. And for experience: *I have fifteen years of experience*.

**Teacher's note**

Every student should leave your course with a confident, rehearsed answer to "What do you do?" It is one of the most frequently asked questions in Canadian social and professional life, and the answer shapes how others see the student, and how the student sees themselves. Practise it until it can be delivered naturally in under 30 seconds.

**Key points**

- For many professionals, the job title gradually becomes the centre of identity.
- Losing it, even temporarily, can feel like grief. That is natural, not vanity.
- Identity includes skills, values, relationships, history, character, culture and direction.
- Answer "What do you do?" with your background and your direction, not only your current job.

# 35. Evidence-Based Confidence

> *Confidence that depends on mood will fail you. Confidence built on evidence will not.*

Many people think of confidence as a feeling: you either have it or you do not. On good days, you feel confident. On bad days, after a rejection or a difficult conversation, the feeling disappears.

For immigrants, that kind of confidence is fragile. There are too many bad days in the first years. If your confidence depends on how you feel, it will rise and fall with every email, every interview and every misunderstanding.

There is a more reliable kind of confidence. It is based not on how you feel, but on what you can prove.

## Feeling-based and evidence-based confidence

**Feeling-based confidence** says: *I feel capable today.* It is pleasant, but it changes with circumstances.

**Evidence-based confidence** says: *I have done this before. Here is the proof.* It does not depend on mood. It may be quieter, but it is far more stable.

Throughout this book, you have been collecting evidence: your inventory (Lesson 9), your success formula (Lesson 18), your resilience history (Lesson 13), your list of discoveries (Lesson 27). This lesson brings them together into one tool.

## Your evidence file

An evidence file is a simple document, in a notebook or on your phone, where you collect proof of your abilities. It has three sections:

**1. Past evidence.** Achievements from your life and career before Canada: degrees, promotions, projects, results, difficulties overcome. Be specific: numbers, names, outcomes.

**2. Canadian evidence.** Achievements since you arrived, including small ones: your first conversation on the phone in English, your first Canadian reference, a compliment from a supervisor, a test score that improved, a problem you solved at work, a form you completed alone.

**3. Feedback.** Positive comments from other people, written down word for word: an email from a manager, a teacher's comment, a thank-you from a colleague.

Wherever you can, include a number: *trained 4 new analysts*, *answered 30 customer calls in English in one shift*, *test score up from 6.0 to 6.5*. Numbers make evidence harder for impostor syndrome to argue with.

Add to it every week. Read it before interviews, before difficult conversations and on days when impostor syndrome is loud.

## Why small Canadian evidence matters

My students often ignore the second section because the achievements seem too small. "I made a phone call. So what?"

But small Canadian achievements are exactly what impostor syndrome attacks. They prove that you are progressing *here*, in this country and this language. Over months, they add up to a powerful record. A student who has fifty small Canadian achievements written down is very hard to convince that they "can't do it here."

## Confidence follows action

There is one more important point. Confidence rarely comes first. People often wait to feel confident before applying for a job, speaking in a meeting or making a phone call. But in most cases, confidence comes *after* the action, as a result of it.

The evidence file helps you take action before you feel ready. And every action, whether it succeeds or not, adds to the file.

> **From my lessons: the green notebook**
>
> *This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*
>
> Camila, 35, a human resources specialist from Florianópolis, kept a small green notebook. On the first pages, she wrote her past evidence. After that, she wrote one Canadian achievement every day, no matter how small.
>
> *Asked a stranger for directions. Understood a joke at work. Corrected a billing mistake in English. My supervisor said "great job" on the schedule. Explained a policy to a new employee.*
>
> After eight months, the notebook had more than two hundred entries. Before her interview for an HR coordinator role, she read it on the bus.
>
> "I didn't feel confident," she told me afterwards. "But I knew I was capable. I had two hundred pieces of proof." She got the job.

## Look in the mirror

> 1. Is your confidence mostly feeling-based or evidence-based?

2. Write five pieces of past evidence, with specific details.
3. Write five pieces of Canadian evidence, including small ones.
4. Write down one positive piece of feedback you have received, word for word.
5. Where will you keep your evidence file, and when will you add to it each week?

## Say it in English

**Speaking from evidence**

- *"I'm confident I can do this, because I've done something similar before."*
- *"In my previous role, I..."*
- *"Since arriving in Canada, I've..."*
- *"My supervisor has told me that..."*
- *"I have a strong track record in..."*

**Model answer.** *"Why should we hire you?"*

> *"Because I have a strong track record in exactly what this role requires. In Brazil, I managed recruitment for a company with over a thousand employees. Since arriving in Canada, I've worked in a scheduling role where I've learned local practices, and my supervisor has praised my organization and communication. I'm confident I can make a real contribution here quickly."*

**Em português.** *Contra fatos não há argumentos* (literally, "against facts there are no arguments"). In English: *The facts speak for themselves*.

**Teacher's note**

Encourage students to keep an evidence file in English. Ask them, at the start of each lesson, to share one small Canadian achievement from the past week. The routine builds evidence-based confidence, gives practice in the past simple and creates a habit of noticing and naming progress.

**Key points**

- Feeling-based confidence rises and falls; evidence-based confidence is stable.
- Keep an evidence file with three sections: past evidence, Canadian evidence and feedback.
- Small Canadian achievements matter, because they prove you are progressing here.
- Confidence usually follows action. Use your evidence to act before you feel ready.

PART V

# The Traits That Master English

> *The habits that made you successful are the ones that will make you fluent.*

# 36. Which of Your Traits Will Help You Master English?

> *The habits that made you successful are the ones that will make you fluent.*

Here is the central idea of Part V, and one of the most important ideas in this book: *you do not need to become a different person to master English.* You need to bring the person you already are into your English learning.

Many of my students approach English as if it were a completely separate challenge, unrelated to everything else they have achieved. They feel like beginners again, and they act like beginners: passive, anxious, waiting for the teacher to make them fluent.

But adult professionals are not beginners at learning. They have learned difficult things many times before. The traits that helped them succeed (discipline, competitiveness, curiosity, resilience, the ability to use feedback) are exactly the traits that accelerate language learning.

## Why adults can be strong language learners

People often say that children learn languages more easily than adults. In some ways, especially pronunciation, younger learners do have advantages. But adults have advantages too, and many of them are significant:

- **Adults know how to study.** They can use strategies, plan their learning and organize practice.
- **Adults understand grammar as a system.** They can learn rules consciously and apply them.

- **Adults have deep knowledge in their field.** They can learn professional English quickly because they already understand the concepts.
- **Adults have clear motivation.** A job, a licence, a promotion, a child's school meeting.
- **Adults can direct their own learning.** They do not need a teacher for every step.

These are the advantages of experience. They are yours.

## Mapping your traits onto English

In Part II, you identified the traits that explain your success. Now look at them again, with English in mind:

| Your trait | How it helps English |
|---|---|
| Discipline | Daily practice that compounds over months |
| Competitiveness | Measuring progress and pushing for the next level |
| Humility | Making mistakes in public and accepting correction |
| Curiosity | Noticing how English really works, not just what the textbook says |
| Resilience | Continuing through plateaus and bad days |
| Using feedback | Turning corrections into improvement quickly |
| Relationships | Creating many opportunities to speak |
| Learning methods | Applying proven study strategies to a new subject |

The next eight lessons look at the most important of these in detail.

## Two kinds of student

Over many years, I have noticed that students tend to approach English in one of two ways.

**The passive student** waits. They attend their lessons, do the homework and hope that fluency will eventually arrive. They see English as something that happens *to* them.

**The active student** manages English like a project. They set goals, choose methods, track progress, seek practice and adjust. They see English as something they *do*.

The active student almost always progresses faster, regardless of their starting level. And most of my Brazilian students have been active learners all their lives, in every other subject. They simply need to remember it.

**From my lessons: the project plan**

*This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*

Helena, 42, had managed large IT implementation projects in São Paulo. For her first six months in Canada, she followed a general English course faithfully, but her progress felt slow. When she started lessons with me, she said, "I'm doing everything the course tells me to do. Nothing happens."

I asked her how she would manage English if it were one of her implementation projects. Her face changed. Within a week, she had a project plan: a clear objective (a specific score on an English test in six months), weekly milestones, a risk list (fatigue, avoidance of speaking), a set of practice activities and a weekly status report to herself.

"I was waiting to be taught," she said. "In my career, I never waited for anything."

I noticed the difference within a month: more questions, more speaking, more initiative.

## Look in the mirror

1. Do you approach English more as a passive student or an active student?
2. Which three traits from Part II are strongest in you?
3. How could each of those traits help your English specifically?
4. Which adult advantages (study skills, grammar understanding, field knowledge, motivation, self-direction) are you using? Which are you not using?
5. If English were a project at work, how would you manage it?

## Say it in English

**Talking about your learning approach**

- *"I'm approaching English like a project."*
- *"My goal is to reach... by..."*
- *"I'm tracking my progress by..."*
- *"I've noticed that I learn best when..."*

- *"I take every opportunity to practise."*

**Model answer.** *"How are you improving your English?"*

> *"I'm treating it like a project. I have a clear goal for the next six months, and I practise every day: listening on my commute, speaking with a conversation partner twice a week and writing short summaries of articles in my field. I track my progress weekly and adjust my plan if something isn't working."*

**Em português.** *Querer é poder* (literally, "to want is to be able"). In English: *Where there's a will, there's a way*.

**Teacher's note**

Ask students how they would manage English if it were a project at work. Professionals who have managed projects, budgets or teams often transform their approach when they make this connection. The teacher's role then shifts from providing all the learning to supporting a learner who is directing their own.

**Key points**

- You do not need to become a different person to master English. Bring the person you already are.
- Adults have real learning advantages: study skills, grammar understanding, field knowledge, motivation and self-direction.
- The traits behind your success map directly onto language learning.
- Active students who manage English like a project progress faster than passive ones.

# 37. Discipline: Twenty Minutes Every Day Beats Three Hours on Sunday

> *Language is built in small, daily layers.*

In Lesson 11, we saw that discipline is mostly structure, not willpower. In this lesson, we apply that idea directly to English.

My students are busy. Between work, study, family and the administration of a new life, there is rarely a free afternoon. So many of them adopt what seems like a logical strategy: they save English for the weekend and study for several hours on Sunday.

It almost never works as well as they hope.

## Why daily practice wins

There are good reasons why short, daily practice is more effective than long, occasional sessions:

- **Spacing.** Research on learning consistently shows that information reviewed at intervals is remembered better than information studied all at once. Daily practice creates natural spacing.
- **Fatigue.** After an hour or so, concentration falls. The third hour on Sunday is rarely as productive as the first.
- **Habit.** A daily routine becomes automatic. A weekly one is easily cancelled when something else comes up.
- **Exposure.** Language is partly about getting used to sounds, rhythms and patterns. Daily contact keeps your ear and mouth "warm."
- **Momentum.** Seeing small progress every day keeps motivation alive.

Twenty minutes a day is about two hours and twenty minutes a week. Over a year, it is more than 120 hours of focused practice.

## What to do in twenty minutes

The best daily practice is varied, active and connected to your real life. Here is a simple weekly rhythm many of my students use:

| Day | Twenty-minute focus |
|---|---|
| Monday | Listen to a short podcast or video in your field; write five new expressions |
| Tuesday | Speak: record yourself answering an interview question, listen, record again |
| Wednesday | Read a short article; summarize it aloud in three sentences |
| Thursday | Review the week's expressions; use each one in a sentence |
| Friday | Write a short email or message you might need at work |
| Weekend | Real conversation: a call, a coffee, a community activity |

This is only an example. The point is to have a plan, so that you do not waste your twenty minutes deciding what to do.

## Finding the twenty minutes

Many students say they have no time. Usually, they have time that is fragmented: ten minutes on the bus, fifteen minutes at lunch, a few minutes while cooking. Fragmented time works very well for language practice:

- **Commuting:** listening, shadowing (repeating what you hear quietly), reviewing vocabulary on your phone.
- **Household tasks:** podcasts, audiobooks.
- **Waiting rooms and queues:** reading, reviewing expressions.
- **Before sleep:** reading a few pages of something enjoyable in English.

Attach English to something you already do every day. That is how it becomes a habit rather than a decision.

**From my lessons: the Sunday marathon**

*This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*

Bruno, 39, had been a sales manager in Campinas. In Toronto, he worked long hours in a restaurant kitchen and studied English every Sunday, from nine until one. By Wednesday, he told me, he had forgotten most of it.

We changed his plan. Sunday became a short one-hour review. During the week, he did twenty minutes every morning on the subway: listening and shadowing on Monday, Wednesday and Friday, vocabulary review on Tuesday and Thursday. He tracked each day with a mark on his phone calendar.

After two months, he was studying a little less in total, but much more of it stayed with him. He said the difference was obvious. “Before, English was something I visited once a week. Now it lives with me.”

## Look in the mirror

1. How do you currently organize your English practice: daily, weekly or irregularly?
2. Where are the fragments of time in your day that you could use?
3. What daily activity could you attach English practice to?
4. Design your own weekly rhythm of twenty-minute practice.

5. How will you track it?

## Say it in English

**Describing routines and habits**

- *"I usually practise on my way to work."*
- *"Every morning, I spend about twenty minutes on..."*
- *"I've got into the habit of..."*
- *"I try to fit in some practice whenever I can."*
- *"I've been doing this for about two months now."*

**Model answer.** *"What do you do to keep developing professionally?"*

> *"I'm a big believer in small, consistent habits. Every morning, I spend about twenty minutes on my English: listening to industry podcasts, practising speaking or reviewing new vocabulary. I also read articles in my field a few times a week. I find that doing a little every day is much more effective than trying to do everything at once."*

**Em português.** *Devagar se vai ao longe* (literally, "slowly you go far"). In English: *Slow and steady wins the race*.

**Teacher's note**

Help students design a realistic daily practice plan, not an ideal one. Ask where their fragments of time are, and suggest specific activities for each. Checking in briefly at the start of each lesson ("Did you do your twenty minutes this week?") creates accountability and lets you see quickly who needs help rebuilding their structure.

**Key points**

- Short daily practice is more effective than long weekly sessions: spacing, less fatigue, stronger habits and more exposure.
- Twenty minutes a day adds up to more than 120 hours a year.
- Have a weekly rhythm so you do not waste time deciding what to do.
- Use fragmented time, and attach English to something you already do every day.

# 38. Competitiveness: Compete With Yesterday's English

> *The only fair competitor in language learning is the person you were last month.*

Many of my students come from healthy, competitive corporate cultures (Lesson 3). They are used to targets, rankings and performance reviews. They like to win. In their careers, that competitiveness pushed them to do better.

In learning English, competitiveness can be a great strength or a serious obstacle. It depends on who you are competing with.

## The wrong competitor

The natural instinct is to compare yourself with other people: the other newcomer who speaks more fluently, the colleague who was born here, your own children who seem to learn English effortlessly, the friend who arrived at the same time and already has a professional job.

These comparisons are almost always unfair. That newcomer may have studied English for years before arriving. Your colleague has spoken English since birth. Your children are immersed in English all day at school. Your friend may work in a field with fewer barriers. You are comparing your progress with people whose starting point, conditions and goals are different.

The result of these comparisons is usually discouragement, not motivation. And discouragement leads to avoidance, which slows progress further.

## The right competitor

There is one competitor who is perfectly fair: *you, a month ago.*

Competing with your past self keeps all the energy of competitiveness, but points it in a useful direction. It answers the question that matters: *Am I improving?* And it lets you see progress that would be invisible if you only compared yourself with others.

## How to compete with yourself

Competitors need a scoreboard. Here are simple ways to measure your English against your past self:

- **Recordings.** Record yourself answering the same question every month, such as "Tell me about yourself." Listen to January and then to April. The difference is often striking.
- **Writing samples.** Keep a short piece of writing from each month. Compare them for vocabulary, accuracy and length.
- **Practice tests.** If you are preparing for an official English test, take a practice test at regular intervals and track your scores by skill.
- **Real-life milestones.** Your first phone call without panic. Your first joke that made people laugh. Your first meeting where you spoke twice. Write them down.
- **Comprehension checks.** Watch the same short video every few months. Notice how much more you understand.

## Healthy competition with others

This does not mean you can never compete with others. Friendly competition can be motivating, as long as it is about effort, not ability. A study group that challenges each other to practise every day for a month, or a conversation

partner who sets the same vocabulary goal, uses competitiveness in a healthy way.

**From my lessons: January and April**

*This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*

Larissa, 34, had been an award-winning architect at a design firm in Brasília. In Toronto, she was miserable at work, because two colleagues on her team spoke more fluently than she did. "I'm the worst on the team," she told me in our first lesson. "I've never been the worst at anything."

I asked her to record a two-minute answer to "Tell me about yourself" in January. She did, reluctantly. In April, she recorded the same answer again, then listened to both.

She was silent for a moment. "The first one is terrible," she said, laughing. "The second one is... actually good."

From then on, she recorded herself on the first day of every month. "I stopped competing with Ana and João," she said. "I compete with January Larissa. And I'm winning."

## Look in the mirror

1. Who do you usually compare your English with?
2. Are those comparisons fair? What is different about their starting point or conditions?
3. How do those comparisons affect your motivation?

4. Which methods from this lesson will you use to compete with your past self?
5. Record yourself answering "Tell me about yourself" today. When will you record it again?

## Say it in English

**Talking about progress**

- *"I've improved a lot in..."*
- *"Compared with six months ago, I..."*
- *"I've noticed that I can now..."*
- *"I'm much more comfortable with... than I used to be."*
- *"My next goal is to..."*

**Model answer.** *"How has your English developed since you arrived?"*

> *"It's improved a lot. Compared with a year ago, I can follow meetings much more easily, and I'm comfortable speaking on the phone, which used to make me very nervous. I record myself every month, so I can*

> *actually hear the difference. My next goal is to become more natural in informal conversations."*

**Em português.** *Cada um no seu tempo* (literally, "each one in their own time"). In English: *Everyone moves at their own pace*.

**Teacher's note**

Competitive students often become discouraged by comparing themselves with colleagues or other learners. Redirect that energy toward self-comparison. Monthly recordings are one of the most powerful tools available: they make invisible progress audible, and students who hear their own improvement tend to practise more.

**Key points**

- Competitiveness is a strength, if you compete with the right person.
- Comparing yourself with others is usually unfair and discouraging.
- Compete with your past self: recordings, writing samples, practice tests and milestones.
- Friendly competition with others works when it is about effort, not ability.

# 39. Humility: Making Mistakes in Public

> *Every fluent speaker you admire made thousands of mistakes out loud first.*

There is no way to learn to speak a language without making mistakes, and most of those mistakes will happen in front of other people. That is the nature of speaking.

For many of my students, this is one of the hardest parts of English. They were respected professionals. They were the ones who corrected others. Now, they make mistakes that a child would not make, in meetings, in shops, on the phone. Each mistake can feel like a small public embarrassment.

Many respond by speaking less. They wait until they can say something perfectly. They prepare every sentence in their head. They avoid situations where they might make errors. It is a natural reaction, and it is one of the main reasons adult learners plateau.

## Why mistakes are necessary

Mistakes are not a sign that you are failing to learn. They are part of how you learn:

- **Speaking reveals gaps.** You only discover what you cannot yet say by trying to say it.
- **Errors create feedback.** When someone corrects you, or misunderstands you, you get information you could not get in silence.
- **Practice builds fluency.** Fluency comes from speaking many times, not from preparing perfectly once.

- **Risk builds confidence.** Each time you make a mistake and nothing terrible happens, the fear becomes smaller.

A student who speaks often and makes many mistakes will almost always become fluent faster than one who speaks rarely and correctly.

## The humility you already have

In Lesson 7, we saw that many of my students are remarkably humble. They take jobs far below their level, accept starting again and work without complaint. That humility is a powerful resource for English.

The challenge is that humility in action ("I will clean floors if necessary") is sometimes easier than humility in speech ("I will say this sentence badly in front of my colleagues"). Speaking mistakes feel more personal, because they seem to reveal something about our intelligence.

But the principle is the same. You are starting where you need to start, in order to get where you want to go.

## Making mistakes easier

Some practical strategies help:

- **Expect mistakes.** Before a conversation, tell yourself: "I will make mistakes, and that is part of the plan."
- **Name it lightly.** *"Sorry, my English is still developing. Let me say that again."* A short, calm comment removes the pressure.
- **Ask for correction.** *"If I say something wrong, please correct me. It really helps."* Many Canadians will not correct you unless you ask.
- **Separate the error from yourself.** A wrong preposition is a wrong preposition, not a judgment of your intelligence.

- **Notice how others react.** In most cases, people are focused on your message, not your grammar. They are usually more patient than you expect.
- **Laugh when it is funny.** Some mistakes are genuinely funny. Laughing at them, with others, builds connection.

> **From my lessons: the mistake count**
>
> *This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*
>
> Hugo, 47, had been a senior lawyer in Rio de Janeiro, known for his precise language. In our first lessons, he barely spoke. When he did, it was only after a long silence, in perfect, carefully constructed sentences.
>
> I gave him an unusual assignment: make at least ten mistakes in English every day, in real conversations, and write down the ones he noticed. He thought I was joking.
>
> The first week, he wrote down six. The second week, he wrote down twenty. By the end of the month, he was speaking four times as much in our lessons, and his notebook was full of mistakes he had already corrected.
>
> "I spent my whole career trying not to make mistakes," he said. "To learn English, I had to do the opposite. It was the hardest thing I've learned here."

## Look in the mirror

1. How do you feel when you make a mistake in English in front of other people?

2. In which situations do you avoid speaking because you are afraid of mistakes?
3. What has that avoidance cost your progress?
4. What is the worst thing that has actually happened after one of your mistakes?
5. Which strategy from this lesson will you try this week?

## Say it in English

**Handling mistakes calmly**

- *"Sorry, let me say that again."*
- *"I mean..."*
- *"Is that the right word?"*
- *"Please correct me if I say something wrong."*
- *"Thanks for the correction. That's helpful."*
- *"My English is still a work in progress."*

**Model answer.** *"How do you handle making mistakes?"*

> *"I see them as part of learning. When I make a mistake, I try to understand what went wrong, correct it and move on. I'm also comfortable asking for feedback. Learning English as an adult has taught me a lot about this, because I've had to make mistakes in public every day. It's made me much more relaxed and open to learning."*

**Em português.** *Quem não arrisca não petisca* (literally, "whoever doesn't risk doesn't get a snack"). In English: *Nothing ventured, nothing gained*.

**Teacher's note**

Students who were high-status professionals often find speaking mistakes particularly painful, and may withdraw into silence. Make your lessons a place where mistakes are expected and even celebrated. Correct in a way that keeps the student talking, for example by reformulating rather than stopping them, and praise risk-taking explicitly.

**Key points**

- You cannot learn to speak without making mistakes in public.
- Speaking less to avoid mistakes is a main reason adult learners plateau.
- Mistakes reveal gaps, create feedback, build fluency and reduce fear.
- Use your existing humility: expect mistakes, name them lightly, ask for correction and keep talking.

# 40. Curiosity: Learning the Language Behind the Language

> *Grammar tells you what is correct. Curiosity tells you what people actually say.*

Many of my students arrive with good textbook English. They know the grammar rules, the irregular verbs and a large vocabulary. Then they walk into a Canadian workplace, a hockey conversation or a kitchen at lunchtime and discover that there is another layer of English they never studied.

People say *"I'm good"* when they mean "No, thank you." They say *"Let's touch base"* and *"Can you loop me in?"* They say *"No worries"* instead of "You're welcome." They sometimes say *"That's interesting"* when they have doubts. They apologize when someone else bumps into them.

This is the language behind the language: idioms, informal expressions, unwritten rules and cultural meanings. It is learned less through study and more through curiosity.

## Curiosity as a learning engine

Curious people learn faster because they notice more. When they hear an unfamiliar expression, they do not ignore it; they ask about it, look it up or write it down. When something surprises them, they want to know why.

Many of my students were deeply curious in their professional lives. They wanted to understand how things worked: why a process failed, what a client really wanted, why a market behaved a certain way. That same curiosity, turned toward English, is one of the most powerful learning tools available.

## What to be curious about

- **Expressions.** "What does 'ballpark figure' mean? When do people use it?"
- **Tone.** "Was that a joke or serious?" "Was that polite or annoyed?"
- **Indirectness.** "When my manager says 'You might want to consider...', is that a suggestion or an instruction?" (Often, it is an instruction.)
- **Workplace culture.** "How do people disagree in meetings here? How do they say no?"
- **Regional English.** Canadian vocabulary, expressions from your province, how people speak in your industry.
- **Small talk.** What do people talk about on Monday morning? The weather, the weekend, sports, the commute.

## Becoming a language detective

Here are some habits of the curious learner:

1. **Keep an "expressions notebook."** Write down every new expression you hear in real life, with the situation in which you heard it.
2. **Ask native speakers.** *"Sorry, I heard you say 'on the same page.' What exactly does it mean?"* Most people are happy to explain.
3. **Notice patterns.** How do colleagues start emails? How do they end meetings? How do they ask for help?
4. **Watch and listen to real Canadian content:** local news, podcasts, television shows, YouTube channels in your field.
5. **Try new expressions.** Use each new expression at least twice in the following week. Notice how people respond.

## Curiosity protects your confidence

There is also a psychological benefit. When you approach unfamiliar English with curiosity, it stops being a threat and becomes interesting. "I didn't understand" turns into "Here's something new to learn." That shift, small as it seems, reduces anxiety and keeps you engaged.

**From my lessons: "You might want to consider"**

*This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*

Mônica, 39, had been a quality manager in a car parts plant in Curitiba, where communication was very direct. In her job in Windsor, her manager told her, "You might want to consider double-checking those numbers before the meeting."

She did not double-check them. In the meeting, there was a mistake, and her manager was not happy.

"He said 'might' and 'consider,'" she told me, confused. "In Brazil, that would be a suggestion."

We spent the next lesson on indirect instructions in Canadian workplace English. Mônica started an expressions notebook that evening. The first entry was: *"You might want to..." = Please do this.* Six months later, the notebook had over three hundred entries, and her colleagues had started asking *her* about Brazilian expressions.

## Look in the mirror

1. What English expressions have you heard in Canada that you did not learn in a textbook?

2. Have you ever misunderstood an indirect message? What happened?
3. What are you most curious about in Canadian English or workplace culture?
4. Who could you ask about expressions you do not understand?
5. Start your expressions notebook today. Write the first five entries.

## Say it in English

**Asking about language and culture**

- *"Sorry, what does ... mean?"*
- *"When would you use that expression?"*
- *"Is that formal or informal?"*
- *"Is that something people say a lot here?"*
- *"Just to check: is that a suggestion or a request?"*
- *"In Brazil we'd say... Is there an English equivalent?"*

**Model answer.** *"What have you found most surprising about working in Canada?"*

> *"Probably how indirect communication can be. In my previous workplace, people were very direct, so at first I took some instructions as suggestions. Now I pay much more attention to phrases like 'you might want to.' I actually keep a notebook of expressions I hear at work, and it's helped me a lot to understand the culture as well as the language."*

**Em português.** *Quem tem boca vai a Roma* (literally, "whoever has a mouth gets to Rome"). In English: *It never hurts to ask*.

**Falso amigo:** *sensible* ≠ *sensível*. *Sensible* means *sensato*. For *sensível*, say *sensitive*.

**Teacher's note**

Dedicate regular lesson time to "language behind the language": idioms, indirect instructions, politeness strategies and small talk. Invite students to bring expressions they heard during the week. This builds curiosity, connects lessons to real life and gives you valuable insight into the situations your students are actually facing.

**Key points**

- Beyond textbook English is a layer of idioms, informal expressions and cultural meanings.
- Curiosity is a learning engine: curious people notice more and learn faster.
- Be curious about expressions, tone, indirectness, workplace culture and small talk.
- Keep an expressions notebook, ask native speakers and try new expressions quickly.

# 41. Persistence Through the Plateau

> *A plateau is not the end of progress. It is the place where progress becomes invisible.*

Almost every adult language learner reaches it. In the beginning, progress is fast and visible: every week brings new words, new structures, new situations you can handle. Then, often at an intermediate or upper-intermediate level, progress seems to stop. You study as much as before, maybe more, but you do not feel any better. Some days, you feel worse.

This is the plateau. It is one of the most discouraging stages in learning English, and it is where many adults give up, or settle for "good enough."

## Why plateaus happen

Plateaus are a normal part of learning any complex skill. In language, they happen for several reasons:

- **Progress becomes less visible.** At the beginning, you go from knowing nothing to knowing something. Later, you are refining: better word choice, more natural rhythm, fewer small errors. These improvements are real but harder to notice.
- **"Good enough" English.** You can now do most of what you need to do. Without new challenges, your brain has less reason to keep developing.
- **Fossilized habits.** Some errors become automatic through repetition. They need deliberate attention to change.
- **Comfort zones.** You naturally use the words and structures you already know, and avoid the ones you do not.

- **Fatigue.** As we saw in Lesson 24, tired brains learn more slowly.

## Breaking through

The persistence you have shown in your career (finishing degrees, surviving crises, keeping going when things were hard) is exactly what is needed here. But persistence does not mean doing the same thing harder. It means changing the approach.

1. **Raise the challenge.** If everything feels comfortable, it is too easy. Choose harder material, more complex conversations, unfamiliar topics.
2. **Focus on one specific weakness.** Instead of "improve English," choose one thing: past tense accuracy, a particular sound, phrasal verbs for meetings. Work on it intensively for two or three weeks.
3. **Get precise feedback.** Ask a teacher or tutor to identify your most frequent errors. Plateaus often hide one or two persistent habits.
4. **Change the input.** If you always listen to the same type of content, try something new: a different accent, a different field, a podcast, a play.
5. **Measure differently.** Compare recordings over longer periods (Lesson 38). Progress that is invisible week to week is often obvious over three months.
6. **Rest strategically.** Sometimes a short break, followed by a fresh start, helps more than pushing through exhaustion.

## The plateau is a test of identity

There is also a mindset side to the plateau. It is the moment when impostor syndrome often returns: *"Maybe I've reached my limit. Maybe I'm too old. Maybe I'll never sound natural."*

This is exactly the time to return to your evidence file (Lesson 35). You have broken through plateaus before, in your studies and your career. You know

that effort, applied intelligently, produces results even when you cannot see them yet.

**From my lessons: the three errors**

*This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*

Vítor, 45, a logistics manager from Santos, had been in Canada for three years. His English was good enough for his job as a dispatcher, but he felt stuck. "I've been at the same level for a year and a half," he said. "I think this is my limit."

I recorded a ten-minute conversation with him and listened carefully. Three errors appeared again and again: missing third-person *s*, confusion between *make* and *do*, and a stress pattern that made some words hard to understand.

For six weeks, we focused only on those three habits. He practised with specific exercises, recorded himself and checked his recordings for the three errors. At first, he found it tedious. Then colleagues started commenting. "Your English sounds different," one said. "More... professional."

"It wasn't my limit," Vítor said. "It was three habits."

## Look in the mirror

1. Have you experienced a plateau in your English? When did it start?
2. Which causes from this lesson might apply to you?
3. What are your most frequent errors? If you do not know, how could you find out?

4. Which breakthrough strategy will you try first?
5. When have you broken through a plateau before, in any part of your life?

## Say it in English

**Talking about persistence and improvement**

- *"I hit a plateau, so I changed my approach."*
- *"I've been focusing specifically on..."*
- *"It took a while, but I'm starting to see results."*
- *"I don't give up easily."*
- *"When something isn't working, I try a different strategy."*

**Model answer.** *"Tell me about a time you had to persist through a difficult challenge."*

> *"My English is a good example. After a couple of years in Canada, I felt that I'd stopped improving. Instead of just studying more, I asked a teacher to identify my most frequent errors, and we found three persistent habits. I focused on those for six weeks, and my colleagues*

> *noticed the difference. It taught me that persistence works best when you combine it with a change in strategy."*

**Em português.** *Água mole em pedra dura, tanto bate até que fura* (literally, "soft water on hard stone keeps hitting until it makes a hole"). In English: *Constant dripping wears away the stone*.

**Cuidado:** *depend of* ← *depender de*. Three classic Portuguese-shaped errors: *depend on* (not *of*), *explain it to me* (not *explain me*) and *ask a question* (not *make a question*).

**Teacher's note**

Plateaued students often need diagnosis more than motivation. Record a natural conversation and identify the two or three most frequent, high-impact errors. A short, intensive focus on those few habits often produces a breakthrough that months of general practice did not. Name the plateau openly; students are relieved to learn that it is normal.

**Key points**

- Plateaus are normal, especially at intermediate and upper-intermediate levels.
- Causes include invisible progress, "good enough" English, fossilized habits, comfort zones and fatigue.
- Persistence means changing the approach: more challenge, specific focus, precise feedback, new input.
- The plateau often brings back impostor syndrome. Return to your evidence.

# 42. Using Feedback Like a Professional

> *Feedback is data. Professionals use data.*

My students have received feedback all their professional lives: performance reviews, audit findings, client complaints, comments from directors. Many of them were very good at using it. They listened, analyzed, adjusted and improved.

Then they start learning English, and something changes. A correction from a teacher feels personal. A colleague's confused expression feels like a judgment. An English test score feels like a verdict on their intelligence. The professional relationship with feedback is replaced by an emotional one.

This lesson is about bringing back the professional.

## Why language feedback feels different

Feedback on language can feel more personal than feedback on work, for several reasons. Language is closely connected to identity: how we express our thoughts, our humour, our personality. Errors are often public. And for adults who were respected experts, being corrected on simple things can feel humiliating.

These feelings are understandable. But they can lead to unhelpful reactions: defending the mistake, apologizing excessively, avoiding situations where feedback might come, or ignoring corrections because they are uncomfortable.

## The professional approach

In your career, you probably used feedback in a structured way, even if you never named the steps. The same structure works for English:

1. **Receive it.** Listen without defending. Say *"Thank you, that's helpful."*
2. **Understand it.** Make sure you know exactly what the problem is. *"So I should say 'depend on,' not 'depend of'?"*
3. **Record it.** Write it down. Feedback you do not record is usually forgotten.
4. **Practise it.** Use the corrected form several times, in different sentences, in the following days.
5. **Check it.** Later, notice whether you are using the correct form naturally. If not, practise again.

## Asking for better feedback

Generic feedback is not very useful. "Your English is good" or "You need to practise more" tells you little. Professionals know how to ask for specific feedback:

- *"What is the most important thing I should work on?"*
- *"Which errors do I make most often?"*
- *"Was my main point clear?"*
- *"What would a native speaker say in this situation?"*
- *"Could you tell me one thing I did well and one thing to improve?"*

Do not wait for corrections to arrive on their own. Many Canadians are too polite to correct another adult's English. If they understand your point, they are satisfied, and the conversation moves on. That is kind, but it has a cost: the same small mistakes can stay in your English for years, because nobody ever mentions them. If you want feedback from colleagues or friends, tell

them clearly that you welcome it, and ask again from time to time. This is also one reason a teacher is so valuable: correcting you is part of the job.

## Learning from natural feedback

Not all feedback comes as correction. Much of it is indirect:

- A listener asks you to repeat something. (Pronunciation or clarity?)
- Someone answers a different question from the one you asked. (Word choice or structure?)
- People laugh when you did not expect it. (A double meaning? A cultural difference?)
- Someone rephrases what you said. (Often a model of the more natural form.)

Paying attention to these signals, without taking them personally, gives you a constant stream of free information.

> **From my lessons: the feedback log**
>
> *This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*
>
> Priscila, 36, had been an auditor at an international firm in São Paulo. In our lessons, when I corrected her, she often became quiet and embarrassed, and sometimes explained why her version was "also correct."
>
> One day, I asked her how she had handled audit review notes from her managers. "I logged every point," she said, "and I closed each one with evidence."
>
> "What if we did the same with English?" I asked.

She created a feedback log: date, error, correct form, three practice sentences and a "closed" column, which she marked only when she had used the correct form naturally in conversation three times. Within two months, she had closed over sixty points. "I stopped feeling corrected," she said. "I started feeling like I was managing my English."

## Look in the mirror

1. How did you use feedback in your professional life?
2. How do you react to feedback on your English? Is it different? Why?
3. Which step of the professional approach do you most often skip?
4. Who could give you specific feedback on your English? How will you ask?
5. What natural feedback have you received recently, such as being asked to repeat or being rephrased?

## Say it in English

**Asking for and receiving feedback**

- *"Thanks, that's really helpful."*
- *"Just to make sure I understand: I should say...?"*
- *"What's the most important thing I should work on?"*
- *"Please feel free to correct my English. I really appreciate it."*
- *"How would you say that more naturally?"*
- *"Could you give me one thing to keep and one thing to change?"*

**Model answer.** *"How do you respond to constructive criticism?"*

> *"I see it as valuable information. In my previous role as an auditor, I received review notes on every file, and I learned to log each point, understand it and close it properly. I do the same with my English now: I keep a feedback log, practise each correction and check that I'm using it naturally. It's helped me improve much faster."*

**Em português.** *É errando que se aprende* (literally, "it is by making mistakes that you learn"). In English: *We learn from our mistakes*.

**Falso amigo:** *assist / attend* ≠ *assistir / atender*. *Assist* means *ajudar*; *assistir* a meeting is *attend*, and *assistir* TV is *watch*. *Atender* the phone is *answer*, and *atender* a client is *serve* or *help*.

**Teacher's note**

Make feedback specific and actionable: "You explained the problem clearly and gave two reasons. Next, work on smoother transitions" is far more useful than "Good job." Connect the student's professional feedback experience to language learning; professionals who logged

audit findings, review notes or client feedback can transfer that system directly. Encourage students to request feedback from colleagues, too.

**Key points**

- Language feedback often feels more personal than work feedback, but it is still data.
- Use the professional approach: receive, understand, record, practise, check.
- Ask for specific feedback, and tell people clearly that you welcome it.
- Pay attention to natural feedback: requests to repeat, misunderstandings, rephrasings.

# 43. Telling Your Story in English

> *If you cannot explain your value, other people may not recognize it.*

Throughout this book, you have been collecting your story: your inventory, your success formula, your resilience history, your evidence file. Now it is time to tell that story in English, clearly and confidently, to people who do not know you.

This matters more than almost any other English skill. In job interviews, networking events, first meetings with colleagues and conversations with neighbours, people will ask about you. The way you answer shapes how they see you, and how you see yourself.

## Why preparation matters

In your first language, you can tell your story spontaneously. In English, especially under pressure, your story can shrink. You forget your best examples. You use simple words that do not reflect the complexity of your work. You undersell yourself.

Preparation closes that gap. A well-prepared story lets your real experience come through, even when your English is still developing. The goal is to sound prepared, not memorized: you know the structure and the key phrases, but you speak naturally.

## The problem–action–result–learning structure

For any example from your work or life, use four parts:

1. **Problem:** What was the situation or challenge?

2. **Action:** What did *you* do? Be specific about your own contribution.
3. **Result:** What happened? Include numbers or concrete outcomes if possible.
4. **Learning:** What did you learn, or what does this show about you?

For example:

> *"Our team was missing deadlines because different departments were using different tracking systems. I proposed a shared weekly review, clarified who was responsible for each task and created a simple progress report. Within two months, we were identifying delays about two weeks earlier, and on-time delivery rose from around 60% to over 90%. I learned that a clear process can stop small problems from becoming expensive ones."*

Notice the result. An earlier draft said *"on-time delivery improved significantly."* That is true, but it is easy to forget. *"From around 60% to over 90%"* is the same fact, made memorable. The Result is the part of the story that interviewers remember most, so it is where numbers matter most:

| Vague result | Quantified result |
|---|---|
| "Sales improved." | "Sales in my region grew by 18% in one year." |
| "I managed a big team." | "I led a team of twelve across two shifts." |
| "We saved a lot of time." | "We cut processing time from five days to two." |
| "Customers were happier." | "Complaints fell by a third in six months." |

Be honest. Do not exaggerate numbers or claim results you cannot support. A modest, precise example is far more credible than an impressive but vague one.

## Three versions of your story

Prepare your story in three lengths, because you will need all three:

| Version | When you use it | What it includes |
|---|---|---|
| **20 seconds** | Introductions, networking, social events | Who you are, what you do, what kind of work interests you |
| **90 seconds** | "Tell me about yourself" in interviews | Your professional path, one key strength, your direction in Canada |
| **3 minutes** | Behavioural interview questions | One detailed example using problem–action–result–learning |

## Practising your story

1. **Write it first.** If it helps, write the ideas in Portuguese, then build the English version. Do not translate word for word.
2. **Simplify.** Replace long sentences with short ones. Remove words you find hard to pronounce if there is a simpler alternative.
3. **Say it aloud.** Many times. Then record it and listen.
4. **Get feedback.** Ask a teacher or a trusted listener about clarity, structure and naturalness.
5. **Use bullet points, not a script.** Practise from key words, so that you sound natural rather than recited.
6. **Update it.** As your life in Canada develops, so does your story.

> **From my lessons: three lengths**
>
> *This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*
>
> Otávio, 41, had been a commercial manager for an agribusiness company in Mato Grosso. In Saskatoon, he went to a professional networking event and, when someone asked what he did, he spoke for almost five minutes. "I saw their eyes go away," he told me.

We built his three versions. The 20-second version: *"I'm a commercial manager with fifteen years in agribusiness in Brazil, mostly in grain trading. I'm looking for opportunities in the agricultural sector here in Saskatchewan."* The 90-second version added his career path and his strength in building client relationships. The three-minute version told the story of a contract he had renegotiated during a drought.

At the next event, he used the 20-second version. The person replied, "Oh, you should talk to my colleague." That conversation became an informational interview, and then a referral.

## Look in the mirror

1. Choose one strong example from your career. Write it using problem–action–result–learning.
2. Write your 20-second version.
3. Write your 90-second version.
4. Which parts of your story are hardest to say in English? Can you simplify them?
5. Record all three versions this week. Who could give you feedback?

## Say it in English

**Useful phrases for telling your story**

- *"I've spent most of my career in..."*
- *"The challenge we were facing was..."*
- *"What I did was..."*
- *"As a result, ..."*
- *"...increased by [20%] / from [X] to [Y]."*
- *"...cut [costs / time / errors] by about [a third]."*
- *"That meant that..."* (the "so what?")
- *"What I took away from that experience was..."*
- *"That's why I'm interested in..."*

**Model answer (90 seconds).** *"Tell me about yourself."*

> *"I'm a commercial manager with fifteen years of experience in agribusiness. I started as a sales analyst in Mato Grosso and moved into management, where I led a team responsible for grain contracts with some of the largest producers in the region. My biggest strength is building long-term client relationships, and I've been able to keep key clients through some very difficult seasons. I moved to Saskatchewan last year because the agricultural sector here is strong and I want to continue in that field. I'm currently building my knowledge of the Canadian market, and I'm looking for a role where I can contribute to client development."*

**Em português.** *Quem conta um conto aumenta um ponto* (literally, "whoever tells a tale adds a stitch"). In English: *A story grows every time it's told*. A useful warning: tell your story well, but never exaggerate it.

**Teacher's note**

Every student should leave your course with three rehearsed versions of their story. Work on them over several lessons: write, simplify, practise aloud, record and refine. Watch for underselling, vague claims and translation from Portuguese. Telling their own story well is often the moment when students begin to believe it again.

**Key points**

- Telling your story in English is one of the most important skills for life in Canada.
- Prepare, so that your story does not shrink under pressure. Sound prepared, not memorized.
- Use problem–action–result–learning, and be honest about your own contribution.
- Have three versions ready: 20 seconds, 90 seconds and 3 minutes.

# 44. The Mindset That Accelerates English

> *Grammar can be taught in a lesson. The mindset that makes it stick has to be built by the learner.*

After many years of teaching adult professionals, I am convinced of something that is not always discussed in language courses: **mindset is one of the strongest factors in how fast an adult learns English.**

Two students can start at the same level, with the same teacher, the same materials and the same amount of time. A year later, one is confident and fluent in professional situations; the other is still hesitant. The difference is rarely intelligence or talent. Very often, it is mindset.

This lesson brings together the ideas of Part V into one picture.

## The accelerating mindset

The students who progress fastest share a recognizable set of attitudes:

- **"I have learned difficult things before."** They remember their track record and apply it (Lessons 9, 12 and 36).
- **"Small and daily beats big and occasional."** They build English into their routine (Lesson 37).
- **"I compete with my past self."** They measure their own progress, not others' (Lesson 38).
- **"Mistakes are part of the plan."** They speak, often and imperfectly (Lesson 39).
- **"That's interesting. What does it mean?"** They are curious about real English (Lesson 40).

- **"A plateau means I need a new strategy."** They persist intelligently (Lesson 41).
- **"Feedback is data."** They seek it, record it and use it (Lesson 42).
- **"I know my value, and I can explain it."** They tell their story with confidence (Lesson 43).

## The slowing mindset

The opposite attitudes slow progress, sometimes dramatically:

- *"I'm too old to learn properly."*
- *"I'll speak when my English is good enough."*
- *"Everyone else is better than me."*
- *"My English is terrible."*
- *"I'll never sound natural, so why try?"*
- *"Corrections make me feel stupid."*
- *"Anyone could have done what I did in Brazil."*

Notice that many of these are not really about English. They are about identity, confidence and self-judgment, the subjects of Part IV. That is why the self-analysis in this book is not separate from language learning. It is part of it.

## Mindset is not positive thinking

The accelerating mindset is not about pretending everything is easy, or telling yourself that your English is perfect. It is about accuracy: seeing your abilities, your progress and your challenges as they really are, and responding with action.

An accurate mindset says: *"My English is not where I want it to be yet. I have a track record of learning difficult things. Here is my plan, and here is my evidence that it is working."*

## Watching your own mindset

Teachers can notice changes in mindset, and in Lesson 50 we look at how. But you can also watch your own. Once a week, ask yourself:

1. What did I tell myself about my English this week?
2. Was it accurate, or was it a verdict?
3. Did I avoid any situations because of fear?
4. What evidence of progress did I collect?
5. What is one mindset I want to practise next week?

> **From my lessons: two students, one starting point**
>
> *This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*
>
> Two students started lessons with me in the same month. Both were in their forties, both had business degrees and MBAs, both had worked in banking in São Paulo, and both started at almost the same level.
>
> The first spoke constantly in our lessons, made many mistakes, asked constantly about expressions she heard at work and kept a notebook of corrections. When she had a bad day, she said, "Okay, what do I need to practise?"
>
> The second was more accurate but spoke much less. He compared himself with colleagues and often said, "My English is terrible." When corrected, he apologized. When he had a bad day, he cancelled his next lesson.

After one year, the first was working as a client relationship manager at a Canadian bank. The second was still preparing to apply. His English was good. He did not yet believe it.

Several months later, after we worked on his evidence file and his story, he applied, and he was hired. The English had been ready for some time. The mindset had needed to catch up.

## Look in the mirror

1. Which accelerating attitudes do you already have?
2. Which slowing attitudes do you recognize in yourself?
3. Choose one slowing attitude. Rewrite it as an accurate statement.
4. What did you tell yourself about your English this week?
5. Which mindset will you practise next week, and how?

## Say it in English

**Speaking about yourself accurately**

- *"My English isn't where I want it to be yet, but it's improving steadily."*
- *"I've made a lot of progress in..."*
- *"I'm working on..."*
- *"I have a clear plan for..."*
- *"I learn quickly when I..."*

**Model answer.** *"How would you rate your English?"*

> *"I'd say it's strong in professional situations. I'm comfortable in meetings, I write reports and emails every day, and I can explain complex topics in my field clearly. I'm still working on speed in informal conversations, and I've seen steady improvement there over the past few months. I'm always learning, and I have a clear plan for continuing to improve."*

**Em português.** *Ver para crer* (literally, "to see in order to believe"). In English: *Seeing is believing*. That is why you collect evidence of your progress.

**Teacher's note**

Listen for slowing-mindset statements in lessons and treat them as seriously as grammar errors. Gently ask the student to rephrase them accurately. Over time, students begin to catch themselves. In my experience, changing how a student talks about their English is often

the turning point after which their English itself begins to change faster.

**Key points**

- Mindset is one of the strongest factors in how fast adults learn English.
- The accelerating mindset uses your track record, daily practice, self-comparison, mistakes, curiosity, persistence, feedback and your story.
- Slowing attitudes are often about identity and self-judgment, not about English itself.
- Aim for accuracy, not positive thinking. Watch your own mindset every week.

PART VI

# The Traits That Master Immigration

*Turn your edge into a life in Canada.*

# 45. Which of Your Traits Will Help You Succeed in Canada?

> *An advantage becomes useful only when you identify it, adapt it and use it on purpose.*

The final part of this book turns from English to the wider project: building a successful life in Canada. The question is the same one we asked about English in Lesson 36, applied to immigration as a whole: *which of your traits will help you succeed here?*

The answer is not automatic. A degree, a strong work ethic, a successful career and the willingness to start again can all help, but none of them guarantees recognition, a good job or a satisfying life. An advantage becomes useful when you identify it, adapt it to the local context and use it deliberately. That is what the Brazilian edge really means: not a guarantee, but a set of resources that can be turned into strategy.

## Your traits in the Canadian context

Here is how the traits we have explored throughout this book typically serve newcomers in Canada:

| Your trait | How it helps in Canada |
|---|---|
| Lifelong learning | Gaining Canadian credentials and local knowledge efficiently |
| Healthy competitiveness | Setting ambitious, measurable goals and pursuing them |
| Discipline | Sustaining effort through a long transition |
| Hunger | Motivation that survives rejections and setbacks |

| Your trait | How it helps in Canada |
|---|---|
| Humility | Accepting bridge jobs and learning from people with less experience |
| Couple partnership | Sharing the load strategically between two people |
| Resilience | Recovering from the inevitable bad weeks |
| Relationships | Building the network that opens doors |
| Adaptability | Learning Canadian norms while keeping your values |
| Responsibility | Being seen quickly as reliable and trustworthy |

## Every strength has a shadow

Each of these traits can also work against you if it is used without awareness. In this book, we have seen many examples:

- **Hunger** can become exhaustion (Lesson 24).
- **Humility** can become self-erasure (Lesson 31).
- **Competitiveness** can become unfair comparison (Lesson 38).
- **Lifelong learning** can become collecting certificates without a strategy (Lesson 2).
- **Responsibility** can become carrying everything alone (Lesson 14).
- **Relationships** can become a comfortable bubble inside one community (Lesson 16).

Recognizing the shadow side is not a criticism of the trait. It is how you keep using it well.

## From traits to strategy

The rest of Part VI looks at how to turn these traits into a practical strategy for Canada:

- **Lesson 46:** Using strategy instead of only effort.
- **Lesson 47:** Learning the Canadian context without losing yourself.
- **Lesson 48:** Building a network with integrity.
- **Lesson 49:** Making a bridge job serve a purpose.
- **Lesson 50:** How teachers can support all of this.
- **Lesson 51:** Building the life you came for.
- **Lesson 52:** Your Brazilian edge, in your own words.

**From my lessons: the strengths and shadows table**

*This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*

Paulo, the systems analyst we met in Lesson 2 with nine online certificates, completed a strengths-and-shadows table in one of our lessons. In one column, he wrote his main traits. In the second, how each helped him in Canada. In the third, its shadow.

When he reached "lifelong learning," he laughed. In the shadow column, he wrote: *I learn instead of applying. Courses feel safer than interviews.*

Then he stopped laughing. "It's happening again," he said. A year after the change described in Lesson 2, after two difficult rejections, he had quietly signed up for two new online courses. The old shadow had come back.

The difference was the speed. The first time, it took him two years to notice. This time, it took a week. He finished one course that a hiring

manager had actually mentioned, dropped the other and went back to applications. Shadows do not disappear. You simply learn to recognize them sooner.

## Look in the mirror

1. Which five traits from the table are strongest in you?
2. For each one, write how it is helping you in Canada right now.
3. For each one, write its shadow: how it could work against you.
4. Which shadow is most active in your life at the moment?
5. What is one adjustment that would help you use that trait more effectively?

## Say it in English

**Describing your strengths and how you manage them**

- *"One of my biggest strengths is... In Canada, it's helped me to..."*
- *"I'm very driven, so I've had to learn to pace myself."*

- *"I'm a lifelong learner, but I try to be strategic about which courses I take."*
- *"I'm aware that I sometimes..., so I make sure to..."*

**Model answer.** *"What are your greatest strengths?"*

> *"I'd say discipline and a strong commitment to learning. I completed two degrees while working full time, and since arriving in Canada I've completed a professional certification in my field. I've also learned to be strategic: I focus my learning on what's directly relevant to my goals, so I can apply it immediately."*

**Em português.** *Não há rosa sem espinhos* (literally, "there is no rose without thorns"). In English: *Every rose has its thorn*. Every strength has a shadow.

**Teacher's note**

The strengths-and-shadows table is a powerful reflective exercise for advanced students. It practises vocabulary for personality and professional qualities, and it helps students prepare honest, balanced answers to interview questions about strengths and weaknesses.

**Key points**

- Your traits are resources for life in Canada, not guarantees.
- Each trait helps in specific ways, from learning credentials to building networks.
- Every strength has a shadow when used without awareness.
- The goal is to turn your traits into a deliberate strategy.

# 46. Strategy Over Effort: Ten Applications, Not a Hundred

> *Hard work is your engine. Strategy is your steering wheel.*

My students know how to work hard. That is never their problem. When they decide to find a job in Canada, they often do it the way they have done everything else: with enormous effort. They send fifty, a hundred, sometimes two hundred applications. They apply to everything that seems even slightly relevant, late into the night, after long shifts.

And very often, they hear nothing back.

The conclusion they draw is painful: *Canada doesn't want me. My experience is worthless here.* But in many cases, the problem is not the person. It is the strategy.

## Why mass applications often fail

Sending many generic applications can feel productive. But it has serious weaknesses:

- **Generic résumés are easy to reject.** If your résumé does not clearly match the specific job, it may not pass the first screening, whether by a person or by software.
- **Volume reduces quality.** Each application receives less thought, less research and less tailoring.
- **No learning.** When you send a hundred applications and receive no responses, you have no way to know what is going wrong.

- **Discouragement.** Silence after so much effort is exhausting and damaging to confidence.

## A more strategic approach

The alternative is not to work less. It is to work more precisely. I often suggest to my students: *ten excellent applications are worth more than a hundred generic ones.*

1. **Define your target.** Choose one or two types of role that genuinely fit your experience and that are realistic in the short term.
2. **Research each application.** Understand the organization, the role and what the employer most needs.
3. **Tailor your résumé and cover letter.** Use the language of the job posting. Show directly how your experience matches the main requirements.
4. **Find a human connection.** Is there someone at the organization you could speak to? A former colleague, an alumni contact, someone from a professional association? (Lesson 48 explores this.)
5. **Follow up.** A short, polite email after a week or two can make your application visible.
6. **Learn from each round.** Track your applications and responses. If ten tailored applications produce no interviews, change something: the target, the résumé, the approach.

## Track it like a project

Many of my students managed projects with detailed tracking. A simple application tracker brings the same discipline to the job search:

| Organization and role | Date and contact | Result and lesson |
|---|---|---|
| Logistics coordinator, ABC Co. | 3 March; referral from former colleague | Interview; asked about Canadian safety standards |
| Operations analyst, XYZ Ltd. | 7 March; online application | No response; résumé not tailored enough |

After a few weeks, patterns appear. Applications with a human connection may get more responses. A particular type of role may attract more interest. The tracker turns frustration into information.

## The monthly strategy review

At the end of each month, write down three actions you took, the evidence of what happened, one lesson and one adjustment. Include progress that is easy to overlook: a clearer interview answer, a new professional contact, better understanding of your target industry. Then ask: *What will I continue, stop or change next month?*

If an approach is not producing results, review the approach before judging yourself.

## Apply from Brazil, or move first?

One of the first strategic decisions is where to search from. Some professionals apply for Canadian jobs while they are still in Brazil. Others move first and search once they are here. There is no single right answer. It depends on your situation:

- **Children.** Moving with children before you have a job means paying rent, setting up a home and covering childcare from savings alone. For many families, that makes a job offer, or a much larger savings plan, more important. A single professional, or a couple without children, can usually take more risk.

- **Savings.** A search from inside Canada can take months. How many months of rent and living costs can you really cover?
- **Your profession.** In regulated professions, parts of the licensing process can often begin from Brazil, and some steps must be completed before you can work in your field.
- **Your immigration status.** Your permit, and your partner's, decides who can work, and when. Check the current official rules.
- **Interviews.** Some employers prefer candidates who can meet in person and start soon. Applying from abroad is possible, but it is often slower.

The best source of practical information is often other Brazilians who have already made this decision, in both directions. Ask several of them, ideally in your field and in a situation like yours, what worked, what they would do differently and what it really cost. Then make your own decision with your eyes open.

> **From my lessons: one hundred and twelve**
>
> *This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*
>
> Eduardo, the HR professional from Lesson 23, had a second problem besides "Canadian experience." In his first eight months in Winnipeg, he had sent 112 applications, almost all with the same résumé. Most received no reply at all.
>
> While he was building his volunteer project, we agreed on a new rule: no more than three applications per week, each one researched and tailored, and each one with an attempt to find a human connection. He also started a tracker.
>
> In the first month, he sent ten applications. He had two informational conversations with HR professionals and, a few weeks later, the

interview described in Lesson 23. “I worked fewer hours on applications,” he said, “and I finally got information back.”

## Look in the mirror

1. How many applications have you sent? How many responses have you received?
2. How much do you tailor each application?
3. What specific types of role are you targeting? Is the target clear enough?
4. Create an application tracker. After four weeks, what patterns do you see?
5. What will you continue, stop or change next month?

## Say it in English

**Professional follow-up and job-search language**

- *“I’m writing to follow up on my application for the… position.”*

- *"I remain very interested in the role, and I'd be happy to provide any further information."*
- *"I noticed that your team is working on..., and I have experience in..."*
- *"I'm focusing my search on... roles in the... sector."*
- *"Would you have fifteen minutes for a short conversation about your experience in...?"*

**Model answer.** *"How has your job search been going?"*

> *"It's going much better since I changed my approach. At first I applied very broadly, but I've become much more focused. I'm now targeting operations and logistics coordination roles, tailoring each application and connecting with people in the industry. I track everything, so I can see what's working. I've had some good conversations recently, and I'm learning a lot about the market here."*

**Em português.** *Mais vale qualidade do que quantidade* (literally, "quality is worth more than quantity"). In English: *Quality over quantity*.

**Teacher's note**

Many students describe the job search only in terms of effort ("I've sent a hundred applications"). Help them shift to strategy language: targets, tailoring, connections, tracking and review. Working on a real job posting in a lesson, analyzing its language and tailoring a résumé paragraph to match it, is excellent reading, writing and vocabulary practice.

**Key points**

- Mass generic applications often fail and teach you nothing.
- Ten excellent, tailored applications are usually worth more than a hundred generic ones.
- Define your target, research, tailor, find a human connection, follow up and learn.
- Track applications like a project, and review your strategy monthly before judging yourself.

# 47. Learning the Canadian Context Without Losing Yourself

> *You can learn a new way of working without forgetting who you are.*

Every workplace has written rules and unwritten ones. The written rules are in policies and procedures. The unwritten ones are learned by watching: how people disagree, how decisions are made, how direct you can be with your manager, how long a meeting should last, what "flexible" really means, when it is acceptable to leave.

Many of my students arrive with excellent professional skills and discover that the unwritten rules in Canada are different from those they knew. Not better or worse, but different. Learning them is one of the most important, and least taught, parts of succeeding here.

## Common differences my students notice

Every workplace and every person is different, and these are generalizations, not rules. But these are some of the differences my Brazilian students mention most often:

- **Indirect communication.** Criticism and instructions are often softened: *"You might want to..."* or *"Have you considered...?"* (Lesson 40).
- **Written follow-up.** Decisions and agreements are often confirmed by email.
- **Work–life boundaries.** Many colleagues separate work and personal life more strictly.

- **Punctuality and scheduling.** Meetings tend to start and end on time; calendars matter.
- **Flat hierarchies.** Junior employees may be expected to share opinions openly, even with senior managers.
- **Process and documentation.** There may be more formal procedures than in some Brazilian workplaces.
- **Politeness conventions.** Frequent "please," "thank you" and "sorry," even in casual situations.

## Ask before you assume

The most effective way to learn the context is to ask. Many newcomers hesitate, afraid that questions will make them look less competent. In fact, thoughtful questions usually signal professionalism.

Useful questions in a new workplace include:

- *"What does success look like in this role?"*
- *"How does the team prefer to communicate updates?"*
- *"What's the best way to raise a concern?"*
- *"How is performance evaluated here?"*
- *"Are there any professional credentials or local requirements that matter in this field?"*

## Adapting without disappearing

Learning the Canadian context does not mean erasing your Brazilian identity. Your background is also an asset. Many of my students bring warmth, flexibility, creativity, a talent for building relationships and the ability to solve problems with limited resources. Canadian workplaces, many of which are highly diverse, often value these qualities.

The goal is not to become someone else. It is to become *bicultural*: able to work effectively in the Canadian context while keeping and using the strengths of your own. Belonging grows through participation: asking questions, joining activities, keeping commitments, learning names and showing genuine interest. Do not wait until your English feels perfect before participating. Participation is one of the ways you learn the context and develop the language.

**From my lessons: the meeting that ended on time**

*This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*

Daniela, the supply chain manager from Lesson 15, was frustrated after her first months in Vancouver. "Nobody here really discusses anything," she said. "The meeting ends exactly on time, even if we haven't finished. Then everyone sends emails."

We discussed it in our next lesson. Many of my students have noticed the same thing. Together, we worked out what was happening: the discussion was not ending; it was moving to a different format. Agendas were sent in advance, and people expected to arrive with their opinions prepared. Unresolved items were handled by email or in short follow-up conversations.

Daniela began reading agendas carefully and preparing her points beforehand. She also kept something from her Brazilian style: she would stop by a colleague's desk for a quick, friendly conversation before important meetings. "Now I have both," she said. "The Canadian preparation and the Brazilian coffee."

## Look in the mirror

1. What differences have you noticed between workplaces in Brazil and in Canada?
2. Which differences have been hardest for you?
3. Choose one setting: your workplace, college or neighbourhood. List five things you do not yet understand about how it works.
4. Who could you ask about each of them?
5. Which of your Brazilian strengths are valuable in the Canadian context?

## Say it in English

**Asking about workplace norms**

- *"How do people usually handle... here?"*
- *"Is it okay if I...?"*
- *"What's the usual process for...?"*
- *"Would you prefer that I send this by email or discuss it in person?"*

- *"In my previous workplace, we usually..., so I want to make sure I understand how it works here."*

**Model answer.** *"How would you adapt to our company culture?"*

> *"I'd start by observing and asking questions. When I joined my current workplace, I asked my manager and colleagues how they preferred to communicate, how decisions were made and what success looked like in my role. I find that understanding these things early helps me contribute more quickly. I also think my international experience brings a useful perspective."*

**Em português.** *Em Roma, como os romanos* (literally, "in Rome, as the Romans"). In English: *When in Rome, do as the Romans do*.

**Falso amigo:** *realize* ≠ *realizar*. *Realize* means *perceber*. For *realizar*, say *carry out*, *achieve* or *complete*.

**Teacher's note**

Make unwritten workplace rules an explicit part of the curriculum. Students rarely learn them from textbooks. Invite students to bring examples of situations that confused them, discuss possible interpretations and practise the language to ask about norms. Avoid presenting either culture as better; the goal is effective biculturalism.

**Key points**

- Every workplace has unwritten rules, and Canadian ones may differ from those you knew.
- Common differences include indirectness, written follow-up, boundaries, punctuality and flat hierarchies.

- Ask before you assume. Thoughtful questions signal professionalism.
- Become bicultural: learn the Canadian context while keeping the strengths of your own.

# 48. Networking With Integrity

> *Networking is not asking for a job. It is building relationships that help both sides.*

Many of my students dislike the word *networking*. For some, it sounds artificial or manipulative. Others feel that asking strangers for help is humiliating, especially when they were once the senior person whom others approached. In Brazil, many found jobs through personal relationships built over years. In Canada, their professional network is small at first.

But networking is essential here. As we saw in Lesson 16, a large share of opportunities come through people: referrals, recommendations and conversations. The question is how to network in a way that feels authentic and respectful.

## What networking really is

Professional networking is not begging for a job. At its best, it is:

- **Learning:** understanding an industry, how people entered it and which skills matter.
- **Becoming known:** letting people see your competence and character over time.
- **Exchanging value:** offering your knowledge, perspective and help, not only asking.
- **Building trust:** through repeated, sincere contact.

You do not need to turn every social interaction into a career transaction. Build relationships that are mutually respectful.

## The informational interview

One of the most useful networking tools in Canada is the *informational interview*: a short conversation, often 15 to 30 minutes, with someone working in your field, to learn about their experience. You are not asking for a job. You are asking for information.

A typical structure:

1. **The request.** A short, polite message explaining who you are and why you would value their perspective.
2. **Preparation.** Research the person and the organization. Prepare five or six thoughtful questions.
3. **The conversation.** Respect their time. Listen more than you speak. Ask about their path, the industry, the skills that matter.
4. **The close.** Thank them. Ask: *"Is there anyone else you'd recommend I speak with?"*
5. **The follow-up.** Send a thank-you message within 24 hours. Later, update them on your progress.

## Where to network

- **Professional associations** in your field, many of which have newcomer programs.
- **Alumni networks** of Brazilian or international universities.
- **Volunteering,** especially in roles that use your professional skills.
- **LinkedIn,** with a complete profile and a clear, honest headline.
- **Mentoring programs** for newcomers, often offered by settlement organizations.
- **Your current workplace,** including your bridge job (Lesson 49).

- **Community activities:** sports, churches, parents' associations, cultural events.

## Integrity in networking

Integrity means being honest about who you are and what you want, respecting people's time and boundaries, following up when you say you will and giving as well as receiving. It also means never exaggerating your experience or credentials. In a smaller professional community, reputation travels quickly.

Your talent for connection (Lesson 16) is a great advantage here, as long as you combine Brazilian warmth with Canadian respect for time and boundaries.

> **From my lessons: the first message**
>
> *This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*
>
> Juliana, the pharmacist from Lesson 20, wanted to understand hospital pharmacy in Canada but did not know anyone. "I can't just write to a stranger," she said. "It's embarrassing."
>
> We wrote a message together: *"Hello, Ms. Thompson. I'm a pharmacist trained in Brazil, currently completing my Canadian licensing process. I read your article on medication safety programs and found it very relevant to my previous work. Would you have 20 minutes in the coming weeks for a short conversation about your experience in hospital pharmacy? I'd really appreciate your perspective."*
>
> She sent it, and two others like it. Two people replied. One conversation led to an invitation to a professional association event. "I thought

networking meant asking for favours," Juliana said. "It was actually just a good professional conversation."

## Look in the mirror

1. How do you feel about networking? Where does that feeling come from?
2. Who do you already know in Canada who works in or near your field?
3. Which networking places from this lesson could you use in the next month?
4. Write a request for an informational interview with someone in your field.
5. What value could you offer to the people in your network?

## Say it in English

**Networking phrases**

- *"I'd really appreciate your perspective on…"*
- *"How did you get started in this field?"*
- *"What skills do you think are most important for someone entering this industry?"*
- *"Is there anyone else you'd recommend I speak with?"*
- *"Thank you so much for your time. Our conversation was really helpful."*
- *"I wanted to let you know that I followed your advice and…"*

**Model answer.** *(At a professional event.) "So, what brings you here?"*

> *"I'm a pharmacist. I worked in hospital pharmacy in Brazil for twelve years, and I'm now completing my licensing process here. I came tonight to learn more about the profession in Canada and meet people in the field. What about you? How long have you been involved with the association?"*

**Em português.** *Gentileza gera gentileza* (literally, "kindness generates kindness"). In English: *Kindness breeds kindness; one good turn deserves another.*

**Teacher's note**

Practise networking through role-plays: requesting an informational interview, opening a conversation at an event and following up. Many students have never written a networking message in English; a well-

crafted template, adapted to each student's field, often gives them the confidence to send their first one.

**Key points**

- Networking is learning, becoming known, exchanging value and building trust, not begging.
- Informational interviews are one of the most useful tools in Canada.
- Network through associations, alumni, volunteering, LinkedIn, mentoring, work and community.
- Network with integrity: honesty, respect, follow-up and giving as well as receiving.

# 49. The Bridge Job With a Purpose

> *A bridge is meant to be crossed, not lived on.*

Many of my students take jobs far below their professional level when they arrive in Canada: cleaning offices, working in kitchens, stocking shelves, driving deliveries, caring for the elderly. They do it to pay the bills, to learn the language, to gain Canadian experience and, often, to support a partner who is studying.

This is honest work, and there is no shame in it. In Lesson 7, I described this as strategic humility. In Lesson 8, we saw that the cleaning job is not the story. This lesson is about making sure that the bridge job does what a bridge is supposed to do: take you somewhere.

## When a bridge becomes a destination

The risk is not the bridge job itself. The risk is staying on the bridge without deciding to. It happens gradually. The job pays the rent. The schedule becomes routine. You are too tired after work to study or network. Months become years. One day, you realize that the temporary job has become permanent, and nobody, including you, made that decision.

Some people do decide to stay in a job that was meant to be temporary, because it suits their life, their family or their priorities. That is a legitimate choice. The problem is only when it happens by default.

## What a bridge job can give you

A well-used bridge job can provide much more than income:

- **English practice,** especially informal, spoken and workplace English.
- **Canadian references** who can speak about your reliability and attitude.
- **Knowledge of Canadian workplace culture.**
- **Contacts,** sometimes surprisingly useful ones.
- **Time,** if the schedule allows study or a partner's education.
- **Evidence** that you can succeed in a Canadian environment.

## The bridge job review

Every few months, review your bridge job with five questions:

1. **What does this job provide?** Income, English practice, contacts, references, time or something else?
2. **What is it costing me?** In energy, time and opportunity.
3. **What skill or qualification would help me move forward?**
4. **What is one practical step I can take this month?**
5. **When will I review whether this job is still serving its purpose?**

Write your answers down. Set a date for the next review. This simple practice is often the difference between a bridge and a trap.

## Using the bridge job actively

You can also make the bridge job work harder for you:

- **Set English goals at work:** a certain number of conversations, new expressions or phone calls each week.
- **Be the most reliable person on the team.** A strong reference is worth a great deal.

- **Tell people your story.** Colleagues and supervisors may know someone in your field.
- **Look for responsibility.** Training new staff, improving a process, helping with scheduling. These become examples for interviews.
- **Use the job's structure** to protect time for study, applications and networking.

And remember the sentence from Lesson 7: *"This is what I am doing now. It is not the only thing I can do."*

**From my lessons: the bridge job that became a plan**

*This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*

Marcelo, the former logistics director from Lesson 7, had set a date in his phone: one year in the kitchen, then a review. When the date arrived, he was honest with himself. The kitchen had taught him what it could. "If I don't plan the next step now," he said, "this becomes my life."

We did the bridge job review together. The job provided income, English practice and a strong reference from the head chef. It was costing him energy and evening time. He set a three-month plan: continue working; practise a defined set of English tasks at work; contact an employment service for newcomers; speak with two people in logistics; and prepare two work stories in English, using problem–action–result–learning.

At the three-month review, he had done all five. One of the people he spoke with was a former supplier to the restaurant who worked for a regional distribution company. Two months later, Marcelo started there

as a warehouse operations supervisor. "The kitchen was a good bridge," he said. "I'm glad I didn't stay on it."

## Look in the mirror

1. If you have a bridge job, what does it provide you?
2. What is it costing you?
3. What skill or qualification would help you move forward?
4. What is one practical step you can take this month?
5. When will you next review whether the job is still serving its purpose? Write the date.

## Say it in English

**Explaining a bridge job positively**

- *"I took this role to gain Canadian experience while I..."*
- *"It's given me a great opportunity to improve my English and learn how Canadian workplaces operate."*

- *"I've been given more responsibility, including..."*
- *"I'm now looking for a role where I can use my experience in..."*
- *"My supervisor would be happy to speak about my work."*

**Model answer.** *"Why are you working in a restaurant if your background is in logistics?"*

> *"When I arrived, I wanted to start working immediately, improve my English and learn how Canadian workplaces operate. The restaurant gave me all of that, and I've become responsible for ordering and inventory, which uses my logistics background. Now I'm ready to return to my field, and I think the combination of my experience in Brazil and my Canadian experience makes me a strong candidate."*

**Em português.** *Quem não tem cão caça com gato* (literally, "whoever has no dog hunts with a cat"). In English: *You make do with what you've got*.

**Teacher's note**

Students in bridge jobs often feel embarrassed to discuss them. Help them reframe the job in English as a purposeful step, and practise answering questions about it confidently. The bridge job review works well as a quarterly activity; it keeps students focused on their direction without dismissing the value of their current work.

**Key points**

- A bridge job is honest, valuable work, and it should take you somewhere.
- The risk is staying on the bridge by default, not by decision.

- Review the job regularly: what it provides, what it costs, the next skill, the next step and the review date.
- Use the bridge job actively: English goals, reliability, your story, extra responsibility.

# 50. For Teachers: Watching the Mindset to Accelerate the Language

> *Good teaching develops skill while keeping the learner's real capabilities in view.*

This lesson is written mainly for teachers, tutors and coaches who work with adult immigrant professionals. If you are a student, read it too. It will help you understand what a good teacher is watching for, and how you can watch for the same things yourself.

Throughout this book, I have argued that mindset is one of the strongest factors in how fast an adult learns English. That makes mindset part of the teacher's work. Not as a therapist, but as a professional who notices how a student is engaging with learning and responds with sound teaching practice.

## What to watch for

Adult professionals bring histories, goals, frustrations, responsibilities and expectations into their lessons. Their emotional state affects whether they are willing to take the risks that language learning requires.

Watch for **changes in pattern**, not only mistakes:

- A student who used to speak freely begins apologizing for every error.
- A student starts avoiding harder questions or giving shorter answers.
- A student compares themselves constantly with colleagues or other learners.
- A student refuses compliments or says "my English is terrible" when it is not.

- A student's homework stops, or attendance becomes irregular.
- A student who was engaged becomes distracted or tired.

These changes are worth exploring. They may reveal a language gap, fatigue, workplace pressure, family worries, fear of embarrassment or an unrealistic expectation of rapid progress.

## A practical teaching cycle

1. **Observe.** Notice participation, confidence, avoidance and the language tasks that cause difficulty.
2. **Ask.** Invite the student to explain what they are experiencing rather than guessing. *"I've noticed you've been holding back more in our recent lessons. What feels difficult at the moment?"*
3. **Clarify.** Separate the language problem from the student's interpretation of it. "I paused several times" is a fact; "I'm not intelligent" is an interpretation.
4. **Practise.** Set a specific, achievable but meaningful challenge.
5. **Review.** Compare performance with a previous attempt and identify the next target.

## Specific feedback, not generic praise

*"Your English is great"* may feel pleasant, but it gives the student little information. More useful feedback sounds like this: *"You explained the problem clearly, gave two reasons and answered the follow-up question without switching to Portuguese. Next, let's work on making your transitions smoother."*

The student hears what worked, what improved and what comes next. This is encouragement tied to evidence. It respects the adult learner rather than treating them like a child.

## Remind students of what they bring

One of the teacher's most valuable roles is to see what the student has forgotten. Ask about their careers, their degrees, the difficult things they have learned. Use that history in your lessons: in speaking topics, in model answers, in the way you frame challenges. When a student says "anyone could have done it," ask the questions in Lesson 29. When a student says "I have no discipline," ask how they earned their degrees.

## The limits of the role

The teacher's influence is real but bounded. Teachers should monitor the learning environment, offer respectful feedback, make progress visible and recommend appropriate support when a problem is outside their role. They should not diagnose students, promise psychological transformation or use personal disclosures beyond the agreed teaching purpose. If anxiety or low mood seems persistent or serious, encourage the student to seek professional support.

**Worked example: a teacher's observation note**

| Area | Observation |
|---|---|
| Specific strength | Excellent technical vocabulary in finance; clear written summaries |
| Current bottleneck | Response speed in group discussions |
| Limiting behaviour | Waits for a perfect pause; prepares full sentences before speaking |
| Experiment for next week | "Main idea first" in every discussion; two prepared openers |
| Result at review | Spoke four times (previously once); reported feeling "less invisible" |

Keep observations concrete and confidential. A blank version of this form is in Appendix D.

**From my lessons: the question I almost did not ask**

*This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*

Simone, the student from Lesson 13, had been one of my most active students. Then, over two weeks, she became quiet. Her answers shortened. She stopped volunteering.

I could have assumed she was tired, or that the material was too difficult. Instead, at the end of a lesson, I asked: "I've noticed you've been quieter recently. Is something making our lessons harder at the moment?"

She told me about the rejected application and her son's difficulties at school. The problem was not English. It was a moment when her confidence had collapsed. So when, a few days later, she said in a lesson, "I don't think I can do this," I already knew what was behind it, and which exercise to offer: the resilience history you read about in Lesson 13. Within a month she was participating fully again.

The question took thirty seconds. Without it, I would have spent weeks teaching the wrong thing.

## Look in the mirror

*For teachers:*

1. Choose one student. What is their specific strength?

2. What is their current language bottleneck?
3. What behaviour may be limiting their practice?
4. What experiment could you try next week?
5. When will you review the result together?

*For students:* answer the same five questions about yourself.

## Say it in English

**Phrases for teachers**

- *"I've noticed that... Is something making that difficult right now?"*
- *"You did... really well. Next, let's work on..."*
- *"Compared with last month, you..."*
- *"What would you like to focus on this week?"*
- *"Tell me how you learned... in your previous career."*

**Phrases for students**

- *"I've been finding... difficult lately."*
- *"Could you tell me what I should focus on?"*

- *"Could we practise... in our next lesson?"*

**Em português.** *Quem ensina aprende duas vezes* (literally, "whoever teaches learns twice"). In English: *To teach is to learn twice*. Often attributed to the French writer Joseph Joubert.

**Teacher's note**

The single most effective habit I can recommend is this: when a student's pattern changes, ask a direct, respectful question before assuming the cause. Then listen, and agree on one practical next step. Over time, students learn to notice their own patterns, and that self-awareness becomes one of their strongest learning tools.

**Key points**

- Mindset is part of the teacher's work, but the teacher is not a therapist.
- Watch for changes in patterns: apologizing, avoidance, comparison, silence, fatigue.
- Use the cycle: observe, ask, clarify, practise, review.
- Give specific, evidence-based feedback, remind students of what they bring and respect the limits of the role.

# 51. Build the Life You Came For

> *Success is not a single job title. It is a life you can sustain and respect.*

Immigration is often described as a series of milestones: the visa, the arrival, the first job, the credential, the better job, permanent residence, citizenship. These milestones matter. But they do not answer the most important question: *What do you want your life to become?*

A person can achieve a prestigious title in Canada and be exhausted, isolated or disconnected from their family. Another person can progress more slowly while building a stable life, meaningful relationships and a career with room to grow. Which one is more successful depends on what you came for.

## Define success in your own terms

Many of my students arrived with a clear picture of success: getting back to their professional level as quickly as possible. That is a legitimate goal. But after a year or two in Canada, many discover that their priorities have shifted. Time with children has become more important. Or a new field has become interesting. Or safety and stability matter more than status.

Ask yourself what matters to you in the next five years:

- **Work:** what kind of role, challenge and level?
- **Learning:** what do you want to master?
- **Relationships:** marriage, children, friends, family in Brazil.
- **Contribution:** to your community, profession or other newcomers.
- **Finances:** what level of security do you need?
- **Well-being:** health, rest, joy.

You may want all of these. But they compete for time and energy. Naming the trade-offs helps you make deliberate choices, rather than having choices made for you.

## Protect the people doing the work

A long transition puts pressure on couples and families. One partner may study while the other works (Lesson 5). Both may be tired, and each may feel that their own sacrifices are less visible than the other's. Talk openly about responsibilities, finances, study time, rest and what success means to each of you. Revisit the plan as circumstances change.

A strategy that depends on permanent exhaustion is not a strong strategy. Sleep, relationships, recreation and recovery are not rewards you earn only after everything is finished. They are part of a life that can continue.

## Notice what your children are gaining

When parents talk about the cost of immigration, they usually list what the family has given up. It is worth listing what your children are gaining too.

One change my students mention again and again is how much more autonomy their children have in Canada. In many neighbourhoods, children walk to school on their own or with friends, ride their bicycles around the area and go to the park without an adult. In many large Brazilian cities, parents drive their children almost everywhere. For many families, this everyday freedom becomes one of the quiet reasons the move was worth it.

Many Brazilian children in Canada also grow up with three languages: Portuguese at home, English at school and with friends, and French, which many provinces teach in school and which some families choose through French immersion. That is a remarkable gift, but Portuguese needs protecting. Keep speaking it at home, read together in Portuguese and keep

your children in touch with family in Brazil, or English will slowly take its place.

Notice these gains, and talk about them as a family. On the hard days, they are part of the answer to the question "Why did we come?"

## Keep your identity larger than your performance

There will be weeks when your English improves and weeks when it feels stuck. You may get a job offer, lose an opportunity, pass an exam or need to change direction. None of these events, alone, defines your worth.

You can take your ambitions seriously without treating every setback as a verdict. You can acknowledge your strengths without assuming you are entitled to a particular outcome. You can adapt to Canada without treating your past as irrelevant.

## Your five-year statement

Write one page beginning with: *"Five years from now, I want my life in Canada to include..."*

Cover work, learning, relationships, contribution, finances and well-being. Then circle the three priorities that matter most *now*. For each one, identify one action you can begin within the next seven days.

Read your statement every few months. Update it as your life and priorities change. It is not a contract; it is a compass.

> **From my lessons: two statements, one family**
>
> *This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*

Cristina and her husband, whom we met in Lesson 32, each wrote a five-year statement separately, then read them to each other.

Many priorities were the same: a home of their own, their daughters thriving in school, both of them working in their professions. But there were surprises. Cristina had written that she wanted to help other foreign-trained dentists with the equivalency process. Her husband had written that he wanted to coach his daughters' soccer team, something he had never had time for in Brazil.

"We had been so focused on surviving," Cristina said, "that we had never talked about what kind of life we were actually building." They circled three priorities together and taped the statements next to their six-question maps on the fridge.

## Look in the mirror

1. When you arrived, how did you define success in Canada? Has that definition changed?
2. What matters most to you in the next five years?
3. Which priorities compete with each other? How will you choose?
4. If you have a partner, what does success mean to each of you?
5. Write your five-year statement, circle three priorities and choose one action for each this week.

## Say it in English

**Talking about long-term goals and values**

- *"In five years, I'd like to..."*
- *"What matters most to me is..."*
- *"For me, success means..."*
- *"We've decided to prioritize..."*
- *"I'm building toward..."*
- *"I want a career that also leaves time for..."*

**Model answer.** *"What are your long-term goals?"*

> *"Professionally, I'd like to be working as a dentist here within the next few years, and eventually to help other foreign-trained dentists through the equivalency process, because I know how challenging it can be. Personally, my priority is a stable, healthy life for my family. For me, success means meaningful work and enough time for the people I love."*

**Em português.** *Cada um sabe onde o sapato aperta* (literally, "everyone knows where their shoe pinches"). In English: *Only the wearer knows where the shoe pinches*. Define success in your own terms.

**Teacher's note**

The five-year statement is a rich writing task: future forms, conditionals, values vocabulary and hedging. It also gives the teacher valuable insight into what each student is working toward. Encourage students to revisit it every few months, and to notice how their priorities evolve.

**Key points**

- Milestones matter, but they do not answer what you want your life to become.
- Define success in your own terms: work, learning, relationships, contribution, finances, well-being.
- Protect the people doing the work. Permanent exhaustion is not a strategy.
- Write a five-year statement, circle three priorities and act on each this week.

# 52. Your Brazilian Edge: A Letter to Your Future Self

> *You arrived with more than you knew. Write it down, so you never forget again.*

We began this book with a simple statement: *you are not starting from zero.*

Over fifty-one lessons, we have tried to prove it. You have looked at the profile of the people who arrive: educated, experienced, married, still studying, hungry and humble. You have examined why you have been successful, and found the discipline, learning methods, resilience, responsibility, composure, relationships and adaptability behind your results. You have named your biggest challenges precisely and turned them into plans. You have looked honestly in the mirror, at impostor syndrome, harsh verdicts, pride, humility, identity and evidence. And you have seen how the same traits that built your career can help you master English and build a life in Canada.

That is the Brazilian edge. Not a guarantee. Not a claim that one nationality is better than another. It is the specific set of resources you carried across: education, professional experience, family cooperation, discipline, adaptability, perspective and a history of learning through difficulty. Some readers will recognize many of these in themselves. Others will discover different strengths. The work is to find yours, understand them and use them deliberately.

## Why a letter

Impostor syndrome, as we saw in Lesson 28, creeps in slowly. Months from now, after a hard week, a rejection or a long plateau, you may forget what you

have discovered in this book. You may start to believe again that anyone could have done what you did, or that you are starting from zero.

A letter to your future self is protection against that forgetting. It is written now, while the evidence is fresh, by the person who knows the truth about you best.

## How to write it

Write a letter of one or two pages, addressed to yourself, to be read in one year. Write it in English. If some parts are easier in Portuguese, you may include them, but try to write most of it in English: it is also evidence of how far your English has come.

Include:

1. **What you bring.** Your degrees, your career, your most important achievements, specifically.
2. **Why you have been successful.** Your success formula from Lesson 18.
3. **What you have learned about yourself.** Your discoveries from Part IV.
4. **Your biggest challenge right now,** and your plan for it.
5. **The traits that will help you master English and succeed in Canada.**
6. **What you will not sacrifice.** Your non-negotiables from Lesson 32.
7. **Your hopes for the person reading the letter.** What do you hope will be true in one year?
8. **A message for a hard day.** What do you want to say to yourself when things are difficult?

Seal it, or save it somewhere you will find it. Put the date to open it in your calendar.

**Worked example: an extract from a letter**

*This extract is fictional. It is written in the voice of Mariana, the composite from Lessons 9 and 18.*

"Dear Mariana,

If you're reading this, a year has passed. I hope you're working in finance again, but if you're not, I want you to remember some things.

You worked for fifteen years as a financial analyst. You built a forecast that three departments relied on. You trained four new analysts. You cut reporting errors by about 70%. That was not luck, and not just anyone could have done it.

Right now, my biggest challenge is speaking in meetings. My plan is to prepare two points before every meeting and say the main idea first. I hope that, by the time you read this, it feels natural.

On a hard day, remember this: you are new here, and you are very capable. Both are true."

**From my lessons: the letter, one year later**

*This is a fictional composite based on a pattern I have seen many times. It does not describe any one real student.*

Ricardo, the operations director from Lesson 29, wrote his letter during his first year in Mississauga, when he was still working nights in a warehouse. He set a reminder for one year later.

When the reminder came, he was a shift supervisor at a distribution centre, responsible for forty people. He read the letter on his lunch break and sent me a photograph of the last paragraph: *"Remember the*

*merger. Remember that only you were given that job. Remember that you are not starting from zero."*

Underneath, he had written a short message: "It was all true."

## Look in the mirror

1. Which lesson in this book was most important for you? Why?
2. What is the most important thing you have rediscovered about yourself?
3. What do you want to remember on a hard day?
4. Write your letter to your future self, using the eight points in this lesson.
5. When will you read it? Put the date in your calendar now.

## Say it in English

**Phrases for your letter**

- *"Dear [your name],"*

- *"If you're reading this, ..."*
- *"I want you to remember that..."*
- *"Right now, I'm working on..."*
- *"I hope that by now..."*
- *"On a hard day, remember..."*
- *"You are not starting from zero."*

**Model answer.** *"What would you say is your biggest advantage as a newcomer to Canada?"*

> *"I think it's the combination of what I bring and how I've adapted. I bring fifteen years of professional experience, two degrees and a strong work ethic. Since arriving, I've learned how things work here, improved my English significantly and built a network in my field. I see my international background as an advantage, because I can bring a perspective that's different and, I think, valuable."*

**Em português.** *Ordem e Progresso* (literally, "order and progress"). In English: *Order and Progress*. The motto on the band across the Brazilian flag. The blue globe behind it shows the stars over Rio de Janeiro on the morning of 15 November 1889, the day Brazil became a republic. The stars on the cover of this book are drawn from that sky.

**Teacher's note**

The letter to the future self is an ideal final assignment for a course. It reviews the language of the whole program (past achievements, present challenges, future plans, conditionals and advice) and consolidates the student's self-analysis. If possible, arrange for students to receive their

letters a year later. Many will tell you it arrived at exactly the right moment.

**Key points**

- The Brazilian edge is the set of resources you carried across, not a guarantee and not a claim of superiority.
- Impostor syndrome makes people forget what they bring; a letter to your future self protects against forgetting.
- Write it in English, covering what you bring, your success formula, your discoveries, your challenge, your traits and your non-negotiables.
- Remember what you bring. Use it on purpose. You are not starting from zero.

## A final word from my lessons

Over many years, I have watched hundreds of Brazilian professionals arrive in Canada. I have seen them clean offices and cook in restaurant kitchens. I have heard them say "anyone could have done it" about extraordinary achievements. I have watched impostor syndrome creep into people who had every reason to be confident.

And I have watched them recover their confidence, master English and build lives they are proud of. Not all at once, and not without difficulty. But again and again, the turning point was the same: the moment they remembered what they had brought with them.

That is what I wish for you. Remember what you bring. Use it on purpose. And when you forget, read your letter.

# Appendix A: Self-Analysis Workbook

> *An evidence-based record of what you bring, why you succeed and where you are going.*

This workbook brings together the most important exercises from the 52 lessons. Complete it slowly, over several weeks if necessary. Use specific examples. If you cannot find evidence for a strength you claim, treat that as a question to investigate rather than a reason to criticize yourself. Write in English whenever you can.

## Part 1: What you bring (Part I)

**My degrees, certifications and courses:**

**My professional roles, with scale, duration and results:**

**Informal assets (languages, family cooperation, networks, life skills):**

## Part 2: Why I have been successful (Part II)

**Three achievements I am proud of, each with at least one number (see Appendix G):**

**The traits behind those achievements:**

**My success formula, in one paragraph (80 to 120 words):**

## Part 3: My biggest challenge (Part III)

### My biggest challenge, in one precise sentence:

### Is it mainly a skill, system or mindset challenge?

### My six-question map:

| Question | My answer |
|---|---|
| Destination | |
| Current position | |
| Gap | |
| Next action | |
| Feedback | |
| Review date | |

## Part 4: What I have learned about myself (Part IV)

### Things I have learned about myself since moving to Canada:

**One harsh verdict I have made about myself, and the facts behind it:**

**My non-negotiables:**

**My answer to "What do you do?":**

## Part 5: The traits that will help me master English (Part V)

**My three strongest learning traits, and how I will use each one:**

**My daily twenty-minute practice plan:**

### My most frequent English errors:

## Part 6: The traits that will help me succeed in Canada (Part VI)

### My strengths and their shadows:

| Strength | Its shadow |
|---|---|
| | |
| | |
| | |

### My three priorities for the next five years:

### My next practical step, and its date:

# Appendix B: Your Story in English

> *Prepare a clear, truthful story. Adapt it to the setting rather than memorizing one script.*

## The five-part introduction

Use this structure to build your 90-second introduction (Lesson 43).

### 1. Who I am

*"I'm a [profession or area of experience] with [number] years of experience in [industry, function or type of work]."*

### 2. What I have done

*"In my previous work, I was responsible for [responsibilities]. One achievement I'm proud of is [specific example]."*

### 3. What I learned

*"That experience taught me [skill, insight or lesson]."*

### 4. What I am doing now

*"In Canada, I'm currently [working, studying, improving a skill or exploring a field]."*

### 5. Where I want to go

*"My next goal is [goal], and I'm working toward it by [specific action]."*

## Problem–action–result–learning

Prepare at least three stories in this structure, for behavioural interview questions such as *"Tell me about a time when..."*

Copy this table for each story.

| Part | My story |
|---|---|
| Problem | |
| Action | |
| Result (with a number) | |
| Learning | |

## Three versions

| Version | Use | My key words |
|---|---|---|
| 20 seconds | Introductions, networking | |
| 90 seconds | "Tell me about yourself" | |
| 3 minutes | Behavioural questions | |

## Practice checklist

- Is the main message clear?
- Have I included at least one concrete example, with a number?
- Can I explain my own contribution without exaggerating?
- Have I removed unnecessary detail and jargon?
- Have I explained Brazilian companies or systems that a Canadian listener may not know?
- Can I answer a follow-up question?
- Have I removed hedging words such as *maybe*, *a little* and *I think* where they weaken my message?
- Have I practised enough to sound natural rather than memorized?
- Have I recorded myself and listened?

# Appendix C: A 30-Day Action Plan

> *Build momentum without trying to solve every part of immigration at once.*

This plan turns the main ideas of the book into four weeks of practical action. It works best alongside a daily twenty-minute English routine (Lesson 37).

## Week 1: Remember what you bring

- Complete Parts 1 and 2 of the Self-Analysis Workbook (Appendix A).
- Write your resilience history: three difficult periods and how you handled them (Lesson 13).
- Write your success formula in one paragraph (Lesson 18).
- Start your evidence file (Lesson 35) with at least ten entries.
- Put a number on your three most important achievements, using the worksheet in Appendix G.

## Week 2: Name the challenge and choose a target

- Rewrite your biggest challenge as one precise sentence (Lesson 19).
- Define one career or education objective.
- Find out which credentials or local requirements apply, from official sources (Lesson 22).
- Complete your six-question map (Lesson 26).
- Speak with one informed person in your field, if possible (Lesson 48).

## Week 3: Practise expression

- Prepare your 20-second and 90-second introductions (Lesson 43).
- Prepare one professional story using problem–action–result–learning.
- Record yourself, listen and identify one improvement target.
- Use your introduction or story in a real conversation or lesson.
- Start an expressions notebook and a feedback log (Lessons 40 and 42).

## Week 4: Review and adjust

- Review what improved and what remains difficult.
- Ask a teacher, colleague or friend for specific feedback.
- Identify which actions produced the clearest results.
- Complete your first monthly strategy review: three actions, the evidence, one lesson and one adjustment (Lesson 46).
- Choose three priorities for the next month.

## Day 30 questions

At the end of thirty days, do not ask only, *"Am I successful yet?"* Ask:

1. What do I understand better about myself?
2. What can I do now that I could not do before?
3. What evidence have I collected?
4. What should I change next month?

These questions keep your attention on progress you can build upon.

# Appendix D: For Teachers

> *Watch the mindset as carefully as the grammar.*

This appendix gives teachers, tutors and coaches practical tools for the approach described in Lesson 50.

## The practical teaching cycle

1. **Observe:** participation, confidence, avoidance and the language tasks that cause difficulty.
2. **Ask:** invite the student to explain what they are experiencing, rather than guessing.
3. **Clarify:** separate the language problem from the student's interpretation of it.
4. **Practise:** set a specific, achievable but meaningful challenge.
5. **Review:** compare performance with a previous attempt and identify the next target.

## Mindset observation form

Use one form per student. Keep observations concrete and confidential.

| Area | Observation |
|---|---|
| Student and date | |
| Professional background | |
| Specific strength | |
| Current language bottleneck | |

| Area | Observation |
|---|---|
| Limiting behaviour or belief | |
| Experiment for next week | |
| Result at review | |
| Next target | |

## Signals worth a respectful question

- Apologizing before or after speaking.
- Saying "my English is terrible" when it is not.
- Avoiding harder questions or giving shorter answers.
- Constant comparison with colleagues or other learners.
- Refusing compliments.
- Discounting achievements: "anyone could have done it."
- Sudden changes in homework, attendance or energy.

A useful opening: *"I've noticed you've been holding back more in our recent lessons. What feels difficult at the moment?"* Listen, then agree on one practical next step.

## Activities that build mindset and language together

| Activity | Lessons |
|---|---|
| Three-column inventory | 9 |
| Resilience history | 13 |
| Success formula paragraph | 18 |
| Fact, interpretation, verdict | 30 |
| "What do you do?" answer | 34 |

| Activity | Lessons |
|---|---|
| Monthly recordings | 38 |
| Feedback log | 42 |
| Three versions of your story | 43 |
| Letter to your future self | 52 |

## Boundaries of the role

Teachers monitor the learning environment, give respectful and specific feedback, make progress visible and recommend appropriate support when a problem is outside their role. They do not diagnose, promise psychological transformation or use personal disclosures beyond the agreed teaching purpose. If anxiety or low mood seems persistent or serious, encourage the student to seek professional support.

## Collecting real stories: interview guide and consent

The lesson stories in this book are fictional composites. Teachers and researchers who wish to collect real, permission-based stories from Brazilian immigrants may find these questions useful.

1. What did your professional and family life look like before you moved to Canada?
2. What achievement best represents the kind of person you are? What did it require?
3. When did you first feel less capable because you were speaking English?
4. What did you initially misunderstand about your own abilities or limitations?
5. Did you take a job outside your former profession? What did it provide, and what did it cost?

6. What did you learn about the Canadian job market, education system or workplace that you wish you had known earlier?
7. Who helped you recognize an ability you had begun to discount?
8. What strategy made a practical difference?
9. What is one mistake or assumption you would advise another newcomer to avoid?
10. How would you define the edge you brought with you, and what did you have to change?

**Before using an interview:**

- Explain the purpose and how the interview may be used.
- Obtain explicit permission for quotations, editing, translation and publication.
- Offer anonymity or a pseudonym, and explain that details may still identify someone.
- Remove unnecessary details about immigration status, employment disputes, income, health or family.
- Let the participant review quotations and factual descriptions before publication.
- Do not reshape a story to fit the argument. Record complicated outcomes too.
- Keep notes securely and agree how long they will be kept.

# Appendix E: Sources and Resources

> *Check the facts, keep the date close to every number and confirm current rules before you act.*

## A note on the research

The statistics in this book describe particular Canadian study populations. They are not results about Brazilians specifically, and they should not be used to suggest that all immigrants, or all Brazilians, share the same experiences. Research gives context; it does not prove the story of any one person. Immigration, employment and credential rules change, so confirm current details on official websites before acting. This book is not legal or immigration advice.

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2030. https://www.weforum.org/publications/the-future-of-jobs-report-2025/in-full/3-skills-outlook/

**[9]** Andersen, Erika. "Learning to Learn." *Harvard Business Review*, 2016. Reprinted in *HBR's 10 Must Reads on Lifelong Learning* (Harvard Business Review Press, 2021). Quotes Arie de Geus on learning as a competitive advantage.

## Practical Canadian resources

- **Government of Canada Job Bank: "Find a job in Canada as a newcomer."** Job-search guidance, credential-recognition tools, language training information and newcomer services. https://www.jobbank.gc.ca/landing-newcomers-seekers.xhtml
- **Government of Canada: "Find free newcomer services near you."** Directory of settlement service providers; available services depend on eligibility and location. https://ircc.canada.ca/english/newcomers/services/
- **Your provincial or territorial apprenticeship authority,** for trade certification and the Red Seal exam.
- **Your provincial or territorial regulator.** For regulated occupations, the regulator's own website is the authoritative source for licensing requirements.
- **Professional associations in your field,** many of which offer newcomer, mentoring or bridging programs.

# Appendix F: Portuguese to English

> *Every expression in this book, with the English a Canadian would actually use.*

Each lesson ends its English practice with a Brazilian expression and its natural English equivalent. Use this list to review them. Notice how often the idea is the same and only the image changes.

## Expressions, lesson by lesson

| Lesson | Em português | In English |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | *Começar do zero* | to start from scratch |
| 2 | *Aprender nunca é demais* | Every day is a school day |
| 3 | *Vestir a camisa* | to be fully committed to the company; to give it your all |
| 4 | *Um bom começo é meio caminho andado* | Well begun is half done |
| 5 | *A união faz a força* | United we stand |
| 6 | *Correr atrás* | to go after it; to hustle |
| 7 | *Arregaçar as mangas* | to roll up your sleeves |
| 8 | *Trabalho honesto não envergonha ninguém* | There's no shame in honest work |
| 9 | *Fazer um balanço* | to take stock |
| 10 | *Sorte é quando a preparação encontra a oportunidade* | Luck is what happens when preparation meets opportunity |
| 11 | *Deus ajuda quem cedo madruga* | The early bird catches the worm |

| Lesson | Em português | In English |
|---|---|---|
| 12 | *A prática leva à perfeição* | Practice makes perfect |
| 13 | *Brasileiro não desiste nunca* | Never give up |
| 14 | *Segurar as pontas* | to hold the fort; to keep things together |
| 15 | *Manter a cabeça fria* | to keep a cool head |
| 16 | *Puxar conversa* | to strike up a conversation |
| 17 | *Dançar conforme a música* | to go with the flow |
| 18 | *Em time que está ganhando não se mexe* | If it ain't broke, don't fix it |
| 19 | *Dar nome aos bois* | to call a spade a spade |
| 20 | *Me deu um branco* | My mind went blank |
| 21 | *Pegar o bonde andando* | to come in halfway through |
| 22 | *Uma coisa de cada vez* | One step at a time |
| 23 | *Quem tem padrinho não morre pagão* | It's not what you know, it's who you know |
| 24 | *Dar um passo maior que a perna* | to bite off more than you can chew |
| 25 | *Longe dos olhos, perto do coração* | Absence makes the heart grow fonder |
| 26 | *Para quem não sabe aonde vai, qualquer caminho serve* | If you don't know where you're going, any road will take you there |
| 27 | *Caiu a ficha* | The penny dropped; it finally sank in |
| 28 | *Complexo de vira-lata* | an inferiority complex (no exact equivalent) |
| 29 | *Se subestimar* | to sell yourself short |
| 30 | *Tempestade em copo d'água* | a tempest in a teapot; making a mountain out of a molehill |
| 31 | *Nem tanto ao mar, nem tanto à terra* | Find the middle ground |
| 32 | *Quem tudo quer, tudo perde* | Try to do everything and you'll do nothing well |

| Lesson | Em português | In English |
|---|---|---|
| 33 | *A grama do vizinho é sempre mais verde* | The grass is always greener on the other side |
| 34 | *O hábito não faz o monge* | Clothes don't make the man; don't judge a book by its cover |
| 35 | *Contra fatos não há argumentos* | The facts speak for themselves |
| 36 | *Querer é poder* | Where there's a will, there's a way |
| 37 | *Devagar se vai ao longe* | Slow and steady wins the race |
| 38 | *Cada um no seu tempo* | Everyone moves at their own pace |
| 39 | *Quem não arrisca não petisca* | Nothing ventured, nothing gained |
| 40 | *Quem tem boca vai a Roma* | It never hurts to ask |
| 41 | *Água mole em pedra dura, tanto bate até que fura* | Constant dripping wears away the stone |
| 42 | *É errando que se aprende* | We learn from our mistakes |
| 43 | *Quem conta um conto aumenta um ponto* | A story grows every time it's told |
| 44 | *Ver para crer* | Seeing is believing |
| 45 | *Não há rosa sem espinhos* | Every rose has its thorn |
| 46 | *Mais vale qualidade do que quantidade* | Quality over quantity |
| 47 | *Em Roma, como os romanos* | When in Rome, do as the Romans do |
| 48 | *Gentileza gera gentileza* | Kindness breeds kindness; one good turn deserves another |
| 49 | *Quem não tem cão caça com gato* | You make do with what you've got |
| 50 | *Quem ensina aprende duas vezes* | To teach is to learn twice |
| 51 | *Cada um sabe onde o sapato aperta* | Only the wearer knows where the shoe pinches |

| Lesson | Em português | In English |
|---|---|---|
| 52 | *Ordem e Progresso* | Order and Progress |

## Words with no English equivalent

- ***Garra*** (Lesson 6): grit, fight and determination. Closest English: *grit*, *drive*.
- ***Saudade*** (Lesson 25): a loving longing for someone or something absent. Closest English: *missing someone*, *homesickness*.
- ***Complexo de vira-lata*** (Lesson 28): the habit of assuming that what comes from Brazil is second-rate. Closest English: *an inferiority complex*.

## Falsos amigos and common errors

Some English words look like Portuguese words but mean something different (*falsos amigos*). Other mistakes come from translating a Portuguese structure word for word (*cuidado*). Both cause common misunderstandings at work.

| English | Looks like | What to know |
|---|---|---|
| *college* | *colégio* | In Canada, a *college* is a post-secondary institution. A *colégio* is a school, often private, for primary or secondary students; in Canada, say *school* or *high school*. (Lesson 12) |
| *actually* | *atualmente* | *Actually* means *na verdade*. For *atualmente*, say *currently* or *at the moment*. (Lesson 20) |
| *I am graduated* | *sou formado* | Say *I have a degree in engineering* or *I graduated in engineering*, not *I am graduated in engineering*. (Lesson 22) |
| *résumé* | *resumo* | A *résumé* is your CV. A *resumo* is a *summary*. (Lesson 23) |
| *eventually* | *eventualmente* | *Eventually* means *no fim* or *mais cedo ou mais tarde*. For *eventualmente*, say *occasionally* or *possibly*. (Lesson 26) |
| *pretend* | *pretender* | |

| English | Looks like | What to know |
|---|---|---|
| | | *Pretend* means *fingir*. For *pretender*, say *intend to* or *plan to*: *I intend to work in finance*. (Lesson 33) |
| *I have 40 years* | *tenho 40 anos* | In English, age uses *be*: *I'm 40*. And for experience: *I have fifteen years of experience*. (Lesson 34) |
| *sensible* | *sensível* | *Sensible* means *sensato*. For *sensível*, say *sensitive*. (Lesson 40) |
| *depend of* | *depender de* | Three classic Portuguese-shaped errors: *depend on* (not *of*), *explain it to me* (not *explain me*) and *ask a question* (not *make a question*). (Lesson 41) |
| *assist / attend* | *assistir / atender* | *Assist* means *ajudar*; *assistir* a meeting is *attend*, and *assistir* TV is *watch*. *Atender* the phone is *answer*, and *atender* a client is *serve* or *help*. (Lesson 42) |
| *realize* | *realizar* | *Realize* means *perceber*. For *realizar*, say *carry out*, *achieve* or *complete*. (Lesson 47) |

# Appendix G: Quantify Your Impact

> *Until you measure your impact, you cannot see it clearly, and neither can anyone else.*

This worksheet turns your achievements into numbers you can use in interviews, on your résumé and on LinkedIn. It also does something quieter: it shows you, in black and white, the impact you have already had. Lessons 9, 29 and 43 explain the ideas behind it.

## Step 1: Find the numbers

Choose one achievement. For each kind of number, write anything you can honestly measure or estimate.

| Kind of number | My achievement in numbers |
|---|---|
| People: led, trained, served, affected | |
| Money: budget, savings, revenue, value protected | |
| Time: time saved, speed, deadlines, years | |
| Volume: projects, files, clients, transactions | |
| Change: before → after | |
| Frequency: daily, weekly, monthly | |
| Rank or scale: out of how many? | |

## Step 2: Apply the "so what?" test

What did the number mean for the company, the client or the team?

### Step 3: Write it as one sentence

Use this pattern: **action + number + "so what?"**

*"I redesigned the month-end process, which cut closing time from nine days to five, so managers received results a week earlier."*

Repeat for at least three achievements. Then use them in your success formula (Lesson 18), your evidence file (Lesson 35) and your stories (Lesson 43).

### Prompts if you are stuck

- How many people reported to you, directly or indirectly?
- How many new colleagues did you train or mentor?
- What was the largest budget, contract or account you were responsible for?
- What did you make faster, cheaper, safer or more accurate, and by how much?
- How many clients, patients, students or suppliers did you deal with in a typical month?
- What problem stopped happening after you fixed it?

- How many years did you do it, and how many promotions did you receive?
- Out of how many people were you chosen for a project, role or award?

## Honest numbers

- Estimate carefully and say so: *about*, *roughly*, *more than*.
- Be ready to explain how you calculated a number.
- If a figure is confidential, use a percentage or a range.
- Never invent or inflate. One true number is worth more than three impressive guesses.

## The language of numbers

| To say... | In English |
|---|---|
| it went up | *increased by 20%*; *grew from 40 to 65*; *doubled* |
| it went down | *reduced by a third*; *fell from 9 days to 5*; *cut in half* |
| an estimate | *about*, *roughly*, *approximately*, *more than*, *nearly* |
| scale | *a team of twelve*; *a budget of about CAD 2 million*; *one of 300 branches* |

**Watch out:** English uses a decimal point and a thousands comma, the opposite of Portuguese. *R$ 1.500,50* becomes *1,500.50*, and *2,5%* becomes *2.5%*. Convert reais to Canadian dollars at the current rate, or describe the scale in relative terms.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

# Ron Taylor

Ron Taylor is a Canadian communication consultant with three decades of experience teaching English through individual, personalized lessons. All of his teaching is online. Over the years he has taught students from around the world; today he works exclusively with Brazilian professionals who are preparing for Canada, settling in or building their careers there: engineers, auditors, lawyers, accountants, IT specialists, managers and their families.

His work goes beyond language. He helps professionals explain their experience with confidence, prepare for job interviews, understand Canadian workplace culture and make the move from a respected career in Brazil to a new one in Canada. Over the years, he has learned to watch his students' mindset as carefully as their grammar, because the moment a capable professional remembers what they bring is often the moment their English begins to accelerate. This book grew out of that observation.

### Executive Class

Ron is the founder of **Executive Class**, a private communication consulting practice for Brazilian professionals. Every course is taught online and one-on-one:

- **Testando as Águas.** A five-day intensive for people who are considering a move and want to experience Canadian life first.
- **The Onboarding Sprint.** For people preparing to move or newly arrived: daily life, work and interviews.

- **The University & College Prep Sprint.** Four weeks of preparation for study at a Canadian college or university.
- **The Interview Sprint.** Two weeks focused entirely on job interviews.
- **The First 90 Days.** Thirteen weekly lessons that rehearse the key moments of a probation period.
- **The Executive Class.** An advanced, ongoing program for professionals already living and working in Canada.

He also created the **Listening Lab**, a free method for learning to understand natural spoken English.

### The Executive Class Library

Ron is also the author of a library of free ebooks for Brazilian professionals in Canada, including *The Brazucan Pathway*, *The Canadian Networking Code*, *The First 90 Days*, *52 Hours to a Winning Interview*, *Why You? The Art of the Interview*, *Comece com Tudo*, *Evolving: Riding the AI Wave into the Singularity* and *Executive Class*, the core textbook of every course. The library also includes a series of reading courses for advanced learners of English, each built around fifty-two short cases.

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